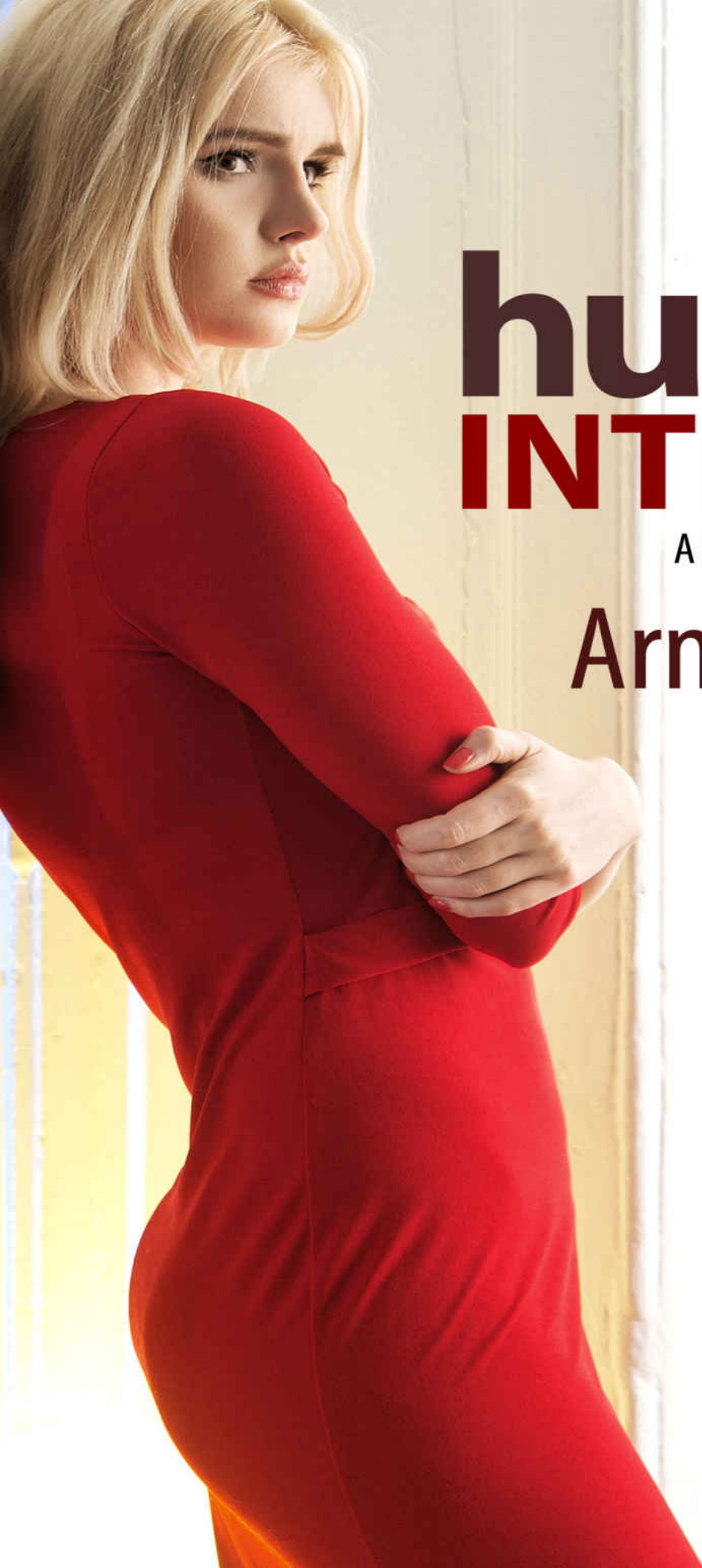




human INTEREST

A LEAD-IN TO WIFE SHARING

Arnica Butler

HUMAN INTEREST

A Lead-In to Wife Watching

By Arnica Butler

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TABLE OF CONTENTS

1: Fans

2: Squirrel Attack

3: Jungle Fever

4: Confrontation

5: Dream

6: Daydream

7: Protest

8: Invite

9: Dinner

10: Tour

11: Dessert

12: Breaking News

13: Swingers

14: The Conversation?

15: The Auction

16: Proposal

17: A Long Lunch

18: I Did It

19: Aftermath

20: The Video

21: Reckless

22: Poorly Planned

23: Out Of Control

24: Way Out

PROLOGUE

So...I want to assure my faithful readers that I am not caught up in making two-part books (although I recognize that it may appear that way, as my last book was a two-parter and this one will be as well.) I certainly never intended to leave anyone with a semi-cliffhanger. It's definitely not "my thing."

Here's what happened: my character, Josh, got an idea about three-quarters of the way through this book, and then so did I. (It's fun, you'll be happy we came up with it.) The story, consequently, got much longer.

I decided to break the book into two parts, in order to get something out for you all to read, while I finish the rest of it. As such, I've subtitled the book "A Lead-In to Wife-Watching." I don't feel the pun needs much explanation for my readers; you're all savvy folks. But you get the idea: there's something "meatier" to come...

As always, I hope you enjoy reading my fantasies as much as I enjoy writing them. Enjoy!

Arnica

1: FANS

The girl on the screen scrunched up her nose.

Her nose was one of those with an almost convex slope. It turned up slightly at the end.

As he watched the video, Josh couldn't help but think how noses are funny things. They weren't, decidedly, a sexy feature, but noses were powerful. They could turn a very pretty face into a horrid one. Or, as in the case of this girl, turn an otherwise sexy face into an adorable one.

She had stunning eyes, this girl. Rich, chocolate eyes, completely solid in color. They would have been dubbed sexy, had they been peeking out over a scarf, for example. But hovering over her constantly wrinkling, adorable nose, they fell under the category "cute," along with the rest of her face. Her lips, for example, were full and sensual, equally beautiful forming a smile or a pout. They suffered, though, from the same problem of proximity to her curved and juvenile nose, and acquired a lacquer of cuteness.

Watching the video, Josh thought this may have been the root of all her problems: her nose.

The girl on the screen unwrinkled her nose, and now her mouth was in a pretty smile. She was turning, and her slender shoulders moved as she extended her hand tentatively to her left.

Then suddenly she was bouncing. Her mouth opened wide, and she laughed.

She began jumping. A little shadow of fear appeared in her eyes as the black of her pupils consumed the brown of her irises. She bit her lip.

No, Josh thought. No, it's not just the nose. It's...everything. Everything about Rachel is causing her problems.

The video was slowed for Rachel Elliot's scrunching nose, and then played at real-speed for Rachel Elliot's cute little shriek.

And here it came: she was waving her hands, also adorably, at the camera.

"Cut, cut, cut. We have to do that again."

A voice mumbled something unintelligible.

Then Rachel again:

"I know. His tongue is just so...*sandy*. Agh! He thinks I'm ice cream!"

The snake she had reached over to touch had surprised her by extending its tongue out unexpectedly. Now it was, indeed, pursuing Rachel as though she were ice cream, its long tongue seeking her skin.

Her creamy, smooth skin, which happened to be very much like French vanilla ice cream.

Josh tried not to smile. Her voice was a sweet contralto, a little nasal, a very unique voice. There was something about it, though, that made it impossible to take it – her voice – as seriously as she wanted it taken. It seemed that she was forever on the verge of giggling.

Next to Josh, in real life, the real Rachel Elliot had her arms crossed defensively and her foot was tapping out her anger in the air. Josh knew she was staring at him, and that he should frown and shake his head and say the appropriate thing.

Whatever that was.

“Read the comments,” she snapped.

She snapped but she was cute even when she snapped, like a tiny snapping turtle at a petting zoo.

Even the heat she was giving off in anger had a slightly comedic quality to it.

As her husband, Josh knew that she hated this about herself: this propensity for cuteness that was so outside of her control. He knew his wife didn't want to be cute, so while he was very uncertain what he *should* say, he at least knew what he *shouldn't*.

He leaned toward the computer screen and squinted, though he didn't need to do either of these things to see perfectly. Reading the comments bought him some time, though, and he wanted to make sure she knew he was reading them.

Intently.

He scanned the comments:

xxxdoug: I love Rachel Elliots ice cream

jquaid13: stop the madness ths girl is 2 cute

Hollah: why is this even news

plummer: Rachel Elliot is hot

xxxdoug: schoolgirl hot

shaft69: I have a snake I need Rachel Elliot to cover

xxxdoug: she can touch my snake any day lol

magikmixx: rachel come over and get my snake
bbrown: Ill lick her ice cream any time

“I mean,” Josh said, clearing his throat. “It's not...terrible.” He pointed a finger at a comment which read: *I am completely up-to-date on current events.*

Rachel's eyes went black with rage as she scanned the comment.

“You're getting people interested in the news,” Josh said, using an optimistic tone. As soon as the words left his mouth he was sorry. They had a dusting of sarcasm on them.

Rachel slapped his finger away from the screen. “You!” she shrieked. “This is not *news*, first of all, it's a dog-and-pony show-”

“Well, snake-and-reporter show.” Josh tried to smile sympathetically. He then changed his face to show remorse for his last comment.

He didn't want to be a dick. It just sometimes came out.
Unauthorized.

Most people on the Rachel Elliot Fan Club page, or the dedicated tweeters of #RachelElliotBeHot and #HotRachel, would be surprised to know that Rachel Elliot actually be a real (albeit cute) bitch when she was mad.

“You are such an asshole.”

Rachel Elliot also cussed, which would probably surprise those same fans.

“I'm sorry,” Josh said, reaching for her hands. She slapped them away, with her teeth gritted together. Her face was flushed.

“I'm trying to have a serious conversation with you about my career,” she began. “And you are cracking bloody jokes. It's not funny! I don't want to be some daft blond reporter they put on the five o'clock for duck-in-the-road stories and every time-” she paused to grit her teeth even more furiously and slap at Josh's hands again, “*every time* these stupid leaks get out and everyone is like, 'oh, Rachel, I'll put some ice cream on my snake,' I get taken less seriously...”

Josh tuned out for a moment and looked sideways at the screen, trying to find out if “*oh Rachel, I'll put some ice cream on my snake,*” was an actual comment.

“Agh!” Rachel kicked the foot of his chair. “You are such an ass!”

“Okay,” Josh said, reaching out to contain her fluttering hands. He pressed them together, and the energy traveled to her torso, where it turned into hyperventilation.

His wife had not helped her cause by changing into a pink shirt with a bear on it to work out in. The shirt stretched nicely across her small but shapely breasts. Her blonde hair was twisted into two braids.

Josh fought against his smile.

“Look, I’m sorry, I know. It’s not what you want. Did you talk to Arthur about it?” He offered.

“Ugh!” Rachel growled. She tipped her head at the ceiling and began to bounce her legs with her unconstrained anger. “*He’s* likely the one who put the bloody thing on there!”

Rachel Elliot, fans would *also* be surprised to know, was also Australian. She had perfected her American accent for the cameras, and she kept it up at work most of the day. But when provoked, she usually reverted to what was, unfortunately for her, an even *more adorable* version of her voice.

“Who else has access to footage?” Josh could focus, at least, on trying to get to the bottom of a mystery.

Rachel rolled her eyes. “Everyone. Everyone. Everyone!” She threw her hands up in the air.

“It’s at least not embarrassing,” Josh said, trying to be helpful. “At least you’re not Kelly Harding from Channel 4.”

Poor Kelly Harding. Always falling down on camera. The internet loved Kelly’s misfortunes.

And the internet – maybe not the vast, far reaches of the internet, but at least a small slice of it – loved Josh’s wife.

Unfortunately, the internet loved his wife for a reasons she found insulting.

Rachel wanted to be a serious reporter. She wanted to do serious journalism and serious interviews. She did not want to be known as #RachelElliotBeHot, or have internet fanclubs, or appear on click-bait lists like “The Seven Most Adorable News Reporters In America.”

Or sometimes much lewder titles.

“The media,” Rachel growled, “has reached an all-time low.” She shook her head and bit her lip. “Maybe I need to get out altogether. Or go to radio.”

“There are no more jobs in radio,” Josh said quickly. Then he cooed: “Besides, you don't have a face for radio.”

Rachel held up her finger. “I have the brains for it, though.”

Josh could feel two things battling inside of him. One was a desire not to be an asshole, which he supposed most men his age had learned to listen to by now. He had a great wife – a beautiful, smart, funny, thoughtful wife. He had a good thing. He knew he should say something supportive at this moment, talk about how she *should* go to radio, dammit! Take her brains and her real journalism to a place like NPR where she would be appreciated!

Josh also felt the call of “something else.” The desire to make a joke that he knew would annoy his wife. To put his hands on her hips, and say something sexual, and walk her backward into the bedroom on the off-chance that his annoying her worked some kind of magic, and convinced her to have sex with him.

Josh was no fool: he knew, as he was sure all men his age knew by now, that his second instinct stood a snowball's chance in hell of working, or doing anything besides igniting a huge fight.

He knew that.

He tried to have a talk with his arms, and his mouth. Tried to will them to say something he knew Rachel wanted to hear, and stay away from her delectable hips.

But down lower in his body, his cock was robbing him of his will to behave rationally.

He put his hands on Rachel's hips. Her frame was small, and beneath clothing she could appear stick-like. Under the clothes, though, she was drastically curved, incredibly feminine. Josh's cock twitched just imagining what he was feeling with his fingertips: the sinuous dip from her pelvic bone to her supple stomach; the concavity of her waist and the sudden swell of her hip. Her navel, and the small brown mole where her torso began to turn to lean thigh, in a secret place, a place where no one but him knew what was there.

Well...*and* her ex-lovers, of course. They knew.

The thought burned through him, and it didn't help to cool him off.

“Honey, you're too smart and too good to have to put up with this for much longer,” he said. He meant that, he really did. Even if it wasn't foremost in his mind, he meant it.

“Dammit.”

Josh's blood was pumping, his cock was getting hard, and his fingers were almost beneath her panties. It took him a moment to figure out where the epithet was directed.

Rachel held up her phone, which had rumbled next to her on the table. Her eyes moved swiftly over the screen.

“I have to go.”

Josh pulled her close. Her breasts, surprisingly full given her small frame, were warm and soft against his chest.

“Quit,” he breathed into her neck.

He half-meant it. He could feel desire clawing away inside of him, and now that he had her close to him, he could think of nothing else.

Rachel squirmed in his arms. Her legs brushed against his erection, and her breasts jiggled against his chest. He squeezed her tighter. “Don't go. That job is demeaning. Stay here with me.”

Josh felt a tinge of regret whenever he acted like this. He also just actually couldn't stop himself.

He also knew that he had crossed the line, from supportive husband to lecherous pig, and his wife knew it, and she was going to get annoyed with him.

Which he sort of enjoyed.

Rachel squirmed more and slapped his hands away when she finally escaped. “God, *fuck off* Josh.”

“I was just joking!” he called to her retreating form.

She gave him the finger and slammed the hall bathroom door closed.

It was a friendly fight. Friendly annoyance, friendly groping. Josh smiled.

He sat back down at the computer.

He scrolled the comments.

I'd lick her ice cream any time.

A very guilty, very delightful shiver of arousal passed through him.

Why? Why did he like this so much?

I have a snake I need Rachel to cover.

So crass, he thought loudly, as if someone could hear his thoughts and he would get points for being sensitive. Women really had to put up with a lot of shit.

He tried to will himself to think about that. To think about empathizing with his wife, how frustrated she must feel, not being taken seriously. It *was* bullshit. Total bullshit. And he really believed that.

But try as he might, he couldn't keep the image out of his head, of a man licking his wife like she was an ice cream. Another man's tongue sliding along her wet, creamy skin from the back of her knee to her ribcage, while she giggled, the same way she had for the snake.

It was that image which led him down the hallway and into the bathroom.

Rachel was taking a shower.

The bathroom was already full of steam when he opened the door.

If there was one thing Rachel loved, it was taking an almost excruciatingly hot shower.

"Don't complain," Rachel laughed, "about the steam. And don't come in here trying to be sexy. I really have to get going."

But her voice was laughing.

He had a chance.

He watched her form through the frosted glass of the standup shower, silently wishing once again they had opted for clear. She made a beautiful silhouette. Her breasts were large and turned up slightly, from the side they made a teardrop shape.

Josh was anxious to feel the weight of her breasts in his hands. They would be slippery with soap, and hot to the touch. His palms itched and his cock jerked to fullness. He took off his shirt and shimmied out of his sweatpants.

He opened the door.

Rachel glared at him. Streaks of soap slid down her chest and snaked over her nipples. "I can't get my hair wet," she said.

Josh said nothing. He imagined Rachel delivering one of her human interest stories with her hair braided into the two girlish tails she was now wearing. Then he imagined the internet eating it up. All the men who would sit at home in the dark, only the glow of the computer screen on their faces, his wife's image filling the screen. Men who would probably jerk off at their desks. Married men, single men, maybe even some women...all of them craving his wife.

His cock flexed. He stepped into the shower.

Jesus, it was hot.

Rachel giggled, and reached down to grab the elastic of his boxers, which he had neglected to remove. She snapped the band, and a spray of superheated water slapped his skin and his balls. It was painful, but the pain only served to heat him up more. He left them on. He had other plans.

The shower – an add-on to the cramped bathroom in the Victorian they were remodeling – was barely big enough for the two of them. Josh reached behind her and turned the heat down a little. As he did, he distracted her by sliding his fingers between her legs, where her slit was damp with only water, squeaky to the touch.

He would have his work cut out for him.

“Josh,” she whispered, but he could tell she was, perhaps, going to give in.

He pushed her against the wall of the shower, and she rippled with a wince at the cold of the tiles behind her, which had somehow escaped the superheated water.

Her flesh was tight against his fingers, and he spread them apart to open her legs a little. He was pleased when she gave in to the motion, and her feet slid apart on the floor of the shower. The silken insides of her outer lips were clean and his fingers moved against them like rubber – for now. He found the teardrop of her clit and gently pulled on it to expose her most sensitive skin, which he pressed gently.

For a moment Rachel seemed to waver. He could see that the temperature of the water had begun to annoy her, and her hair was getting damp pressed up against the wall. He moved his finger in a slow circle over her clit, and lowered his head to take the soft nipple of one of her breasts in his mouth.

His tongue swirled over the center of her areola, and he felt her nipple pebble in his mouth. Between her legs, her own juices smeared the insides of her outer lips, and they turned from rubbery to silky smooth underneath the pads of his fingers.

Rachel let out a small gasp.

It was time to move down her body.

With a deftness that impressed even himself, Josh turned off the water as he moved down to a kneel on the floor of the shower. He peppered her body with kisses on the way down, following the rivulets of water that trickled down her flesh. He placed a hand on her small thigh, and lifted her leg a little.

Rachel's cunt was surrounded by a tiny patch of downy blonde hair, which she barely had to trim because it was so feathery and fine. In the water, it was nearly invisible, and because she had cooked her skin to a bright red with her hot water, it looked as though her snatch was shaved.

Josh ran his tongue along the outermost edge of her outer labia, barely touching her. He felt a ripple of pleasure in her body, and so he did it again on the other lip. He repeated this tease, admiring the streams of shower water that dripped from her navel into her engorged red flesh, mixing with her own nectar. Drops of water clung to her clit, tempting him to suck them away.

But not yet.

He slid his tongue into the now-silky fold between her outer labia and her clit, and lapped at the honey he had drawn into the fold with his finger. He avoided her clit, saving the best for last. He made a slow circle around the semi-hard edges of her inner labia, and he felt her pushing against his hands to get his tongue inside of her.

But he resisted.

Slowly, savoring the quick breathing that was quaking in her abdomen, he traced his tongue up to her clit. He licked the outside, and he felt her thigh and abdomen harden with desire. Then he pulled with his thumb on the small hood that covered her bundle of raw nerves in the center, and flicked his tongue at the center.

He looked up at her. She had forgotten about her hair, and now had her head pressed against the wall. She looked down at him and watched as he flicked his tongue at her clit, never giving her what he knew she wanted: the slow and deliberate pressure that would bring her to release.

She placed a hand on his head. "Oh god, Josh...please..."

Her stomach was moving in waves, and her foot slid on the floor. He pressed upward with his right hand – never mind the searing pain of holding up her weight – and held her steady with his other hand, sliding his thumb into her soaked hole.

Then, and only then, did he allow her to sink the weight of her pussy into his mouth. She pushed herself against him so that her clit was absorbed by the heat of his mouth, and he obliged her by sucking it and rubbing it with his tongue. He teased her until she was breathing in an almost panicked way, and twisting in his hands, before he began to lap at her clit in steady waves.

She closed her eyes and pressed her head against the wall as she came closer to coming, and he looked up to watch as her body shook with her orgasm. Her lips parted and she gave a high-pitched gasp, and then a moan. Her juices welled up and covered his mouth. He let the hot liquid of her pussy fill his mouth, tangy and sweet.

He dropped her leg and rose up to her. She was panting against the wall.

He kissed her, and then he smiled. She wiped a strand of wet hair away from her face.

They both knew, from past experience: there was no such thing as stand-up, penetration-sex in the shower.

“Don't worry,” Josh said. “I know you have to go. You can get me back later.”

He wanted her to turn down this offer, and invite him for a quick romp in the bed.

Rachel looked confused for a moment, then wiped her face again.

Then a cloud of worry came over her face. “Shit. Shit, shit! I'm so late!”

Josh reached behind her and turned on the shower, and then he stepped out.

His boxers were soaked, and hard to peel off his aching cock. Rachel was frantic as she showered, got dressed, and kissed him goodbye. He waited for her to leave, sitting on the toilet seat, wrapped from the waist down in a towel.

And then he went into the shower, and pressed one hand against the wall while he stroked his cock to get some relief.

What he thought about, though, was not the scene that he had just played out in the shower, as delightful as it was.

He tried to think about the shower, and real events in his real life, but his mind kept wandering to something else. A different image. An image of Rachel in the shower, holding onto one man's thick, snake-like cock, while another man licked her from head to toe like an ice cream cone. And Rachel herself gasped and moaned, the same way she had in the shower, but not because her husband was making her come.

No, instead she was gasping because another man was slamming his enormous cock into her, from behind.

Josh gave a light yell as he came.

The fantasy seemed suddenly ridiculous (how would three people even fit in the shower?). He stood directly beneath the shower stream.
As if maybe it would wash the thoughts from his head.

2: SQUIRREL ATTACK

“What did it say?”

Rachel looked at Xavier, leaning her head on her hand so that she could bite on her pinky fingernail. A bad habit, one she had never been able to shake. She did it when she was annoyed.

She could tell Xavier was amused by her internet “problems,” but it was a different kind of amusement than she felt from Josh. Josh seemed to be amused at her expense, and Xavier somehow managed to convey friendly complicity in his amusement. Without saying as much.

This disparity kicked up a storm of fury in Rachel's chest. Why couldn't her husband just be more sympathetic, like Xavier, instead of trying to get in her pants?

The memory of the shower came back to her, though, and she softened. That *had* been fun. Josh had been experiencing some kind of renewed libido lately, and while she had a vague worry that it was somehow related to her internet escapades, she also wasn't complaining.

She looked out the window.

The fury died down and she felt a familiar rush of attraction spread through her chest. It ended, as it always did, pooling deep in her abdomen.

And deeper still.

She shifted in her seat.

The problem was, the feeling *began* with Josh, but ended with the man sitting next to her.

“Well? Not *that* bad, I hope?” Xavier continued. He jerked the jeep too late to avoid a pothole and Rachel's arm jumped from where she was resting it against the window. Loose papers slid from the dash and scattered around the car. Rachel half-heartedly scooped them together.

“Damn, sorry. You okay?” Xavier said. But he kept right on talking. “Don't listen to any of that dumb-ass shit on the internet. Just keep playin' it cool and you'll get where you want to be.”

His voice was low, almost too low to hear. Smooth like a caress. Exactly the kind of voice that a man like Xavier would have. Dark. Strong.

Stop it, Rachel.

Rachel tried to keep her eyes glued to the window, and the scenes outside the vehicle. If she kept her eyes on the outside of the car, she wouldn't let her eyes wander to places *inside* the car. Places where her eyes shouldn't wander.

It had already happened, earlier. She had found her eyes drifting, on more than one occasion, almost as if they were not her own eyes and she didn't control them. Drifting over the jeans that Xavier wore, and the way the material folded right where his cock was nestled -

Stop it, Rachel.

She concentrated on what she was seeing out the window. They were in a bad part of town now. Not bad-bad: this wasn't really that kind of city. She remembered the advice given to her, at unrelated times and for unrelated incidents, by both a cop and a real estate agent: the cars tell you what kind of neighborhood you're really in. On their way out of the downtown core, the cars had moved from parking structures to streets, the hallmark of creative-class, loft-dwelling millennials. The cars migrated back onto driveways for the blue-collar neighborhoods. They multiplied in number and grew dents and rusted bellies: lower-rung blue collar. Cars became more than five years old: creditless blue collar.

When they began to disintegrate on the front lawns, the advice was unanimous: watch your shit.

But they were not here to cover anything of importance that happened in this neighborhood of decaying cars.

They were here to cover a “gang of squirrels,” who were making it hard for kids to walk to school and reportedly threw objects at people.

“Is this where *you* want to be?” she said, without even really thinking about the question before it came out of her mouth.

She already knew the answer, anyway. Xavier was one of those guys who seemed only to do whatever the hell he wanted, nothing more and nothing less.

Thinking about something like that almost inevitably led her to think about other things. Bam, bam, bam, in a chain: her mind was right back on his cock, and whether the stereotypes about black men were true. If she reached over and felt the shape of him in her hand, would she be surprised by the size of it?

“Jesus,” she muttered, cutting off her own thoughts. Xavier threw her a look but ignored her. She hoped he assumed this was uttered as part of her

melancholy.

"I like where I am," Xavier declared, answering her question about a minute later. He often did this, thinking long and hard about something she asked him.

He was always so damn spiritual and upbeat. He really meant something like that when he said it. "Thing you gotta do, Ray, is stop *giving a shit*."

Rachel sighed. Partly a sigh of annoyance with herself. Partly a sigh for the way he said her name. She liked that he gave her a nickname. Another palpitation rattled in her chest.

"Okay, okay. Tell me what they said," Xavier prodded.

She looked out the window again, and gave a small shake of her head. She found, though, that she was smiling in spite of herself. For some reason she kind of *wanted* to tell him.

"Rachel Elliot has sweet headlights," he offered.

She tried not to smile bigger.

"Rachel Elliot is one fine-ass bitch." He swooped into an exaggerated black dialect, which he ordinarily had no traces of at all. "Whoo-hee, Rachel Elliot has them thick thighs and I'd eat them up like a bucketful of chicken!"

Rachel tried to keep from laughing but ended up snorting into her hand and messing up her make-up.

"All right, all right, I admit it: that was me posting. The chicken one." He looked over and leaned a little toward her. He lowered his voice to a gravelly rumble. "You *know* I love me some fried chicken."

"Stop it."

He smiled and gave it a moment. "Tell me."

Rachel snapped the mirror down to check her makeup. Her face, in spite of her bad mood, pleased her when she saw it. She was quite pretty. She liked her dark eyes and her light hair. A natural, if uncommon, combination. She had always secretly liked when her lovers found the same white-blonde hair they had believed to be dyed further down her body, covering her snatch, silky and downy-thin.

She wrinkled her nose. She took a breath, and then she dove in:

"Rachel Elliot can lick my ice cream, Rachel Elliot can come see my snake," she recited. A small hot patch of anger formed on her cheekbone.

She could see Xavier's mouth open wide next to her, his perfectly white teeth showing. "Lick my ice cream? Pet my snake?" He shook his head. "That was definitely white people. Damn. That's some stupid shit."

Rachel couldn't help but smile. Xavier always managed to make her feel better. She tamped down on the rising feelings inside of her.

Why wasn't Josh any better at consoling her?

That isn't fair, Rachel, she told herself.

"Maybe it was, 'I'd lick her ice cream,'" she said, dotting some lip gloss on her lips and trying to distract herself from her own thoughts..

"Oh that...that's some black folk right there. That's clever. See, that makes sense. Because of your pointy feet, and how your hair is all white so it kinda looks like you're bald. You know?"

Rachel laughed in spite of herself.

"Okay. Cut out the Will Smith act."

"What do you *have* against that man?"

Rachel shook her head, smiling, and started looking over her notes. It was an old joke between them.

"Everybody likes Will Smith," he went on.

Rachel looked up. They were almost there. "Okay so...171 Montenegro Avenue, you got this?" Xavier was a die-hard non-user of GPS, so it was turned off and they were relying, as they always did, on old-fashioned maps.

Xavier opened his mouth to make a joke, and then thought better of it and laughed instead. He shook his head. "Pet my snake, huh?"

Rachel groaned.

As if he were going to a friend's house and drove there all the time, Xavier slowed halfway down the block and parked the car in front of a ramshackle bungalow with a 17 dangling from the chipped brick on the front porch. He put the van in park and turned it off.

"Look," he said, and Rachel felt something twist inside of her as his voice changed to a more serious tone. She closed her eyes briefly to remind herself of her husband. She found her wedding band with the tip of her thumb and gave it a twist.

"You gotta just blow all that shit off, for real. It sucks, but it isn't like you're the first pretty girl on the news everybody's been getting...more than the news out of."

There was something about Xavier's pragmatism and sensitivity, balanced very carefully, that Rachel really liked. She felt a pang, both of longing and guilt, as she compared Xavier to her husband again. She wished Josh had this...undefinable charisma.

Maybe because Xavier wasn't trying to get in her pants.

The thought disappointed her a little.

Or maybe he *was*, and this was all part of the ploy.

She flushed a little.

She looked over at him. He was unwrapping a piece of gum.

He held it out to her. Always the same joke, offering her a stick of gum right before she went on camera. She shook her head.

He popped it in his mouth. Rachel let her eyes linger on his lips. Dark, big, very soft and yet with a certain kind of hardness in them. His neatly trimmed beard, that would be rough like sandpaper against her inner thigh while he -

She cut herself off again, opened the door, and hopped out.

The neighborhood was Hispanic, so neither one of them fit in very well. Cold glares began to gravitate toward them from the porches where quite a few people were sitting.

"You got my back right?" Xavier joked, as he came around the front of the car.

He was at least six and a half feet tall, and his physique was lean but imposing. Underneath his plain shirts and jeans, an athlete's build rippled. Rachel definitely felt better having Xavier as a cameraman in a neighborhood like this one, than say, Harry, who was a full foot shorter, one hundred pounds lighter, and more nervous than a lab rat.

Xavier leaned on the hood of the van and turned his head around a full 180 degrees. He seemed to be broadcasting a message. Sort of a "don't-fuck-with-me" glower.

Rachel turned away and closed her eyes. She knew she shouldn't be feeling...what was she feeling? Hotted up? She shouldn't be feeling hotted up by such an apelike display of macho behavior.

But low in her torso, something was stirred up by it.

"Okay," she said. "Let's talk squirrels."

Xavier's message to the neighborhood was complete. When his gaze fell on Rachel it transformed completely, softening back to his natural, friendly demeanor.

He shook his head. "This is gonna be a good one. I can feel it." He winked.

Rachel savored the half-second that Xavier's eyes walked down her body. She knew he wasn't doing anything unusually lewd.

He was married, she reminded herself.

And his wife was, apparently, gorgeous.

And I am married, she emphasized, with another current of guilt in her veins for thinking of that second, rather than first. *And I love my husband*.

But these gentle reminders to herself didn't stop her heart from beating faster, or her skin from tingling.

His eyes stopped on her shoes. "Ell-i-ot," he said, in a sing-song voice. "That is more *like it*. Gonna have an easy day today. Helpin' an old man *out*."

Because Xavier was so tall, she had chosen her highest heels. That way, he didn't have to crouch the whole time he was filming her.

Or not as much, anyway.

Rachel wrinkled her nose. She wasn't even aware that she did this, most of the time. Or aware that it had the unfortunate effect of exacerbating her cuteness. It was an admonition for herself, and a way to cover the wave of embarrassment that was passing through her at that moment, for thinking the thoughts she was thinking.

Right on the heels of the unmistakeable pleasure it gave her to see Xavier's eyes linger on her shapely feet.

There was also the fact that she hadn't minded having an excuse to wear such high heels, because she knew they gave her legs definition and shape that no man could resist.

But Xavier was a professional.

And I am married. We are all married here, Rachel reminded herself.

She gave her head a quick snap, to flip her bangs into place. "Let's do this thing."

3: JUNGLE FEVER

It was 11:00 am on a Thursday, and Josh was staring into his computer screen and trying concentrate on a recommendations report for the containment of measles in three school districts with dangerously low vaccination rates. He was trying to stay off the internet.

Trying to stay off Rachel Elliot's fanclub pages and Twitter accounts. Trying not to scour the trashy news sites for click-bait with Rachel in it.

It was a secret he felt guilty for, but Josh visited the websites and fanclubs dedicated to his wife. Constantly. He spent far too much time at work, in his cubicle, checking Twitter for new tweets, her fanclub pages for new posts, and reading and re-reading trashy “articles” about her. Looking at her pictures.

Re-reading the most lewd comments, over and over.

The feelings that churned inside of him while he did this were complicated. It was painful, on the one hand, and infuriating.

But underneath that reaction, the one he knew it was most normal to have, he also felt a sliver of arousal. His stomach had the feeling of twisting metal that he had gotten whenever he had a crush on a girl. The same liquid ache that he had felt when he first met Rachel. And the feeling drained downward and into his balls. Most days his cock was hard, pressing out against his suit pants, and he had to sit, sweating, and distract himself from his thoughts about his wife in order to be able to leave his workspace.

In the beginning, when Rachel first started getting reporting assignments, he had simply enjoyed the sight of her on TV. Something about the fact that other men were watching his wife and seeing her doll-like beauty turned him on. A feeling like that he could explain to himself. He was just proud of his wife. Proud that such a lovely girl had married him.

It didn't seem strange to him to be turned on by his wife.

Josh had discovered her first fanclub long before she had. Why had he found it? He could barely remember. Maybe he had googled her. And there it was. The Rachel Elliot Fan Club.

The first fanclub had seemed harmless enough. A bunch of young guys, judging by the posts. It was all very immature, mostly harmless, and a small group. It seemed like the sort of thing that couldn't go anywhere. This was a mid-sized Midwestern city, and Rachel Elliot covered the news. Not just the news, but the silliest news.

But it had grown, this silly fanclub. And offshoots of her fanclub. Mock Twitter and Instagram accounts that photoshopped Rachel's face onto naked women.

Josh shuddered thinking of those, and wondered if Rachel even knew about them. She couldn't. She would have had a fit.

It then became apparent that more than just men liked Rachel: she appealed to everyone. She had the special mix of “cute” and “sexy” that made her a favorite with all kinds of people. And her boss, Josh knew, was playing her appeal up by manufacturing stories about her, and making sure every “cute” thing she did made it onto some kind of social media outlet.

It really was quite a phenomenon. And the more it grew, the more it enticed Josh.

When Rachel tried to quit KRTV, a year ago, because she felt her career wasn't going in the right direction, her boss had given her a raise to make her stay. An instantaneous, enormous raise. And there was no doubt in Josh's mind it was because of Rachel Elliot's fanclubs and nasty Instagram accounts, and the fact that everyone – or at least internet boys - seemed to prefer KRTV's local news because the local interest stories were delivered by the lovely Rachel Elliot.

Josh knew Rachel felt like a sell-out for taking the raise. They didn't even need her income, so she could have just quit. But she had also bargained that if she went to another news channel in town, they'd have her doing the same thing she was already doing. So she had taken the money, and continued to be cute, while she planned her escape or hoped to be promoted to “real” journalism.

And Josh knew that he should not be looking at Rachel's fanclub photos, and the clips of outtakes that were somehow leaking to the media, and the gossip that went on around her. He knew he shouldn't be staring at Twitter and Instagram with a hard cock in the middle of his workday. He knew that. He knew he shouldn't be turned on by the fact that so many other men found his wife “adorable” or compared her to ice cream, or wanted her to come over and pet their snakes or do an in-depth “interview” with them.

He knew he shouldn't be fantasizing about men in the city staging news stories in the hopes of getting Rachel Elliot to come to their house and get up close and personal.

He didn't *like* this.

He shifted uncomfortably in his seat and stared into the table he was creating for his report.

It wasn't long before the thoughts came back, nagging him. His fingers were itching with a desire to reach for his mouse...all of this was just a click away.

He felt himself getting turned on. It had been like this lately. Increasingly distracting. He was getting almost obsessive. Ninety percent of the time, there was nothing new to look at, and he just lost himself in old posts and old comments and wasted his time.

He made it until 11:30, and managed to type out a few paragraphs in his report.

His heart skipped as he opened the fanpage. A familiar skip. There were new posts. New comments.

A new video.

And under the video, glaring at him, the caption: *Jungle Fever*???

The words sent a sensation through Josh that he couldn't quite understand. Did it make him ill, or did it turn him on?

"Jungle Fever" could mean anything. She was probably at the zoo.

Josh's chest felt tight, because he knew how very unlikely it was that this particularly crass fanpage had made such a G-rated play on words.

He was...

Excited.

The frozen frame of the video looked action-packed. Rachel's hair was in a blur, and not much else could be seen.

The date beneath the video indicated it was footage from several days ago.

His hand was on the mouse, ready to click, but something inside of him wanted to drag this moment out. His stomach was cold, and his heart was knocking at his chest.

Josh thought back on Tuesday. There was nothing memorable about it. What had they even done that evening? Watched TV? Rachel hadn't seemed particularly upset, or told him about anything unusual happening at

work. What had she said she had covered? He searched his memory, which was far from impeccable. Something about wild animals.

He scanned the comments. He always liked the comments best, anyway.

As he read, his brow descended over his eyes and he moved his head back and forth in the confusion of a dumb animal. These comments went straight to filthy, and they went there fast.

xxxdoug: Jungle fever in the air?

anonymousse: my life just got so much better

SteveO: looks like someones getting a big surprise

plummmmer: bbc anyone

jquaid13: am i the only one who wants to see her mouth on this guys cock?

xxxdoug: I'd watch her take that cock any day

anonymousse: i bet she has a tight hole

buckeroo: he can help her with that

SteveO: ill help her with that i have a big black one

Josh blinked. Beads of sweat were forming on his brow, and for some reason he became acutely aware of them. Beading up, turning to droplets, and sliding down to his eyebrows. His cock was hard, and he could feel that, too, it was throbbing against the zipper of his pants and tiny stabs of sharp pain were being reported back to him. His stomach had gone cold. He was paralyzed. But for some reason the sweat on his brow stood out from all these things.

He could hear his own breath. His own breath under the buzz of the lights, suddenly the only two sounds in the world.

her mouth on this guy's cock...her mouth on this guy's cock...

The words kept repeating in his head.

And then he started to imagine scenarios. Scenarios as dirty as the comments below the video.

Rachel, her lips wrapped around the meat of another man's cock, looking at him and somehow smiling at the same time. A cock so big she had trouble fitting it all in her mouth.

How much time passed while he was thinking about that? A minute? Ten? By the time he actually clicked on the video, he was half-expecting to

see what he had been permitting himself to imagine: Rachel with her mouth full of another man's meat.

The video began in mid-sentence. Rachel holding her microphone, a light breeze ruffling her pretty hair. She was wearing a dark purple shirt, one that clung to her figure and dipped low – respectably, semi-conservatively, evening-news low – but low enough to allow for a glimpse of the beginning of the crevice between her breasts. Her lips were dark in this clip, and her cheeks had a sweet flush to them, as though it were maybe unusually cool or unusually hot.

Maybe it was just blush.**xxxDoug**: *Jungle fever in the air?*

anonymousse: *my life just got so much better*

SteveO: *looks like someones getting a big surprise*

plummer: *bbc anyone*

jquaid13: *am i the only one who wants to see her mouth on this guys cock?*

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Maybe it was just blush.

Maybe it was the flush of a woman who had just had some cock.

“- exercise awareness around not just squirrels, but all wild animals,” she was saying.

That's right. The squirrel gang. She had mentioned that it had turned out that the boys claiming to be attacked had attracted the animals with sandwiches and the squirrels had bravely returned for more, until one day the kids didn't have any sandwiches.

But Rachel hadn't mentioned anything else about this news story, other than that she hated her bullshit assignments.

She was still talking on the video. Josh could feel the excitement building up as he watched. What did any of this have to do with big black cock?

He shivered.

He let his eyes fall to the comments again.

In the second he took his eyes off the video, the a voice interrupted Rachel's speech. “Oh shit, Ray!” and the camera seemed to fall. There were sounds of a dog growling, men yelling at each other, all of it very fast and disjointed. He heard, “get your fucking dog!” and a frightened, feminine scream from Rachel. When it stopped moving, the camera was on the ground, sideways. Rachel was maybe ten feet from the camera, and a pair of legs with jeans hurried over to her. Rachel sat down on the steps of a porch, and half of her face came into view.

And then the man in the jeans crouched. The dark skin of a well-muscled arm reached behind him and the man extended his hand, palm forward and fingers splayed, at someone yelling off-screen. “Yo, I got you

man, just get the fuck over there and shut up.” The ebony man was crouching next to Rachel, and he put his hand on her knees. He was speaking to her in a low voice that could not be heard off-camera.

Josh stared at the hand on her knee. His skin was dark, almost ink-black. His arm was chiseled into waves of muscle. He bounced lightly on his heels in a crouch, with the ease of an athletic man.

His face was turned sideways, but enough of the shape of his cheekbones, the fullness of his lips, the dark curls of a well-trimmed beard, were visible to convey that he was striking. Statue-like.

And so black.

And his hand was on her knee. His very large hand, covering it almost completely. Next to her bare knee, the yawning darkness of the space between her legs, between her thighs, under her skirt. Almost revealed to the camera...

In the video, Rachel nodded.

She tucked her hair behind her ear.

She smiled bravely.

She placed her hand on top of the dark man's hand and looked into his eyes.

Josh felt a knife plunge through him. From his throat, which had closed tight with a gurgle, to his heart, which was beating so fast he was sure it would explode, through his torso that twisted in tense pain.

Right to his cock.

Was he aroused? Was he angry? Was his heart being smashed into a million pieces?

Josh replayed the video from the point where the camera was dropped.

Again.

Again.

He paused it.

He stared at the black hand on his wife's knee.

He looked behind him, to make sure no one was watching him.

But no one would know why he had paused the video there.

Someone might think, because he saw a man putting his hand on his wife's knee.

They would be right.

But they would probably think he was jealous, or angry, or about to have a talk with his wife about her behavior.

Only Josh knew that the things going through his mind were not of that persuasion.

That instead, even if he didn't particularly want to, he was thinking about the acronym *bbc*.

In detail.

Imagining that big black cock inside his wife.

He stood up and wiped his brow. He looked down at the tent of his pants and thought better of standing. He sat back down.

He closed the window of his browser and exhaled sharply. He needed to think about something else. He needed to think about something else...

But his mind kept going to the image of his small-framed wife, and her cameraman's large hands, one on each knee, prying her legs open.

He stared at the words on his computer, but the lines of the black letters and numbers against the white of the page soon led him back to the same thoughts and the same fantasy: the cameraman's black hand moving over the skin of his wife's knee. Then her leg. Then dipping into the pink of her flesh. Pulling away at her clothes.

And all the while, the face of the “adorable” Rachel Elliot washed over by an expression of lust, her lips open and her mouth begging him for more. Her eyes wet and wide with pleasure as her cameraman moved his dark hands up cup the fullness of her breasts. In Josh's fantasy, Rachel turned to look at him, her lips turned up at the corners in an unnerving smile, just as her cameraman sunk into her spread-open flesh.

The afternoon disappeared this way. At four, his coworkers began to move around him, and Josh realized that he hadn't done much work at all, and what he had done would have to be reviewed because he had no recollection of doing it.

And his cock had been hard for hours.

He waited for as many people as possible to leave ahead of him, and then unsteadily went to his car. He felt both exhausted and almost high as he drove home, trying to rein his thoughts in to figure out what he should do when he spoke to Rachel.

Should he ask her what happened, and reveal that he stalked the very fanclub video sites she detested? Should he play it cool, and glean the information from her some other way?

Or should he merely let it all play out? Say nothing, and quietly observe as her cameraman honed in on his wife?

His cock flexed at the thought.

And while he wondered why that was, his mind didn't linger long on these questions before it spun downward, in ever-more graphic circles of thoughts and images. His head was full of images of Rachel panting and drooling, her lips hanging over the erect tip of an enormous black cock, her throat squeezing out stereotypically pornographic gasps and moans of pleasure, her eyes glowing as inch after inch of cock disappeared inside her every hole.

It was a miracle he managed to drive his car home at all.

4: CONFRONTATION

Rachel was home and making dinner. She smiled sweetly. She was the antithesis to the wife Josh had been fantasizing about all the way home. The Rachel in his kitchen was his sweet-faced wife, loyal and kind. Not the moaning, spit-covered porn star of his fantasy, who filled her mouth with as much cock as she could get her hands on.

He dropped his briefcase to the floor. He was relieved when he heard the sound of it hitting the floor, that in his daze he had remembered to bring it home with him.

Then he wobbled to a stool at the counter when Rachel had her back turned. His erection was still embarrassingly noticeable. And painful at this point.

He watched his wife as she clipped through the kitchen, preparing dinner.

He had resolved to say nothing to her. One of his fantasies in the car had gone to an absurd and disgusting climax, in which Rachel fit both the cock and the balls of the cameraman into her mouth to clean them off after he had filled her pussy full of his seed. At that point, Josh had seen through the haze of unusually high testosterone and lust that he was going too far, even in the privacy his own mind.

He would say nothing to Rachel about any of this.

Of course he wouldn't.

But now, in the kitchen, with her pretty ass turned to him, he felt differently. Perhaps because she had said almost nothing to him.

"Oh, hello," she had said. Nothing more.

Josh felt the foreign grip of animal jealousy seize him. His voice was like cut glass when he said:

"Is there something you want to tell me about the other day?"

Rachel opened the fridge and dove into it. From behind the door, her voice was cheerful. Blasé. "Are we out of soy sauce *again*?"

Josh frowned at the refrigerator door. Rachel had begun her sentence long before he finished his own, so he knew she wasn't deliberately trying to avoid the question he had asked.

She did that all the time.

She was just being herself.

He *knew* that.

How he *felt* was quite different.

Something reptilian was growing inside of him. He glared at the door.

"I think you better talk to a doctor before you keep using that much of it," Rachel continued, still talking about the soy sauce. Then she swung the door half-closed and peeked out from behind it. "Sorry honey, what was it you were saying?"

She turned her attention back to the contents of the fridge.

It would be ridiculous now to repeat his sentence.

He *knew* that.

But he did it anyway.

"Is there anything you want to tell me, about what happened the other day?" He said this more loudly, and narrowed his eyes in preemptive accusation.

He was half-hoping, he realized, that she would lie to him.

"Uh...the other day..."

She was distracted, searching the items in the fridge, thinking about dinner. The question didn't seem to have disturbed her. She didn't even seem to be thinking about it, but rather, repeating the words with her brain turned off.

This made Josh stumble a little. If the moment he had witnessed on camera had been meaningful to her, and that was her reason for not telling him about it, wouldn't it have given her pause when her husband asked her a question like this? A question laced with accusation?

Rachel closed the door. She was looking at him. She had a block of tofu in her hand.

Her look was expectant. Josh had to rack his brains a little to get at what she was expecting, because his mind had drifted far away from his own kitchen, to a place where his wife was cheating on him. With her cameraman, a big, built black man who pounded her until she screamed -

"Honey?" She had a tinge of annoyance to her voice. "*What* are you talking about? *What* other day?"

"I..." Josh suddenly felt like an ass. What was he accusing his wife of? This was not a way to have a conversation with her about the video clip. Just as quickly as his masculine rage had built up, it dissipated as the reality of what he was doing finally made its way into his brain:

He was sitting here accusing his wife of having an affair, half-hoping she was, because he enjoyed fantasizing about her being fucked by a huge black man.

He was a disgrace. A rather *racist* disgrace to boot; a man who had actually just spent the better part of an afternoon imagining his wife upside-down on a couch with a big black man crouched over her, shoving foot after foot of his cock inside of her.

It felt as dirty, all of the sudden. Like coming into a sock just before the end of an ultra-filthy porno and then having the remainder of the sick, twisted porn play out on the screen.

“I forget,” he said lamely.

There was no point saying that, and he knew it as soon as he said it.

But Rachel didn't let comments like this go until they were fully explained.

“About the other day?” Her eyes were already turning to beady little slits. She knew he was faking something, had sniffed out his confrontational tone.

She wasn't going to let it go.

Josh coughed. “I just...” There was no way out. He had set the conversation in motion, and he would have to ride it out now. “It's just...have you seen this video from the other day? When you went to cover the squirrels?”

Rachel's face registered a very genuine surprise. Confusion. She shook her head slightly, but it was evident she was thinking in circles. “They didn't even air it...” her voice trailed off. “Wait. What happened in the clip?”

But her brain had lit up like a piece of paper on fire. She dropped the tofu onto the counter and steamed out of the room.

Josh felt a strange kind of excitement as he followed her. A mixture of fear, jealousy, rage, and arousal. He wasn't sure what he wanted to happen next:

For her to watch it and say, “oh, yeah, that guy. I've been letting him fuck my brains out for years?”

Or for her to start crying? Or for the whole thing to be a big misunderstanding?

She was moving quickly now. She threw her laptop on the coffee table. “What site was it?”

“Huh?”

“The site? Where did you see it?”

She was furious.

“Uh...Rachel's Fans or...maybe...” he was struggling to remember. Had it been a clean site, or one of the dirtier ones?

“God,” she dismissed him impatiently. Rachel clicked through her bookmarks.

Josh was relieved to see the video clip posted to one of the more innocuous sites – not the same one he had seen. Rachel's eyes moved over the screen, quickly and the slowly. She scrolled.

She played the video.

She stopped it halfway through.

“What the fuck?” she spat.

Josh was urging her, silently, to press play and watch it all the way through. Instead, she, waved her hand at the screen and turned to him. “This isn't even footage we shot. This is just...some dog got loose and came running at me. What the blood...is this doing...how did someone even get a hold of this?” Her mouth was open and she was spewing half-finished sentence and words. Her eyes moved over the screen like a scanner.

It was clear to Josh that whatever was going on here, he had lost control of where Rachel's thoughts were going. She turned back to the computer.

She was silent, her upper teeth nibbling at her lower lip. Then she dug into her bag, took out her phone, and stood up. She paced the room with the phone to her ear.

Josh opened his mouth, and he wasn't even sure what he was going to say, but Rachel was already talking.

“Have you seen this shite on the internet?...”

“...sorry, yeah, okay, I'm just worked up, listen, go to...” she spun around and read the website address off for the person on the other end of the phone.

Josh stood, feeling helpless and almost superfluous. He had wanted something else to happen in this moment, of that he was sure.

But what had he wanted?

“How in the hell did this even...? I'm...look, I have to ask you, straight away: it wasn't you, was it?”

A pause.

“I know.” Rachel put her hand to her forehead. She started to lose her composure. Josh was surprised to see that she seemed to be ready to cry. “God. I know. I'm sorry I even thought that. I just don't understand how this stuff keeps getting out. And the comments are like...”

There was a long silence on Rachel's end, during which she stared into the wall and appeared to be listening intently. She said “okay” a few times, and her face relaxed. Her watering eyes stopped looking as though they would overflow, and she started to nod.

It was as though Josh was not only no longer in the room, but he didn't even exist.

He moved closer to the couch, and she didn't even sweep her eyes toward his movement.

“Okay,” she said again. Then she added, in a sweet voice. “Xav? I'm sorry. I was just-”

The words cut through Josh. “*Xav?*”

So that was her lover's name.

Suddenly Rachel laughed outright. She swung back around to the screen. “What does that...”

Her face flushed.

“Oh my god. Oh my god.” She covered her face with one hand.

Another pause.

She laughed again.

Josh watched his wife's face, as the words from the man on the other end of the phone transformed her expression. Smoothly, calmly, Josh imagined, talking her down. Telling her not to worry, there was nothing damning in the clip.

Telling her to smile, her husband would never find out that he had been filling up her tight little blonde cunt with his enormous black cock. *Just act cool*, he was saying, *and I'll see you tomorrow, and put my huge hand right on your red-hot little pussy...*

Josh felt his face flush. Jesus. What was wrong with him?

“See you tomorrow,” Rachel said.

She tossed the phone onto the couch. She folded her arms and finally turned to Josh.

He was suddenly very aware of his erection. He watched her eyes, and they didn't go to his crotch, which was good. She bit her lip again.

Her eyes were not seeing him.

She was thinking.

“Someone,” she said, waving a slender finger in the air, “has been leaking videos to these creeps. And it wasn't Xavier.”

Xavier. The cameraman. He had a name. He had a name and a smooth, calm voice to talk his wife down from a fit of rage. He had smooth black hands that he liked to put on her knee.

Josh felt the animal in him stirring up again.

“Who's Xavier?” Josh said. But there was too much in his tone. More than casual curiosity.

Rachel noticed. Josh could see it in the way her eyelid twitched, and her mouth parted a little before she spoke.

“He's my cameraman. Xavier.” She pointed her finger at the screen, almost angrily. “The guy in the video.”

She had a tone to her voice like she expected him to know this. As though she had said something about this guy a million times before. It was a tone Josh was familiar with because he often didn't listen, and often got caught for that crime.

“Oh,” he said. “Xavier.” Then very lamely: “I didn't realize he was black.”

His mouth was out of control now. Silently, he told himself to shut up. To close his mouth and not let another word come out of it. He was being an idiot.

Rachel rolled her eyes. “Anyway. He's my cameraman. But I know he wouldn't...I mean, I don't even understand what someone would be thinking...”

Josh folded his arms over his chest.

This was as good of an opening as he was going to get. For whatever it was he thought he wanted, which he wasn't sure of at all. He felt like he was piloting a boat in a dream, drunk.

He opened his mouth, dreading the fact that he was going to speak.

“It's sort of...have you seen the whole thing?”

Rachel's eyes were on fire when she looked at him. “I just watched it the first time right now!” she said. Her voice was shrill.

She put her hands to her face and rubbed it. “Oh god. Oh god, honey, I'm sorry. This is just...it's sort of creepy, you know what I mean?”

She turned and plopped into the couch and clicked on the paused video.

Her body didn't move, revealed nothing as she watched. She brought her hand to her mouth at the end and scrolled through the comments again. "This is just so...stupid," she said. "What the fuck is wrong with these people? Don't they have anything better to do than...I don't know, like stalk me and write dumb comments?"

It was true. She was right, of course, but Josh could sympathize deeply with "these people." He even liked these people, these men who were so dedicated to stalking his wife and watching footage of her – any footage.

His balls ached so much he felt ill.

Josh looked at Rachel's face as she scanned the comments. Her expression was turning sour. She was so disgusted by it all.

Why was even *that* turning Josh on?

It was true, he had to admit: she didn't seem to be hiding anything. She wasn't acting like a woman who had been caught on camera doing something she shouldn't. She didn't even seem to notice the gesture, or the fact that Xavier had touched her knee.

And wouldn't a woman guilty of having an affair notice something like that?

Wouldn't a woman having an affair try to cover it up?

The thing Josh couldn't get his head around was whether or not he was relieved, or disappointed.

5: DREAM

Josh was an analytical man, and he rarely turned off that part of his brain. He was the kind of man who more often than not knew when he was dreaming, because he spent a good part of his dream-time analyzing everything that was wrong with his dream-world.

Sleep had been a long time coming. Rachel had declared that she needed to work. She had eaten her dinner angrily and thrown half of it away. In the time it took to eat dinner, Josh's cock had deflated somewhat, and he was able to have a rational thought.

And that was this:

He should just go jerk off in the shower. Which he did, imagining Rachel and Xavier, Xavier and Rachel, black and white and writhing like snakes in slippery-wet cum. Then he had gone to bed, and thought about the same thing until he was sweating and had to jerk off again.

Then he had lain face-up and hoped for sleep to put him out of his strange misery.

He knew he was dreaming some time after he returned to his cubicle in the dream. The coffee mug in his hand was weightless, and people who didn't work in his office were watching him as he approached his desk. They had no faces.

Knowing, somewhere in the back of your mind, that you are in a dream, is not necessarily helpful for numbing the feelings of stress it gives you. Josh, ever-analytical, noted this as well as he sat down with a sinking feeling in his chest.

All the way to his cock, where it pulsed, heavy and aching.

His computer screen was filled with porn. Somehow, without saying it, the screen broadcast “BBC!” and “tight white pussy stretched by black cock!” He knew his coworkers could read the words, and they were horrified. The sounds coming from the computer – for of course he had left the volume blaring while he went to retrieve his weightless cup of coffee – were the hyper-sexualized moans of cheap porn.

“Oh!” a girl with a small, underaged-sounding voice squeaked. “Oh! Oh! Oh! Oh! Oh fuck!”

The screen, however, was a blur of black and white skin. Josh strained to see what was making the woman scream the way she was (he

knew it was a big cock, maybe in her ass) but the video never cleared up. Only the sound. "Oh, baby, I like that tight little cunt," the male growled.

More screaming. The slapping sound of skin as the man apparently pummeled the woman. High-pitched wailing, and poor Josh left to imagine it all in his dream.

There was the annoyance of not being able to actually see them, and the implicit shame of his colleagues staring at him. It all twisted together into a hard knot, and to make matters worse, he couldn't unzip his pants in this dream. His dream hands fumbled, sensationless, with the flat nothingness where his zipper should be.

The voices from the computer monitor changed. The timbre of the woman in the video transformed, and turned into Rachel's voice. In the way that things are known in dreams, Josh knew that the new resonance of the black man was the voice of Xavier.

A gasp, simultaneous and theatrical, was emitted by the growing crowd surrounding his cubicle.

The provenance of the voices shifted suddenly. No longer coming from his speakers, the voices could be heard echoing in the very real world of his dream: down the hallway.

Josh abandoned his computer, and his workplace faded away. He moved into a hallway that did not exist, and on either side of him, doors led to bedrooms, each of them empty as he peered into it. The sheets were all rumpled, though, and sodden from lovemaking. Josh didn't know if it was possible to smell in dreams, but every room smelled of sweat and the scent of his wife.

He glided, or whatever it is you do in a dream, down the hallway. Each room was more disheveled, each bed more used. The scent of his wife grew stronger. The voices became louder.

When he arrived at the scene his mind obviously wanted him to be taken to, he was finally able to unzip his pants. His hand, which had been flailing at nothing, suddenly found his zipper.

In the room, the dark body of Xavier was on top of his wife. Her legs were spread wide and he was pummeling himself into her.

Josh stroked his cock furiously, mimicking the rising orgasm of first his wife and then Xavier...but to no avail. He would never make himself come; deep down he knew that, because he knew he was dreaming.

Xavier filled his wife, and then they kept going: she climbed to her knees. In the magic of dreams, there was no transition, she was just suddenly close to Josh. At eye level. Xavier had stretched out on his back, and his cock was waving in the air. A big, thick, cock. Unreal. Insanely thick.

Rachel looked at her husband as she opened her mouth, and her lips stretched to an impossible size to accommodate the impossibly large brown cock. Her eyes burned into his, and Josh frantically jerked at his own cock, hoping to rid himself of the pain that was building up inside of him. He knew, the way you know in a dream without seeing something, that his wife's pussy was wide and gaping and dripping load after load of hot white cum down her thighs. The sound of her moaning was muffled by the cock in her mouth, and she slurped and gagged but went on relentlessly. "Mmm, mmm, mmm-mmm," she hummed.

This went on for what seemed like an eternity, until the pain was too great in his cock. A lucid dreamer, he reasoned with himself after what seemed like hours of this torture: he needed to wake up so he could alleviate his pain, by actually touching himself.

Josh forced himself to wake up. He was sweating, and blood pounded in his ears until the air around him seemed to be tingling.

He looked down, and was surprised to see a moving lump, the size of a head. He felt the warmth of Rachel's mouth on his cock, enfolding him in her wetness. He closed his eyes and looked at the ceiling, basking in the sensation of her frisky tongue, her tight throat enclosing him...

But wait. It was going nowhere again. Only making things worse.

He tossed the covers away and there she was, her hand clamped around his cock and her mouth moving up and down the length of his shaft.

He reached out to put his hand on the back of her head, an impulse that tipped him off before he even did it – he was not that kind of guy, it always felt a little sleazy. So he knew he was still dreaming.

He stared at his wife's mouth on his cock and knew he should wake up. A blowjob in a dream could never end.

Then Rachel released him from her mouth, and lifted her head. Xavier was again in the scene, kneeling next to her on the bed, and she abandoned Josh for him. She opened her mouth and took him inside of her again.

Josh stared as she took him in and out of her mouth. She looked up to meet Xavier's eyes. She let him grasp her fine blond hair and push her

down, down, down onto his cock until her lips grazed his pubic bone.

Then he released her, and she gasped for air and licked her lips. With a serrated smile she turned to Josh and placed one hand on his cock. The other, she kept wrapped around Xavier's, drawing it in languid strokes from the fat base of his dick to his blunt head, massaging the nub of it with her palm before going back down to the base. She moved her head back toward Josh's aching cock.

Josh felt his wife's lips on his balls. The heat of her mouth burned into him, and he opened his mouth to scream in pleasure. No sound came out.

In the dream, Xavier's big cock erupted. He gushed what seemed like gallons of cum, a seemingly unending stream. The ropes of cum fell on Rachel's back, and then she turned to capture his spurting seed in her mouth. The creamy white flood spilled down her neck, covered her tits, and leaked. It splattered across her face, into her hair, all over her face until she was sticky and shiny with Xavier's cum.

She kept her hand on Josh's cock as she did this, stroking him fiercely. But the release never came for Josh. His cock was still hard and aching. He could only watch, pained, as more and more cum covered his wife, and she smiled and let it fall into her mouth and across her face.

He sat up, breaking with his dream immediately.

He had sweat into the sheets; they were soaked through.

He looked around the room, absorbing the details that are the sure tell-tales of reality. A reflection in the mirror, accurate down to his graying hair. Light, coming from a source outside the window. He looked at his feet, which never seemed to be a thing he could imagine in a dream.

He was really awake.

The pain in his cock was still throbbing mercilessly. His heart was beating as though he had gone on a bender the night before.

He looked to his left. Rachel was in bed now, asleep, but she was stirring.

His cock had made a tent of the sheets at his crotch.

The ache in his cock had been the one true thing about his dream. There was no doubt of that. He pushed the covers aside and reached down to touch himself: the tip of his dick was wet with precum.

He stared at it, almost disbelieving reality at this point. How long had it been since he had been this turned on? Since his cock had been this hard,

and his balls had felt so squeezed?

It was both terrifying and bit ego-boosting. But he was probably still dreaming. He had to be.

He slid down and onto his side, facing Rachel.

He slid his hand beneath the covers, and tugged at them gently, exposing her shoulders, and then her breasts. She was wearing a light cami-like shirt and some silky panties. He pulled the sheet down further, sliding it off of her body.

She made a sound and reached for the sheet.

Josh slid his hand over her smooth side and down along her flat stomach. He pressed his nose into her neck, and inhaled her scent. In the morning she smelled most like herself, from sleeping buried beneath the covers and sweating lightly. His fingertips brushed along the hem of her panties. The rough lace tickled the pads of his fingertips. Rachel stirred, but she did not move away from him. He was sure he could see a faint smile on her lips, so he moved his hand along the fabric. Beneath the lace, he could feel where the downy hair of her neatly trimmed bush began. He worked his fingers into the fold of her thigh, and dug to get his fingertips under the material.

His own urgency was growing, and the sound of Rachel moaning in his dream was still fresh in his mind. It echoed in his ears as he pulled gently on her thigh to spread her legs just a little, and his cock pulsed against her.

She opened her eyes, and it was at that moment that things could go either way. After his dream, though, Josh was in no mood to have Rachel wriggle away from him or blow him off. He pushed her with the hand between her legs so that she rolled toward him, and at the same time he moved his fingers up, upward to where he was pleased to find her slit slightly wet.

A look of mild surprise crossed Rachel's face. He knew it was because he wasn't ordinarily so forward, so eager. His fingers moved to her clit and with his eyes he told her to stay as she was. He could feel that he was conveying something different to his wife, and it held her motionless where she was. When he pried her legs apart to get better access to her cunt, she simply fell open for him.

He could feel her body responding to him. Her juices welled up quickly and coated his fingers as he stroked her clit. Her eyes were on his

and they half-closed in pleasure as he pressed her button a little harder, and swept some of her hot moisture up to swirl the pad of his forefinger over the raw center of her clit.

The images from his dream seemed to come back to life: his wife's legs spread beneath the powerful blackness of her cameraman's body. Her mouth pried open to an obscene hole by his thick cock. Josh was suddenly impatient, and he threw the covers off and rose up on his knees. He jerked Rachel's panties away, down her legs, and threw them on the floor.

Her face registered more surprise, but she said nothing. A smile turned up the corners of her mouth. Her gaze swept over his body and rested on his cock, and Josh's member swelled even more, if it was possible. They had been married for almost seven years now, and it was not often that his wife looked at his cock anymore.

But in his mind, he imagined that she was looking at Xavier's cock. How would her face change for him? Would she be afraid of its power, its girth, its length?

As he moved toward her, she spread her legs open for him. He slid into her easily. She was wet and unusually hot, and a moan escaped his mouth as her flesh enclosed his cock.

She lifted her thighs and wrapped her legs around him. He felt the familiar weight of her soft heels on his lower back. Her mouth opened, and her eyes closed.

Josh let himself indulge in the fantasy that she might be lost in her own dreams from the night before. Similar dreams. Or perhaps in her dream Xavier spread her legs open and pulled the lips of her pussy apart to better access her swollen clit with his tongue...

Josh realized he was slamming himself into his wife, fucking her so hard their skin was slapping together. He opened his eyes and saw that hers were still closed. Her nails dug into his back and he felt the pressure of her thighs on his ribs and against his lower back. She writhed beneath him as she came. Her pussy seemed to burst around him, hot and sticky-wet. He watched a flush of color streak up her cheeks, and felt her body almost deflate as the tension left her.

And then, he let himself go. He looked at her lips as he thrust himself deep inside of her, imagining, the whole time, that they were stretched around a veined black cock so large she could barely breathe.

6: DAYDREAM

Xavier was not at work for two days, which set Rachel to thinking and over-thinking. She had bouts of having to lock her phone in her car to keep from calling him, to find out where he was.

After all, she reasoned, this was nothing. He had told her so. It was the internet, being what the internet was: stupid and full of unrealistic, childish dreams of sex.

But Xavier's absence worried her.

Was it worry, though? Just worry? If she were to be honest with herself, there was an element of longing, wasn't there?

She spent a day justifying the feeling to herself as stemming from her annoyance with Harry, who had all sorts of annoying ticks and was a bad driver.

She knew, though, that it wasn't truthful to blame what she was feeling on Harry. She knew she wanted Xavier back not because she wanted to make sure everything was 'cool,' - that was only part of it – but because she wanted to see him.

Secretly, she enjoyed thinking about the ideas “the internet” had come up with. She liked entertaining the idea that Xavier's friendliness had something more behind it.

She ate lunch in the van the second day he was out. It was a nice day and she didn't feel like going through the rigmarole of getting into the office, just to come back out thirty minutes later. Harry had hurried in, after divulging too much information about his bathroom needs, leaving her alone. She ate a bag of carrots and leaned back against the headrest. She closed her eyes.

She just went for it. There was little flutter of guilt, as she stepped off into her fantasy. She was married. It wasn't right to think about another man, to know you were about to start thinking about him, deliberately, as a pleasurable activity.

But then again, it was also just fantasy.

Surely Josh watched porn now and again.

What was the difference?

Besides, her fantasy was mild. It began with Xavier touching her knee. They exchanged looks.

His hand moved up from her knee, up to her thigh. She could almost feel the sensation of his fingers against her skin, and the surge of arousal that would snake up her inner thigh and settle in her pelvis.

"I'm married," she whispered, and Xavier said nothing. He just kept moving his hand up, between her legs, until his fingers brushed over her panties...

She rewound this part, started back at his eyes when she told him she was married. His fingers traveled up, up, to where he found her without any panties on. His fingers dipped into her pussy, and they slid in easily because she was craving his touch so much.

Then she reached over, and did what she had wanted to do for so long: she unbuckled his pants and pulled on the zipper...

They were sitting. It would be easier if they were standing. How would they get there?

Rachel frowned. She moved the characters in her fantasy to the hallway of the office. She walked down the hallway and suddenly he reached out and pulled her into a closet.

"I'm married," she whispered, her hands on his chest. His muscles were hard under her palms, he was just as strong as she imagined he was. His eyes held her and conveyed that he wouldn't accept this as a "no." He slid his hands down her body, and she did what she had wanted to do for such a long time. She lowered the zipper of his pants, and dipped her hand into the warmth between his legs.

Her hand found his cock, and it was everything she had imagined it would be: it was smooth against her hand. Hot. So thick it was hard to close her hand around it. It thumped in her hand with desire. She stroked it and it glided beneath her skin.

She dropped to her knees, so she could see it. She held it and stroked the length of it for a moment, just to look at it. Dark, darker than his skin. Beautifully shaped, almost like a carving.

She opened her mouth, and pushed him inside of her. She had to stretch wide. She felt him between her lips, and her jaw began to ache as he went in further, further. Now he was in her throat, and she was filled up completely, pleasuring him. He placed his hand on the back of her head and pushed her against him, forcing himself further down her throat -

“Rachel!” A tap on the window.

She was pulled from her fantasy with a jerk. Harry was outside her window, tapping on the bottom half of it. She was instantly annoyed.

Harry held up a hand and pointed across the parking lot. He had a greasy bag in his claw. “We have to take that van,” he said. “Marisa needs this one because of some equipment issue.”

“What equipment issue?!” Rachel snapped. She didn't care, and she knew she was being unreasonable, but she was irritated as hell for being drawn out of her fantasy.

As she moved to slide out of the passenger seat, she felt a slickness between her legs. She was incredibly wet, and she ached between her legs.

“Give me a minute,” she snapped at Harry. “I have to go to the bathroom.”

She crossed the parking lot, unable to believe what she was about to do. But the craving she had was distracting her. She wouldn't be able to think about anything if she didn't get some relief. She would spend her whole afternoon thinking about her cameraman's luscious black cock.

Imagined luscious black cock, she corrected herself.

She ran up the stairs to the second floor, where there was a bathroom outside of security checks that no one used. She locked the outside door, and the thought that it seemed a little reckless occurred to her, but she pushed it out of her mind. She was aching now. She couldn't remember being so turned on an eternity. She locked herself in a stall and leaned her left hand against the wall. She would ordinarily never have done such a thing in a public restroom, but she was beyond reason, now.

She pushed her hand between the tight waist of her black skirt and her torso. The fabric had only a little give, but there was something too seedy about unzipping it. Her fingers moved between her panties and her skin, and she was surprised by how wet she was. Her fingers slid between the folds of her skin easily, and she found her engorged clit.

She parted her legs a little more, and closed her eyes. She tried to pull herself back into her daydream, right where she left off: the feeling of Xavier's cock in her mouth, the unexpected silkiness of his shaft, the weight of his hand against the back of her head. She opened her mouth, enjoying the idea of mimicking her fantasy as she rubbed her clit quickly, right on the sensitive bud in its center.

In her fantasy, she tipped her head down and to the side, to lick Xavier's balls, and feel him shudder with pleasure.

She sucked in her breath as her finger stroked her over the edge. Her orgasm was violent, and it shook her all at once. She leaned against the door of the stall and tried to calm herself. Her fingers were swimming in her cum now, and her wrist hurt from the awkward angle she had shoved it in her skirt.

With her ears ringing, she stepped backwards and sat down on the toilet, as though to pee. Her panties were soaked. She felt dizzy.

What was she doing?

The absurdity of what she had just done hit her suddenly. It was the middle of the day. She was married. She was masturbating to the fantasy of sucking her coworker's cock, which wasn't even a fantasy (sucking cock) that she normally entertained. Her underwear were soaked through with her own excitement.

What the fuck was she doing?

7: PROTEST

Rachel cleaned herself up the best she could and went back out to the new van, where Harry was waiting in the driver's seat with the window down and terrible death metal music blaring. He was shaking his head and his unwashed mop of hair with wild abandon. Rachel sighed and opened the passenger door.

Harry almost immediately turned down the music. "You're on that other story now," he said. He looked her up and down, and Rachel felt herself burning up. Did he know what she had just been doing? Could he tell?

Oh dear god. He couldn't *smell* her, could he?

Harry smiled. "It's a real story," he said, winking. "And your *love interest* is going with you."

Rachel stood looking at him, with no idea how to respond. The first half of his sentence had actually seemed like genuinely friendly comment, but the second had not.

That's how it was with Harry.

Rachel closed the door and looked back at the other van. "Thanks," she muttered, distractedly. Something was bothering her, and it wasn't until she was halfway across the parking lot that she realized what it was: Harry had evidently seen the fanpage, or talked to someone who had.

Which meant Harry was some kind of pervert who stalked her, or that the entire station was talking about her and Xavier.

"God," she said. She wanted to be purely annoyed. She *should* be purely annoyed.

But she knew there was something inside of her that very naughtily liked the video.

She liked the idea of Xavier.

She liked the idea of his cock...

"God," she repeated.

She crossed the parking lot in a daze. Halfway to the van the driver tooted a welcome song at her.

Xavier.

She couldn't see him, with the glare of the sun on the windshield, but she knew it was him.

She also knew that her breath quickened, and her chest seemed to fill with a swarm of insects.

She opened the door.

Xavier smiled at her.

Her head whirled, and she stood there stupidly.

“You coming? Come on, chop chop, we have to beat these protesters. Get on the phone with Arthur, he was looking for you.” Xavier tossed a phone in her direction.

Rachel hopped into the van, in a daze.

She thought of her underwear, soaked through with the excitement of her naughty fantasies. She wondered if Xavier would smell her, and a forceful blush crept up her cheek.

She looked down at her skirt, making sure there was no evidence of what she had been doing. It hit her suddenly that she had just locked herself in a work bathroom to masturbate in the middle of the day, and that she was sitting next to the man she had thought about while she did it, hit her suddenly. She flushed again.

“You okay?” Xavier said.

“What? I...yeah...I'm fine. Why do you ask? It's just hot.” She fumbled with the air conditioning and turned it on to her face to emphasize her point. “Where have *you* been?” she said, to change the subject.

Xavier shrugged. “Called in.” He backed out of the parking space and adjusted the mirror afterward. “Call Arthur.”

Rachel fumbled with the phone grateful to have something to do.

The awkwardness continued when they arrived at their destination: just outside the steps of City Hall. Rachel should have been thrilled to finally get an assignment that met her criteria of “news.” She should have been curious about why Arthur had suddenly had a change of heart and put her on this story instead of another human interest garbage story.

But the only thing she could think about was her dirty daydream.

Xavier seemed to be deliberately ignoring her discomfort. Finally, without taking his eyes off the windshield and the street where the protesters were rumored to plan to travel down, he spoke.

“Cat has Rachel's tongue. Why's that Rachel?”

Rachel felt her stomach turn. She needed to think of something quickly, and it couldn't be: *"I'm slightly embarrassed that I just spent the morning daydreaming about sucking your cock and then I masturbated in the second-floor bathroom."*

You need to divert, Rachel.

There was the blog, and the video. Talk about that.

Instead, words tumbled out of her mouth in a garble:

"Can we just...I want to..."

Rachel felt like she was about to start crying. The feeling gripped her suddenly. Her chest was tight, and her eyes were stinging.

Fuck, she thought. She never lost her cool. She hadn't felt this feeling for almost fifteen years, since she did her first public speaking. She had gotten over it and now she was a professional.

Her cheeks felt hot. A hysterical laugh was also building up inside of her, maybe from the pressure building in her chest.

She had no choice. She covered her face with both hands and doubled over to hide as much of herself as possible in her own lap.

The sound that came out of her chest was horrible. It was a strangled half-cry, half-laugh, and there was nothing about it that wasn't embarrassing. It was wet, half in her nose and half in her mouth, and she felt her eyes well over in tears.

Xavier did nothing.

She was extremely grateful for this. If he had touched her back, or made a joke, it would have made everything worse.

She sat up. She knew her face was red, and she had probably drooled on herself. She was sweating, even in the air conditioning.

"I have to talk to you about this," she said. Her voice came out shaky, and she had to squeeze hard to get it out of her chest. "I'm so...I can't just not not talk to you..." she waved her hands in front of her face, trying to cool herself off.

Jesus, she was acting like an idiot. A new wave of embarrassment welled up inside of her and she felt like her voice would be choked off if she uttered another word, so she just looked up at the corner of the car roof and waved her hands in front of her face.

"Look," Xavier said. "You're a fine-ass white woman, and I'm a fine-ass black man. People on the internet are gonna say all kind of shit about that. What is it? The bbc?"

Rachel fell into her own lap again.

Xavier laughed.

"I can't talk about it."

"Are you crying?" He was amused.

She waved her hand up above her torso and shook her head.

But she was.

She was crying, but it wasn't necessarily because she was prude, or embarrassed.

Or was it?

What was it?

Why was she crying?

It wasn't a sad-cry, or even an unhappy cry.

She knew what it was.

It was overwhelmed crying. The memory of her dream was not helping her, and the guilty pleasure she indulged in of bathing in the idea of Xavier's affections, letting the arousal of it flutter around in her stomach, was also not helping.

There was also the fact she very literally did not want to cause any problems in any marriages. Not for herself, not for Xavier.

The whole thing made her so wildly uncomfortable she felt like she was going to stop breathing from the sheer weight of it on her chest. And now, she was in the car with Xavier, and her thoughts were swinging back and forth from wild attraction to dark guilt.

"Ray?" Xavier's voice, low and soothing as always, rippled with concern. It didn't help matters. Rachel felt his words squeezing her heart even more fiercely. "Okay, look. I'm sorry. I didn't realize you were so upset."

Rachel sat up and took a deep inhale. She shook her head. She knew her face was crimson red now, and she could feel that her skin was damp without touching it.

"You're a mess," Xavier laughed. "Look...it's the post?"

Rachel shook her head.

"Josh?"

She shook her head again. What *was* it?

"It's everything!" she said. She felt ridiculous. "I just...it's all really awkward and I feel like...I don't know...I feel..." She was very close to the right answer, she sensed.

“Guilty? Like it's your fault for being Rachel Elliot, KRTV's most adorable reporter?” Xavier offered. He used an announcer-voice to say “KRTV's most adorable reporter.”

Rachel felt as though he had pricked her with a pin and the tension was draining out of her. She nodded.

“Maybe it's *my* fault. For being black.” Xavier had a sarcastic tone as he said this.

She gave him an uncomfortable smile.

It was all so stupid, when he put it like that.

“Just forget about it,” Xavier said.

Rachel frowned.

“Don't you worry about your wife seeing something and thinking...I don't know.”

“Nope.”

Xavier said it so quickly, and with so much confidence, that Rachel felt a flicker of annoyance pass through her. She looked at him skeptically.

“Tell you what,” Xavier said, to her incredulity. “Let's have you all over for dinner. Okay? Clear the air. You'll see, Tyra doesn't care about this, Josh will see we don't care about this, we'll have some of Tyra's food, drink some wine, have an orgy, and it will all be fine.”

He winked at her.

“Stop it.”

“No but seriously, come over for dinner. It'll be...oh shit, here they come. Look alive, Rachel Elliot.”

And then he reached over with a tissue he had seemingly produced from nowhere, and dabbed at a droplet of sweat on her temple.

She shivered with the touch, but there was no time to think about anything that had just transpired between them, or the way an electric ripple of pleasure was traveling down her neck. The protesters were arriving, and this was the first real news story Rachel had been sent to in months. She gave herself a quick glance in the mirror, hastily repaired her make-up, and followed Xavier out of the van.

8: INVITE

Rachel was fidgeting. It was clear to Josh that she had something to say. Rachel had an inability to keep secrets, or even lie well, really. Whatever she had in her head seemed to almost move around beneath her skin like a liquid, shifting every time she moved, until she just let it boil over.

He could feel his pulse quicken a little, as a drop of his fantasy entered his blood. He didn't *really* want her to tell him she was having an affair, or that what had happened with Xavier had been just a little more than what had happened on the screen. But he found it scorching hot that some guilty pleasure might be crawling under Rachel's skin right now. He felt the heavy, queasy ache of excitement in his chest.

He decided to just enjoy it. "Do you want a different salad dressing?" he asked her. "I can make some fresh."

Rachel was staring at her fork. She shook her head. "No, that's okay." She was distracted, he noted. Her mind was miles away.

Was it on her cameraman? Had she done some naughty thing with him? Did they sneak into closets at the station, and press their bodies up against each other, briefly but with longing snaking through both of their bodies? They would look so beautiful together: her pale skin, her light hair; his dark wiriness wrapping around her like a snake...

Josh exhaled. He could feel an erection building.

He looked at Rachel. She was still thinking of something else.

Someone else?

She twisted her fork and spun her salad, as though it were spaghetti. She brought it halfway to her mouth, and then set it down.

"So..." she dragged out the vowel.

Here it was, Josh thought. He could feel arousal and fear fighting each other inside his abdomen. He almost felt sick as he waited for her to finish her sentence.

Because he wanted her to say: "I fucked Xavier."

And he did not.

"Listen, I was talking to Xavier today...he's my cameraman..."

She was looking at her salad. As soon as the word “Xavier” left her lips, it sliced through Josh, either so cold it felt hot, or the reverse. He placed his hand on his stomach. His pulse was so fast now it concerned him.

“And, he thought maybe it would be a good idea to like...smooth things over...*not* that there's really anything to smooth over, but you know, like, de-awkwardify the situation.”

She looked up at him. He was staring at her, and he knew it. He wondered what his expression looked like, and if it betrayed the excitement she would probably find perverse.

Smooth things over, how? he wondered.

Rachel shrugged, almost as if he had said something, and for a moment he felt naked, as if his thoughts had been revealed to her. “If you don't feel like it, that's cool, but...I don't know, I feel...really weird about the whole thing, and Xavier said maybe we should just have a dinner or something.” She looked up at the ceiling. “Sort of like, if we're all just together, there won't be anything weird.”

Josh felt another convulsion inside of him. What did Rachel think was weird? Sparks of arousal flickered through him. She wouldn't think things were weird unless there was, in fact, some kind of “weird” thing going on. Could it be that she was attracted to Xavier?

He watched his wife. She had directed her gaze back to her salad.

She felt guilty. It was a profound guilt, he could see. Not the guilt of having done something inappropriate, but a low-grade guilt. The beginning of a fever.

Josh was starting to think quickly. It wasn't his forte. He was an analyst. He thought slowly and deliberately and made long-term recommendations after considering piles of research.

He scrambled around in his own mind, knowing he needed to steer “things” in the direction he wanted them to go, that he had an opportunity here. But he didn't know for sure what he wanted.

“Uh...” he said, if only to buy himself some more time. If he said nothing, Rachel would keep talking and she might talk herself right out of whatever she was considering.

She shrugged again, again as if he had said something. Rachel was a fast mover, a fast-thinker. Her job required her to move quickly and think quickly, and she could hold up both ends of a conversation by herself, in her

own mind, if he let her. In fact, she did it often enough that they had almost begun communicating this way.

Josh urged himself to take control.

“I think dinner is a great idea. I mean...if that's what you want to do,” he heard himself saying. Not even he was sure where this was leading. “I just don't want...”

He realized he had no idea what he wanted to say.

“I know,” Rachel said, and her reporter-mind was clearly activated. Josh felt a sense of defeat. She was now going to steamroll ahead, finishing his sentence because she didn't have the patience to wait for him. “It to seem like anything weird has actually happened, which was my thought, too. Ever since...you know...it's just been weird, and there *isn't* anything weird, so it's silly, but...”

She scrunched her nose up again. Her sweetness slammed down on everything Josh was thinking, and brought him back to the reality of the situation: his wife had been the subject of wild internet speculation, and she felt bad about it. His own feelings, his own newly awakened and strange feelings about wanting to watch his wife have sex with another man, had nothing to do with any of this. He had no business even thinking about it.

He reached out and put his hand on Rachel's hand. “Honey,” he said. “It's fine. I think it's a good idea. I think we should do whatever you think is a good idea, so you can feel okay about everything.”

Rachel's torso deflated a little as she let out a sigh of relief. She relaxed; he could see that tension had been building up inside of her. He had a pang of guilt when he saw this. She was really stressed out by whatever she was feeling.

And he was feeding off of it like a vulture.

She brightened. “Okay, good. That's good. I really think it will help. So...I'll just tell him that's okay. Apparently his wife is a really great cook so they asked if we could go over there. Will that work?”

Josh summoned his diplomatic, meeting-level smile. He pasted across his face and nodded. “It's perfect,” he willed his mouth to say.

Inside, he felt like someone was throwing his mind around like a basketball. *Wife*. It had never occurred to him that Xavier had a wife, though why wouldn't it? The man was almost forty, of course he was married.

He could feel the pleasure his fantasy had been giving him slipping away from his grasp. He probably never would have had the guts to ask Rachel to do it, and she probably would never have agreed to do it, and she was too good of a wife, he knew, to ever cheat on him. Those were all the sharp corners of reality it had been easy to push aside as he savored his fantasy.

But now, hearing that Xavier had a wife, reality came back into focus. This was all just ludicrous fantasy.

And so much the better.

Rachel gathered energy again, suddenly, and began to talk about Xavier's wife and her cooking. With every word, it became clearer to Josh that Rachel had no desire to have sex with her cameraman. Not secretly, not at Josh's behest, not at all.

He felt a little foolish.

So he nodded, and agreed it would be fine idea if they cleared the air, had a nice dinner together, yes he would probably like Xavier, and Tyra as well.

And he filed his fantasy under “private thoughts for jerking off when Rachel is out of town.”

That was that.

9: DINNER

Xavier, in person, was a great, masculine specimen, and there was no denying it. He opened the door and seemed like a character in a movie, towering above Josh and Rachel, dark and foreboding. He had to be at least six and a half feet tall. Lean muscle peeked out from a short-sleeved dress shirt, and pressed against his jeans. The man was chiseled.

Josh felt a number of feelings as Xavier looked down at them, and none of them were particularly easy for him to define, even to himself.

Principally, he felt his desire rekindled, to see this dark man with his wife skewered by his cock. It was as though someone had tossed gasoline on the idea.

Josh shifted from one foot to another. He extended his hand and Xavier took it. His hand was large and warm, and Josh stared at it, forgetting completely to say anything to him.

“Josh,” Xavier said, just in time to save the moment from an awkwardly long pause. “Xavier.”

Xavier nodded at Rachel, and Josh watched the interaction like a hawk, not sure whether or not to be relieved or disappointed yet again. He hoped for a kiss on the cheek, or a hug, but then wasn't he also relieved that the relationship between his wife and this giant of a man was more professional than that? Mere camaraderie between partners.

“Nice to meet you,” Josh said, and he was impressed with how warm he managed to make his own voice.

This was all going to be fine.

He was going to have a nice evening and not act like a fucking idiot.

He was going to have a nice evening and not spend the whole time thinking about Xavier fucking his wife.

It was going to be difficult.

Just as he was pondering how he would keep his mind under control, in spite of the fact that it was already bubbling with erotic images of Rachel and Xavier, a woman appeared behind Xavier and made Josh's mind stop dead in its tracks.

The woman who materialized behind Xavier *appeared* to be seven feet tall. She wasn't, it was evident, because she was shorter by at least a foot than Xavier, but she appeared that way. Her skin was an impossible color, darker than Xavier's, but also like oil: it captured something in the light that made it seem like hundreds of colors it was not. Her lips were carved into her face like the petals of a lily: full but with sharp edges at the corners. They were painted blood-orange, and they seemed to occupy all of the space in the world for a moment.

Her face was so stunning it was hard not to stare at her. Her hair was a tremendous afro of wild curls, a tinge lighter than her skin. The twists of her exotic beauty, in her strange nose, her high cheekbones, her big, round eyes, held both Josh and Rachel enthralled for a moment.

She seemed to know, probably after a lifetime of looking like she did, that people needed a moment to take her in. Like Xavier, she paused for a moment, expressionless, ethereal, and looked down at the two of them.

Then, with an easy-going warmth, she smiled, and reached for Rachel's hand. "I'm Tyra," she said. "It's so nice to finally meet you." She pulled Rachel up the stairs and, much as Xavier had done to Rachel, gave Josh a nod. As though they saw each other all the time.

The effect was, surprisingly, quite calming. Josh was surprised to find himself put at ease by the presence of Tyra, after the initial shock of seeing someone so beautiful wore away.

Rachel was adorable, and stunning in her own way, but Tyra was a goddess. Obviously, a man with a wife like that wouldn't be overtly putting the moves on a woman from work. He could dismiss his fantasies now, and try to just have a nice time.

A table had been set up in an elegant dining room, and Tyra invited them to sit while Xavier slid behind a small bar in the corner and offered them drinks. "We have wine," he said, "because Tyra insisted on it. But she's made Cajun food and so I am *personally* having a beer."

To emphasize his point, he set a beer, dripping with condensation, on the counter of the bar.

Josh looked from Xavier to Tyra, and saw the amused glances the two were exchanging. This was clearly some kind of silly, marital showdown between the two of them, and Josh had no idea how serious they might be taking things.

Rachel looked at Josh for guidance. He was no help, he knew. He could feel the magnetic pull of Tyra from across the room. He was going to have whatever Tyra told him to. This was partially because she was beautiful, and partially because she was terrifying.

“I’ll have...a glass of wine,” he said.

Tyra clapped her hands together and shook her hips. “That’s a man with class,” she said, pointing at Josh.

Josh couldn’t help feeling a flutter of delight that Tyra was looking at him with approval.

Now Xavier and Tyra turned their sights on Rachel. Xavier pointed to the beer. Tyra narrowed her eyes. “Don’t *let him* talk you into some nasty old beer, darling,” Tyra said to Rachel.

Rachel, Josh could see, was clearly uncomfortable. He took a tiny bit of perverse pleasure in her discomfort.

And he knew what was coming next.

The wrinkling of her nose.

“I’ll have...” she gave the room one last look all around, and then puffed, desperately, “a beer.”

“Mmmhmmm,” Xavier sang-hummed, crouching behind the bar to get into the fridge.

Tyra turned to Josh and pointed again. Her fingers moved back and forth from Josh to herself. “You and me, baby. We have class. I’m gonna go get us some of the *good* stuff.”

Josh felt something come over him. He resisted, with great difficulty, the urge to watch Tyra retreat into the kitchen. He could feel a craving clawing at him, one he hadn’t felt in a long time, to look at a woman’s ass. *Her* ass, specifically, since the dress she was wearing was tight to her skin and the front of her body was a voluptuous, flawless wonder.

Her ass was high and full, as he had expected. It pushed her orange dress out in two absolutely spherical globes, and the material change color ever-so-slightly where it dipped into the crack between those hard spheres as she walked. He had to tear his eyes away from her.

His mind went, unauthorized, to what she must look like naked.

Xavier had come from behind the bar, and set the beers down on the table.

He clinked his bottle together with Rachel’s, and they smiled at each other.

“Animals!” Tyra yelled from the kitchen. “Aren't you even gonna get that poor girl a glass?”

Xavier smiled. Josh watched his face, and saw the embedded wink and complicity in his expression. “You need a glass?” he purred at Rachel. Josh felt his cock twitching, and he was completely unsure whether it was Tyra's round ass, Xavier's panther-like voice, or the remnants of his fantasies about Xavier pumping his wife full of cum.

Rachel shook her head with a small grin.

“We don't need any damn glasses!” Xavier yelled at the kitchen.

Josh heard Tyra tisk and mumble something under her breath.

Josh's fantastical doubts began swirling around again. There was something in the way that Xavier was leaning toward his wife, clinking his beer bottle together with hers, sharing the moment...there was something between them.

Wasn't there?

Maybe it didn't matter to Xavier that his wife was incredibly hot. Maybe Tyra was too much for Xavier. Too beautiful in an untouchable way. Too headstrong or dominating...she seemed a little like that. That could happen. Maybe Tyra was too caught up in her work. Maybe Tyra was cold and mean, and Rachel was a refreshing drink of water to him.

Maybe he liked white women.

Tyra reappeared and set a glass of wine down in front of him. He picked it up, and she clinked her glass to his ostentatiously. Then she gave Xavier a look from the side of her eyes. “I'm not toasting some beer bottle. Not with this crystal.”

Xavier broke into a wide grin.

It was suddenly clear to Josh that this was how the two of them were. This was just the typical banter between a married couple with a good relationship. He immediately felt silly for the thoughts he had just entertained.

But was Xavier staring at Rachel now?

He was.

Wasn't he?

Tyra left for the kitchen again.

“So Josh,” Xavier said, putting his elbows up on his chair. He had the easy-going, smooth masculinity of a man who knew he was a *Man*; he took up the amount space he wanted to; he changed the conversation when he

wanted to; he didn't mind letting his wife boss him around in front of people because he didn't take it from anyone else. "What is it you do, man?"

He was smiling. His face was friendly.

Josh admonished himself again for his rain of crazy thoughts. "I, uh...I work at the CDC."

Xavier nodded. "Oh, that's right. What do you do, though, are you one of those guys who works in the lab testing anthrax and stuff like that?"

Josh was sure Rachel emitted a light laugh, though it might have just been his imagination. When he looked at her, her face was calm and she was holding her wine glass, waiting for his answer with feigned enthusiasm.

Josh's head was swimming. "I...no, no, I'm in...I prepare reports."

"Are they at least *about* anthrax?"

Josh smiled. He wasn't sure what was coming over him, but he felt an impulse, not unlike the impulse to exaggerate his job to a woman, to impress Xavier with his job.

"They can be," he said.

Rachel hit him lightly with the back of her hand.

"They're about measles and Ebola and stuff like that," Rachel said. Then she picked up her cuteness momentum. "It's actually *really scary* sometimes, so I don't talk to him about work anymore. There is some stuff I would rather. Not. Know."

Xavier was looking at her, and Josh was sure he could see a look of pleasure on his face. He liked Rachel as much as the next guy. He liked listening to her when she got excited.

He was probably a fan on Rachel's fanpage.

"Okay, move your hands and get ready for fried pickles and okra!"

Tyra was yelling from the kitchen.

Xavier was looking at Josh. He seemed amused. "I know what you're thinking," he said. His voice was serious, and cut through the air to Josh directly, under the squeals of delight from Rachel.

Josh felt cold prickle his forearms and make a puddle in his torso. Did Xavier know what he was thinking? Which thought? About him wanting to fuck his wife, or about Josh's own lewd thoughts, that had briefly bloomed, about Tyra's cunt and what it looked like?

"You're thinking, 'what are black people doing serving Cajun food?' But Tyra lived in New Orleans. So this isn't like when y'all make spaghetti or something."

Josh stared at him. He hoped his discomfort wasn't evident, but years of experience not thinking well on his feet told him it was.

Xavier smiled, and brought the beer to his lips. "I'm joking with you, man."

There was a moment, before the topic of conversation turned suddenly, that Josh felt sure that Xavier was somehow challenging him.

But Tyra put her hand on his arm, and asked him a question about okra, and the moment was gone. Dinner began, and the food was delicious.

Josh made up his mind to stop being a filthy-minded man, and just enjoy a nice dinner with new friends.

10: TOUR

Rachel had had too much beer. She could feel the heat of an alcoholic flush spreading from her neck to her cheeks.

She was relieved that dinner seemed to be going so well. She was relieved that Tyra was obviously at ease with her presence, and didn't seem to harbor any ill will about what was happening on the childish fanpages of the internet. She seemed amused by it, in fact.

Also, Tyra was beautiful. She was stunningly beautiful. Rachel felt a little relieved about her appearance; it seemed too improbable that Xavier would be attracted to anyone but his own stunning wife. She had felt a pang of disappointment, but relief eventually overwhelmed it.

It was good. It would keep her from doing anything she shouldn't.

Rachel was relieved that Josh seemed to feel comfortable, too. He was even hitting it off with Tyra.

Xavier was making Rachel laugh at the dining table.

All was well for most of the evening.

She wasn't sure how the evening turned, on a dime.

She was laughing at Xavier's imitation of a man she had interviewed the day before. The guy had been eating a TV dinner when a driver, choking on a piece of beef jerky, drove into his living room.

"I was just eatin' them...you know, them Salisbury steaks, because I like them, and I had one bite left and then I *thought* somethin' started shakin', but you know it coulda been me," Xavier was declaring, imitating the man's very down-home black dialect perfectly. He leaned closer to Rachel, precisely as the old man had, and placed his hand next to his mouth. He lowered his voice. "You know *I do* get into the whiskey but it's the end of the month and I live on a pension, if you know what I mean, so that shakin', it may have coulda been my *own* hands."

Rachel laughed appreciatively for the good imitation. The man had been such a raconteur and made Rachel laugh so much it had taken almost an hour to get one minute of footage they could use.

Xavier stayed where he was, leaning close to her. A clean smell of soap or a light cologne was on his skin, and only now, with him next to her like this, could she smell it. Her mind drifted to an idea, and it unsettled her.

She tried to get it out of her mind, but Xavier remained close to her, saying nothing. An unusual smile was on his mouth.

The tension between them was suddenly palpable. Rachel knew she should feel more uncomfortable with it, especially because Tyra and Josh were in the kitchen choosing a wine, and they could come out any moment.

Still, those two were drinking wine, they seemed to be having a good time. Xavier was so close to her, and looking at her with what seemed to be desire.

Her mind drifted to her fantasies about Xavier again, and then she surprised herself very much by saying:

“I haven't seen the rest of the house, yet.”

Her voice sounded sultry. She heard it, and wished almost instantly that she could take it back. It was over the line.

But Xavier leaned back in his chair. His expression was more like he was impressed than shocked. “Okay,” he said, and his voice was quiet and serious.

Rachel's idea, which was little more than a gratuitous, flash-fantasy, fluttered through her mind again. Xavier would lead her down the hallway, and once they were out of sight of Josh and Tyra, he turn around. Overcome by his desire, he would pounce on her, pressing her to the wall, and then she would feel the heat of his body against her own. He would brush his lips over hers, and his cock would be hard against her inner thigh...

Xavier stood up.

Rachel felt the spectacular swing of mood that alcohol often gave her. The cheerful, a-okay mood of just moments before transformed to a sense of foreboding.

What was she doing? What had she just set in motion?

She stood up, though, and followed Xavier.

Her heart was racing, and she could feel sweat forming on her palms. A feeling of guilt was snaking through her: she had just done something over the line. What was she doing? With Josh in the next room? And Xavier's wife?

She stared at the muscles of back as he walked ahead of her. No matter how much she tried to think about how inappropriate this was, she found herself thinking instead about his toned arms, and how he could probably hold her up against the wall while he fucked her senseless.

“This is the guest room, which, if you want, you guys can stay in...and here is my favorite room...” he opened a door and turned on the light.

Rachel was so preoccupied with her thoughts that she didn't really see the room.

She was being ridiculous. Xavier was a man with a gorgeous wife, and he was, quite literally, taking her on a tour of his house. Nothing more.

“Nice,” she said vaguely.

Xavier looked at her, perplexed. “Like, 'nice, that it's here?'” He was shaking his head. “I thought this would be funnier to you.”

It was only then that she saw that the room was obscenely small, smaller than a lot of walk-in closets, and covered in Barbie-doll wallpaper.

“Oh god,” she said.

Xavier was looking at her now, though. He seemed to have stepped closer to her. “That's right,” he said. But his voice seemed quieter. He definitely moved closer now. There was not very much space between them at all. “What could Rachel Elliot be thinking about,” he said, and his voice was as low and sultry as hers had been when she asked for a tour of the house, “that makes her not notice an entire room covered in Barbie doll wallpaper?”

In her mind, a very lewd image developed of what she imagined Xavier looked like naked: dark, carved like a statue, his cock pulsing between his legs. She stopped breathing and willed her heart to cease its heavy beating against her chest.

She was shaking, but what it was that was making her tremble was unknown to her. Was she afraid? What was even going on here?

Xavier was definitely putting the moves on her.

And she definitely wasn't stopping him.

She should. She knew that.

She tried to open her mouth, or move her body, or try to do something to stop their bodies moving together.

“Oh,” she heard Tyra's voice in the dining room. “Looks like they've flown the coop.”

Tyra and Josh – her husband, her *husband* – were just ten feet away. Just around a corner.

“We're just down here,” she said, and her voice wobbled from her throat. Xavier moved back from her, but he kept his eyes locked on hers as

he smiled.

“Oh,” Tyra said, coming into the hallway. “You're taking a *tour*. In the dark.”

Her voice was lighthearted, but Rachel felt a stab of fear. An adrenaline-soaked thrill went through her body. Tyra turned on the hall light.

Rachel turned and moved to stand by Josh. She squeezed his hand. He looked at her, an expression of confusion on his face.

“We should probably get going soon, huh?” she said.

Tyra was standing by Xavier now. “You can have the guest room, if you want,” she said.

The four of them stood looking at each other. Xavier had a faint smile on his lips. Rachel was paralyzed. Tyra was grinning, and brought her wine glass to her lips.

Rachel was delighted when Josh shook his head. “No,” he said, and he sounded a little robotic. “I have...a thing tomorrow morning, I have a lot of work to do.”

Rachel hoped he didn't suspect anything was going here. He seemed not to.

And nothing was, after all.

She hadn't *done* anything.

She had only thought about it.

And looking at the spectacular shape of Tyra's body in her orange dress, she knew Josh had to have had at least one dirty thought in his own mind.

The pendulum of her mood swung again, and she felt released from her guilt. She squeezed Josh's hand.

She was turned on. She wanted to go home, have sex with her husband, and put this whole weird evening behind her.

11: DESSERT

Xavier and Tyra stood waving at them from the doorway as they got into the car.

Rachel was in good spirits. She tossed her head against the head rest and laughed as the car reversed. "They're so nice," she said. "They're so funny. I don't know what I was worried about."

Josh brushed from his mind another percolating image of Tyra leaning close to him, her dark nipples within reach of his fingers. Tyra had been *quite* friendly, and quite unperturbed about leaving Rachel and Xavier together in the dining room, alone, leaning ever-closer to each other.

Josh's mind reeled to process what Rachel said. "Uh...what...what were you worried about? You were worried about something?"

Rachel turned to him in disbelief.

"Are you serious?"

Might as well commit, Josh thought. Commit to ignorance.
"Uh...yes."

Rachel rolled her eyes. "Rachel Elliot wants some big black cock...Rachel Elliot is having an affair with her cameraman," she said, in a mocking voice. Then she waved her hands at the air as though she had something on display in front of her.

Ah, yes. The internet problems.

"Oh, *that*," Josh said, falling back down to reality.

"Am I the only one who is worried about how Xavier's wife would feel about a rumor like that?" Rachel asked, rhetorically.

Xavier's *wife*.

The words turned in Josh's head. Tyra's lips swarmed in front of his eyes. *Wife, wife, wife*.

The word "wife" made his cock throb. Thinking of his wife, of sharing her, of letting her slip away to "tour the house" with another man...he exhaled sharply to clear the lust and alcohol from his head and focus on driving.

The car fell silent, and Rachel stared out the window. She was lost in her own thoughts, and didn't seem to care if Josh picked up the conversation

where it left off.

Maybe because she was thinking of Xavier.

Josh mopped his brow with a napkin, grateful that Rachel seemed to take no notice. They drove home, lost in their own thoughts. Josh indulged the entire time in imagining his wife was thinking about Xavier. X-rated, filthy thoughts.

Of course she probably wasn't. But it didn't stop him fantasizing about it.

When they stepped through the door, he moved close behind Rachel and slid his hands over her hips and down to the center of her, between her legs. He knew his cock was against her, and she could feel it, and that she was probably going to squirm away from him. Perhaps angrily. This whole evening was so confusing to him. He felt a little guilty for enjoying the idea of his wife with Xavier so much. At the same time an irrational fear was sneaking through him. The fear that perhaps Rachel could read his dark thoughts, and she would tell him to sleep on the couch.

Instead, however, she pressed up against him. She let her head fall back against his shoulder, and did not impede his traveling hands.

She did not ask why he was so turned on. That was a good sign, wasn't it? A sign that she was too consumed by her own needs to ask what was going through his head? Maybe she was so preoccupied with her own private fantasies about Xavier that she wasn't even thinking of him. His cock pulsed at the thought.

She reached behind her and grabbed his tie. She began walking, pulling him with her down the hallway to the bedroom.

He was surprised by her hunger, but it matched his own so he went along with it. She struggled with his pants, laughing a little but quickly turning back to the sexy, serious self she rarely became.

When they reached the bedroom, she pulled his pants down, and surprised him further by falling to the floor with them. He stared at her as she grasped the fabric of his boxers with two hands and slid it over his ass.

His cock sprang loose: he had spent the entire evening with varying stages of erection, either because he was thinking of his wife with Xavier, or because Tyra had stood close to him and he imagined the weight of her breasts in his hands. In the moments since they had arrived home, Rachel's hungry attitude had brought him full-throttled heat.

She grasped his cock in her hand, and began to stroke the length of his shaft. She squeezed him hard, which was unusual: Rachel usually handled his cock like it was an expensive vase she didn't want to break. Now she was holding it fiercely, squeezing the length of it as she moved her hand up and down.

He stared at her, and was surprised to see her smile and open her mouth.

She took only his glans inside of her hot mouth at first, and sucked on it hard. He felt her tongue moving through suction, exploring the rivet around his head, sliding down the contours of his glans and then to the hole where precum was oozing into her mouth. He felt her tongue digging into him, as if she wanted more.

He had to close his eyes, the pleasure was so intense. He gasped, and then looked back down as she sucked to the end of his cock and gave a light smack as she back up to stroke him again.

She smiled up at him.

What had come over her? She never acted like this, not even when she was drunk.

She went for his cock again, this time lapping at the tip of him, teasing him, as though she were tasting a Popsicle, unsure of whether or not she liked the flavor.

He thought of Xavier again, of his fantasy of Rachel licking Xavier's cock instead of his own, and he felt a bead of precum squeeze from his head. Rachel swept it up with her tongue, and then made a trip around the sensitive ridge again, this time without taking him into her mouth. He longed to feel the full heat of her again, but she teased for what seemed like an eternity.

Finally, she guided his cock to her mouth with her hand wrapped tightly around the shaft.

Josh sucked in his breath as she plunged him inside of her mouth. He felt her lips slide to the usual depth, maybe three-quarters of the distance to the base of his cock. She pulled back, and slid up to the tip of him, and then went down on him again.

But when she reached the place she normally stopped, he felt her tug at his cock, and her lips began to slide further. She took him deeper into her mouth, past the hard ridge of the roof of her mouth. He felt her soft palate,

and a spasm as she gagged, but she kept going, until her throat and all of its silken wetness was swallowing him up.

He looked down, almost in disbelief, as her lips closed around the base of his cock. She was pressed against his pelvis now, and on the underside of his cock her lower lip was hot against his ball sack. He could feel her spit-covered chin against him.

“Oh god,” he said involuntarily.

He felt another twist in her mouth, and a choked sound came from her throat. But it was Rachel who was holding herself there, Rachel who was forcing herself to take his entire cock.

He liked the sound of her gagging.

And he liked the idea, an idea that was snaking around in the shadows of his mind, that Rachel was behaving like this because she felt guilty.

Or maybe she wanted to practice.

Or maybe she just wanted to be a dirty slut.

Any way he sliced it, he knew he shouldn't be as turned on as he was, but he couldn't help it.

She began to bob up and down on his cock again, and she looked up at him. Her eyes were watering, and her mouth was filled with his shaft.

It was incredible. He should have just focused on how incredible of a blowjob his wife was giving him.

But he couldn't help think that her mouth could be even fuller. He couldn't help but imagine what it would look like, if a bigger cock were inside of it. How she would gag if there was an even longer prick probing her throat...

He felt a surge of cum threatening to burst, and he jerked his head up at the ceiling in an effort to slow his orgasm. He didn't want this to be over just yet.

But looking at the ceiling only allowed him to fill his head with even more filthy images of his wife and Xavier.

Jesus.

He reached down and grasped her hair, pushing off rather than pulling her toward his cock.

Then he noticed that she had her hand beneath her skirt. It was twisted at an odd angle, and it was clear she was fingering herself.

“Come in my mouth,” she said, pulling on his cock.

Josh inhaled sharply. He had longed for his wife to be such a dirty talker, and to say something like this, for ages.

But what had come over her?

Xavier?

He felt this thought, rather than turning him off, only make him more wild. He changed the force of his hand, and pushed Rachel back onto his cock. This time he pushed her head deep onto him, something he had never done.

The rush of the sensation, the feeling of pushing on the shape of a human head and having his cock swallowed into the wet, sticky heat of her throat, was already threatening to send him over the edge. But then he let himself imagine Xavier doing this same thing, with his fingers worked into his wife's hair, pulling her up and down his long shaft, gagging her with his meat, and his climax erupted violently. The pool of cum that had coiled at the base of his cock sprang forward.

Rachel always pulled away and let his cum splash somewhere on the carpet or the floor, on those rare occasions when she gave him head.

This time, though, she moaned with her own climax, and her throat remained closed around his cock. The moan warbled around his cock as his cum surged forward and filled her throat.

Her eyes were closed, and he had to hold her to him. But she wasn't pulling away hard, and he felt her spasming throat drink him up.

He wondered, as she let him fill her up, if she was thinking about her husband...or about someone else.

12: BREAKING NEWS

“Another shit assignment.” Rachel indulged in leaning her head back on the headrest. She didn't care, anymore, if her hair got messed up.

The assignment wasn't all that terrible: some kids were building a scale-model solar system on a rancher's property, and it turned out he had nearly been selected for a space flight, so he was more than happy to help them out. Blah blah, human interest.

Xavier took a long drink of water. Rachel found herself watching his Adam's apple, and then letting her eyes drop further down his chest. She blinked deliberately and looked out her own window.

She needed to get herself together. Xavier hadn't acted strange or mentioned the dinner or the hallway. And that was good.

She had thought about him that night, and she felt guilty about it. She was almost sheepish when she arrived at work and saw him. Sheepish because she had sucked her husband's cock in a lewd and pornographic way, and imagined the whole time that she was sucking up Xavier. She had even let Josh fill her mouth with his bitter cum, and she hadn't gagged at it like she usually did, because she had been thinking of swallowing Xavier's cock. Pleasing him. Giving him an incredible blowjob.

Oh god. She was really losing it.

So she had busied herself complaining loudly about her assignments for the day. Talking about politics and anything else non-sexual she could think of.

“What do you want anyway? City Hall?” Xavier asked, in answer to her question.

She paused to make sure she didn't reveal her real thoughts, and say, “your cock.”

“Something like that,” she said.

What she seemed to want was a very naughty thing.

Xavier shook his head. “Just as boring. 'Mayor cut ribbon on new development.' 'Mayor gave speech at Rotary Club Fundraiser.' 'City Council had meeting and got nothing done.' 'Council has no response to the eternal question, why are there so many potholes on 8th avenue?’”

Rachel closed her eyes. She didn't like how Xavier was making her feel. Cheering her up. Making her smile. Making her want to press her hands against his chest and see if it was, in fact, as smooth as it seemed.

"Better than, 'duck crosses road,'" she said. Her voice was sour but she had to work at it. "I just...really want to do something serious."

Xavier shrugged. "It's all the same."

"You're a cameraman, though," Rachel protested. "It *is* all the same to you. Nobody knows who you are. Nobody makes stupid blogs about you."

"Excuse me," Xavier said. "I am a camera *artiste*. And last I checked..." His eyes went up and down Rachel's body. It was such a deliberate, groping look, that Rachel almost didn't believe it happened. "People *are* writing about me," he finished.

Rachel felt herself blush. Xavier's eyes moving over her body had left her tingling. She stepped hard on what she felt inside, but there was no denying that she felt it: desire. There was no denying to herself that she liked Xavier's eyes taking a long drink of her.

There was a moment of silence, and Rachel felt something clawing inside of her chest. Her breath was caught in her throat, and she found herself completely speechless. He was looking at her, and she could read the attraction in his eyes. Did he know what she thinking as well? Did he read the fantasies she had in the unsteadiness of her gaze?

"We have a solar system to film," she finally said. Her voice sounded unsure of itself.

"We do," Xavier agreed, but he didn't move. He gave her a wry smile.

There was no denying to herself that she wanted to do something very, very bad. Her eyes were fluttering almost maniacally between Xavier's lips and his eyes. Her mind was fluttering between thought of affection and thoughts of his cock. She felt like a crazy person.

She looked forward and exhaled.

"Am I making you nervous, Rachel Elliot?" Xavier said.

There was no mistaking that he was coaxing her with that voice of his. This wasn't a neutral question, and it wasn't even phrased to be deniable later.

It was just like the hallway.

Xavier was making a move.

And she sort of wanted him to.

She didn't, because she didn't want to be unfaithful.

But she sort of did.

No, she really did.

And now it was happening.

“Oh god,” Rachel said helplessly. She closed her eyes. Maybe the whole situation would go away if she just kept her eyes closed.

She could feel, though, almost like heat, that Xavier was not looking away. He wasn't going to let her off the hook. She could feel that he was still staring at her, boring into her with his eyes.

And what would it feel like to have a man like that look at her with that same intensity while his magnificent body pressed her into the sheets and his cock filled her until it hurt?

Rachel snapped her eyes open. She looked at Xavier. Sure enough, he was still staring at her.

“I'm married,” she whispered. “I'm..you're...you're married, this is...” she struggled to think of the word. Wrong? Right? Hot?

“Inappropriate,” she finished lamely.

Xavier laughed. It was a controlled laugh, small and short.

“Inappropriate, huh?” He pressed his lips together.

Rachel was helpless, she would tell herself later, as Xavier reached out his hand and brushed it over the bare skin on her knee. His touch sent a wave of excitement along the inside of her thigh and the back of her knee, and she felt goosebumps burst to life on her neck and her shoulders. Just from his fingertips over her knee.

“It's up to you how inappropriate it is, Ray.”

Another moment of holding her gaze. She was paralyzed. She was sure she wasn't even breathing.

The sound of the door handle opening cracked through her trance. As though nothing were happening in the car, Xavier looked ahead. “Well. Let's go get these planets filmed.” He smiled, and turned back to her. “Want some advice?”

He paused, and she felt her heart turning to liquid inside of her chest.

“Talk about Pluto. It's controversial.”

He left the car.

When she started breathing, it came in ragged puffs. Rachel stared at the windshield. Whatever had transpired between them had left a light film of steam on the glass.

She brushed her hair from her forehead and found it damp.

Jesus.

She barely made it through her takes, and she barely remembered what she had said to the smiling, proud kids and the old man who was helping them build a solar system model to scale on his giant farm. Pluto had been the size of a grain of sand, she remembered that.

She and Xavier didn't really speak on the way back to the station. She wasn't sure how to take it. The silence wasn't uncomfortable for him: she could see that. He made a few jokes. He pointed out an ugly dog in a tutu.

Everything, in fact, seemed so normal with him that it almost infuriated her.

Had she imagined what he had said?

Had she read more into it than was there?

Her knee felt the ghost of his touch, and a shiver traveled over her much as it had before.

No, he definitely touched her. He definitely touched her knee and it definitely meant something to touch a woman's knee. *Like that.*

He went to the editing room to drop off his footage, and she went to the office she half-shared with Melissa Wagner, a part-time non-camera reporter. Melissa wasn't there, and Rachel found herself struggling to waft through the piles of human-interest nonsense she was supposed to provide an opinion to Arthur about (not that he would listen to what she said, which wasn't helping her enthusiasm or her focus).

But it wasn't Arthur who was distracting her.

She could feel the hard ache of desire between her legs. She didn't like it; she didn't want to feel it. She knew she was treading in dangerous waters with her marriage, and that was the last thing she wanted to do.

She couldn't deny to herself, though, that Xavier's touch was thrilling.

She also couldn't deny that when she had seen Tyra, in all of her ethereal beauty, her heart had taken a dive for the floor. She had felt embarrassment and disappointment wash over her, standing there on the steps of Xavier's house. His wife was far too beautiful, and far too...in possession of herself...for Xavier to be even momentarily distracted by a girl like Rachel.

Her disappointment had healed over quickly, turned into relief. She had been harboring silly thoughts about Xavier. Dangerous thoughts. And

now she could put them away, dismiss them as ridiculous, childish fantasies, and not have to worry about anything ever happening with them.

Then, today had happened. And Rachel could not deny that she felt a swell of pleasure that Xavier could be interested in her. Even though his wife was so beautiful.

It's up to you how inappropriate it is, Ray.

Rachel shivered, and tried to concentrate on her task. She would be here forever if she didn't.

At nine o'clock, she realized that time had escaped her. She had been reading the sludge of stories on her desk but understanding nothing, thinking about Xavier and then Josh, playing out sensual fantasies and nightmarish consequences, for two hours without actually reading a single story on her desk. She sighed. She would have to come in early tomorrow or Arthur would ream her.

Then she gave the papers a swirl with her hand. Did it really matter? She found herself smiling, and Xavier's devious nature whispering in her ear. Why the hell would she spend her time actually thinking about any of this?

She grabbed three leads at random and tucked them in her purse. She'd make a case for them tomorrow and not worry about it.

She walked down the hallway smugly.

Everyone on her floor had left. The lights were all still on, as they always were, because it was unusual that no one at all was left behind, working.

When the male figure stepped out of the stairwell behind her, she knew it was Xavier. She knew without looking back. He said nothing, and she kept walking, pretending not to have noticed it was him. The presence of his body behind her raised the hairs on her skin with a static charge. She could feel it from the narrow spine of her ankles, along her calves, in the fold where her ass met her legs, curled up in her lower back, breathing on her neck. Her heart began to beat faster as he quickened his step, ever-so-slightly, to catch up to her.

"Hmm. You *don't* even look to see who's behind you," he said.

Rachel felt a shiver travel through her. There was no denying, no denying to herself, that she was attracted to him. That he turned her to jelly.

This was very, very bad. She knew it was bad.

Flustered, she turned around and waved her hand at him, palm forward.

He stepped closer to her, though. “That could be very dangerous, Rachel. You never know who could be up here.”

Rachel felt heat traveling up her neck. Xavier was moving ever-closer to her, and she wanted to move away from him – she knew she was supposed to move away from him – but she felt like her feet had turned to lead.

“Or what ideas they might get,” Xavier said. His voice was low. They were alone in the hallway.

Rachel willed herself to say:

“Xavier,” and she meant to keep going, and say “this is inappropriate,” but her voice failed her and that was all she managed to whisper.

He moved closer to her, and now his mouth was just millimeters away from her lips. He appeared to have not even registered what she said.

Or care.

And though she knew she should move away, press the elevator button, get out of here...she couldn't help wondering what he was insinuating by *what ideas they might get*.

Part of her wanted those ideas to consist of pushing her up against the wall, lifting her with his two strong arms, and filling her full of cock right there.

His lips were so close to hers she could almost taste them.

Rachel felt a stab of pleasure reach up from her quivering pussy to her chest, raking at her insides like a wild animal.

So far, you haven't done anything.

She pulled her head away. “This is a bad idea,” she managed to say.

Xavier seemed to expect this. He cocked his head and smiled. “Why's that?”

Rachel held her hand up. “We're married. You're...I'm married. You're married.”

She was babbling, and she hated how flustered she was.

“It's not a problem for me. Tyra and I have an understanding.”

Rachel couldn't help but put her hand to her mouth to cover her look of shock. This made Xavier smile in amusement.

“You're...swingers?” Rachel whispered.

Xavier mocked Rachel's expression. "You're *not* swingers?" he said, imitating her voice.

Rachel dropped her hand. "Sorry," she said. "I mean, it's just..."

"Just what?" He was looking at her again, his face serious and his expression disarming. Rachel couldn't stop herself from squirming.

"Just...surprising," she said. She shook her head, as if she wanted to erase what she said. "I don't know. I've never met anyone who..."

"Oh I'm sure you have," Xavier said. He leaned closer, or maybe it just seemed that way to Rachel. "What you haven't met, is someone who propositioned you with the idea."

It felt as though he had somehow found a way to reach inside of her and stroke her insides. She was so uncomfortable with the feeling inside of her that she had to move her body. She shifted from one foot to another and shook her hands. "That's not...I mean..."

Xavier had moved closer to her yet again. "You don't think about it all?"

She felt the rush of blood that colored her cheeks and she felt like closing her eyes in mortification, but she forced herself to keep looking at him.

"Because *I* do," he said.

He retreated slightly, but he was still within inches of her. She could feel the heat of his body, and she had to fight with her fingers to keep them from reaching out to feel the contours of his chest. Or lower. To find out what she didn't want to admit that she wanted to know: what his cock felt like, hard and heavy in her hand. What the bristle on his jaw would feel like, dragging along her inner thigh.

She was breathing in ragged, uneven gasps. She couldn't move her body, and the parts of her that were moving were not obeying any command from her higher reasoning.

A stream of incoherent syllables came from her mouth. She managed to form the word "Josh."

Xavier put his arm up on the wall behind her, and the dark heat of his muscled bicep seemed to radiate into her face. She felt the fine hair on her neck rise as though a balloon were being rubbed against her skin. The shiver traveled across her back and down her right arm.

And lower.

Xavier was very close now. So close that she could feel his thighs brush against her legs. His chest was close enough to her that her nipples were caressed by the friction of their shirts. She thought she felt the shape of his cock, hard, against one of her thighs as she moved, and it sent a shudder through her.

“So it's Josh,” Xavier said.

He nodded, though it was not the nod of a man who was conceding anything. It was the nod of a man who was accepting a challenge.

Rachel felt like she had been turned to a liquid from the inside out. There was no longer anything holding her up. She was going to disintegrate.

“You know, you'd be surprised what a lot of men might do if you just talk to them about it.”

He pushed himself away abruptly, and pressed his lips together.

“You might just have a talk with him,” Xavier said.

He slid his backpack, which he had been holding in one hand, over one shoulder. Rachel was still pressed against the wall, because if she stepped away from it she felt sure she was going to crumble.

He pressed the elevator button.

Xavier gave her a mock salute. “See you tomorrow, Rachel Elliot.” He turned and strode back down the hallway. “I always take the stairs,” he explained, as she stared after him.

Rachel let the elevator come and go, and waited a good ten minutes before she pressed the button again. She rushed to her car. She wanted to put as much distance between the scene that had just unfolded and herself as possible.

She wasn't thinking. Thought – rational thought – had been cut off completely since Xavier stepped toward her. The only thing happening in her mind was a replay of the scene, over and over again. The feel of his body, just out of reach. The guilt and longing, braided together and writhing in her chest.

His smug fucking look as he left.

She shook her head. “Talk to him?” she muttered, in a fierce whisper. She started the car and backed out much too fast.

Who just talked to her husband about...about what? What would a woman even say? I want to have an affair, is that okay with you?

Please.

She almost got sideswiped by a car as she pulled into traffic. She drove blindly for a few blocks, but when the car behind her honked because she was sitting through a red light, she knew she had to pull over. She turned on a residential street and sat in the car, parked on the curb.

Her pulse was still racing.

You know, you'd be surprised what a lot of men might do if you just talk to them about it.

He wasn't serious.

No. He *was* serious, because he wanted to fuck her. Naturally. He would say anything, just like all men would say anything. She, Rachel, was the crazy person here, because she was actually taking the idea seriously.

The idea that she could talk to her husband about having an affair.

With Xavier.

She tried to make herself feel indignant and frustrated. She tried very hard to talk herself in to outrage. How dare he?

All that.

But there was no denying that a bubble of thrill was filling up inside of her.

Xavier wanted to fuck *her*.

13: SWINGERS

Josh knew Rachel had something she wanted to tell him.

When she had something to tell, she twisted her fork more than usual. If she wasn't eating, she twisted her hair.

She was maniacally doing both, and scrunching up her nose for no one – because she was having a conversation about her secret with herself, in her own mind.

He felt another sweep of pleasing jealousy, and longing, and fear. The three traveled together now, playing off each other, ricocheting inside his mind and body. Sometimes he felt sick, sometimes he felt high.

He sliced a piece of chicken and grinned. “So? What's the gossip?”

Rachel immediately dropped her hands to her lap. She knew her tells, but she was powerless to stop herself from doing them.

Josh felt himself begging the universe that whatever she was about to say had something to do with Xavier.

She started twisting a strand of her hair with two hands. She bit her lip. Josh felt a flush of attraction in its most simple form wash over him. His wife was adorable. She didn't even mean to be.

“Okay,” she said, suddenly, turning toward him with her eyes lit up with a strange energy. She reached one hand out and tapped her finger on the back of his hand. “You know how I was all worried, you know, about Tyra and Xavier, and Tyra being mad about...you know.”

Josh nodded. Inside his abdomen excitement was writhing like a nest of snakes. He waited patiently for her to continue.

“So it turns out...they're...there's no reason to even worry about it. Because...Xavier told me this just today...” she paused. An odd look came over her face, almost like she wasn't sure of she should keep talking.

“Told you what?”

She bit her lip again, and lowered her voice as though they were in a public place and someone might overhear.

“They're...so they're...swingers.”

Josh's mouth fell open a little. It took a moment for the words to get through his head, and register.

And then it felt his mind blooming with ideas. He felt his cock shake to life.

Swingers.

The hair on the back of his neck prickled to life.

Swingers.

“No shit,” he said calmly.

He turned to his chicken and began to slice it again into minute pieces.

He knew Rachel was looking at him. But with what expression?

What did Rachel think about this news?

Surely not the same thing he did.

He watched his hands using the fork and knife to slice his chicken to smithereens. A new discomfort was wedging itself into him, and he couldn't figure out where it came from.

He looked up.

“And, how is it you ended up on this topic?” he said. When he began the question, he had meant for it to sound like mere curiosity. Once it started to leave his mouth, however, it took on a more accusatory tone.

After all: how *had* they ended up on that topic?

He watched Rachel's face. He didn't like that he wasn't able to read her expression. That many different feelings played out on her face, and she was so evidently trying to hide them.

She finally shrugged, and her shrug struck a dagger right through his chest.

Below the table, though, his cock was registering excitement. Filling up with it, in fact.

“I don't know,” Rachel said. “We just...got on it.”

Was her voice just a little casual? Did it contain a layer of guilt?

He looked at her face. It *did*.

Josh took up his fork and knife and cut some more chicken. It was now turning to a shredded mass on his plate. “How *does* one just 'get on' the topic of swinging, I wonder?”

Inside of his own mind, he was shaking his head at himself. What the hell was he doing? He wasn't even as defensive as he was acting. He was turned on. In the far corners of his mind, he was even playing out a fantasy in which Rachel and Xavier were wrapped around each other. So why did his voice sound the way it did? Why was he saying the things he was saying and shredding his chicken?

Rachel stabbed her chicken with her fork. Her guilt turned to something else.

“Well,” she said icily, “we were fucking in the back of the van, and I was like, 'oh, what about your wife,' and he was like, 'don't worry, we're swingers.’”

She took a bite out her chicken.

Josh was taken a little aback. It wasn't like Rachel to make this kind of joke. Was she doing it because she was annoyed with him? Or was she doing it because she felt guilty...guilty the way Josh did, about having the thoughts he had been having? Was she having the same kind of thoughts?

He was curious. More curious than he was interested in salvaging the evening.

So, where he would ordinarily have said: “Yeah, okay, I deserved that,” and they would have laughed immediately and decided to open a bottle of wine, he instead had the urge to say:

“Oh. So how often do you two fuck in the back of the van?”

Rachel paused, obviously not expecting this reply.

Josh half-wished he could take it back, and part of his mind was careening around, looking for a way to turn it into a joke.

Rachel pressed her lips together, dropped her cutlery, and folded her arms. “This was the first time,” she said, hotly. “Usually, we fuck in the boardroom.”

Now it was Josh's turn to be caught off guard. He wondered, if like him, Rachel was now sorry for taking things too far. If she also wanted a way out of this “joke,” but didn't know what to do.

Or maybe she was serious.

Or maybe, like him, she was partly joking and partly serious: part of her wanted to stop this duel of verbal dares, and part of her wanted to see where it went?

“So? Is the 'bbc' all it's cracked up to be?” Josh lifted a glass of water to his lips, in part to hide his discomfort, in part to give his runaway mouth something else to do.

Rachel's eyes widened, and then they narrowed.

And then she leaned back over her plate, and began to cut her chicken calmly. She smiled.

And said nothing.

Josh set his water down.

He knew he should shut up now. The “joke” had somehow gone too far. Even though he had been craving this very scenario, it felt derailed somehow.

And at the same time, Rachel's coy smile was making his cock rock-hard beneath the table.

She was still smiling. She wriggled in her chair. Josh had a hard time deciding if she was feeling triumphant for having won a silly marital showdown, or if she was actually smiling, thinking of a big, black cock.

Xavier's big black cock.

This is why, quite unauthorized, his mouth must have kept moving.

“Is that a 'yes'?”

His tone was almost desperate, though what kind of desperation it was, he couldn't be sure. Desperation to hear her say “yes,” or desperation to hear her say “no?”

Rachel rolled her eyes skyward. “Okay. That's enough. Stop acting like an idiot, Joshua.”

Josh's face was hot. His cock was painfully hard. His mind was offering up image after image of his wife's mouth getting closer to the tip of Xavier's cock, opening for him, licking the tip of him.

Rachel looked at him. She gave an expression of disdain. “You. Are. Serious. Oh my god.” She stood up, grabbing her plate. She spun around, headed for the sink.

“Rachel,”

She held up her free hand.

“Okay,” Josh exhaled. “That got out of hand, I'm sorry. But you still haven't answered my question. How *did* you get on the topic of swinging with Xavier?”

Rachel set her plate down. She turned around. Her mouth was open for a pithy reply, but she seemed to have thought better of it and forgotten to close her lips.

She folded her arms again.

“I don't know,” she said simply. “I don't have any idea.”

She was a little angry, and instead of making Josh feel bad, it only turned him on a little more.

And again, he felt one of the many feelings inside of him go into free-fall, while another was buoyed.

Of course she was telling the truth. Of course it made sense, if one wasn't having an affair with a coworker, to not remember how a topic like this came up. It wasn't impossible for it to have happened, especially with everything that was going on on the internet.

Yet, there was also the possibility that Rachel just wanted it all to look like that. She wanted him to believe that she was just innocently stumbling into conversations about swinging, when in fact she had brought the topic up because there was something she wanted.

Something dark.

Something black.

Something other than her husband.

Exasperated, presumably because Josh had disappeared into his own thoughts for too long, Rachel turned and walked out of the kitchen with a sigh. "I really don't know," she muttered, but this was not in reference to how her conversation with Xavier started. She often said this, or a version of this, in reference to Josh. He had a tendency to space out and start thinking, leaving a conversation and leaving Rachel stranded by herself. It aggravated her, and they'd had more than one fight about it. But like so many things in marriage, they had made an uneasy peace with it: she would mutter and walk out of the room, and then he would go and apologize.

Only now, he had other things on his mind.

14: THE CONVERSATION

Her heart was pounding as she stomped out of the kitchen.

Josh could really be a horse's ass sometimes. She wondered if he had Asperger's, at moments like this.

She railed about it for a while, locked in the bathroom, where she sat on the toilet lid fully clothed. The bathroom door was the only one that locked.

What had just happened in the kitchen?

She tried to replay the conversation, and make sense of it, but she was having a hard time. It had gone...well, south...so fast and so unexpectedly, that she wasn't sure at all if she was angry, if Josh was angry, or if the opposite had happened.

She hadn't expected this reaction.

She could feel her heart inside her chest. She felt guilty. She felt...what did she feel?

Was it disappointment? Had she wanted the conversation to go differently, as in, for Josh to say: "Oh, how interesting. I've always wanted to be a swinger, I think we should try it, and you should try it first with your hot black co-worker, Xavier."

She bit her lip. That was ridiculous, but there was a small part of her - Scratch that. A large part of her - that actually did want for that to have happened.

She looked at the ceiling.

Was that really what she wanted?

She shook her head and closed her eyes.

This would all end badly, wouldn't it? Affairs never ended well. And she didn't actually want to do this, did she? She didn't want to jeopardize anything with Josh. It wasn't like she wanted to run off with Xavier. It wasn't like she was fantasizing about anything but...sex.

Right?

She searched her thoughts, treading carefully, almost like spying on herself. Was she fantasizing about something more than sex?

She liked Xavier. There was no denying that. He was a good friend, a fun wing-man. A lot of what she found sexy about him had nothing to do

with his...body. Did that mean that she wanted something more from him? Something deeper?

A knock on the door interrupted her thoughts.

She had no idea what to say.

It wasn't as if Josh didn't know she was in there.

She knew what she *wanted* to say.

She wanted to say something to let him know she was sorry. She wished she could take back the whole scene in the kitchen.

"I'm sorry," Josh said first. "That was...out of line."

You know, you'd be surprised what a lot of men might do if you just talk to them about it.

Isn't that what they were supposed to do in a marriage? Talk about things? Wouldn't it be the most honest thing to do just that?

She pictured herself opening the door, and admitting the whole truth to Josh.

But what *was* the whole truth?

"Honey?" Josh sighed. "Please open the door."

She drummed her fingers on her arms.

She reached from the toilet to the door, an easy feat in their small bathroom, and pulled on the handle to unlock it. She had time to get her hands back on her arms before Josh entered the bathroom. She wanted to let him know she was still mad.

But was she mad? Was he mad? She felt like she was acting out an empty shell of anger. Like she was doing and saying things because she felt she "should," not necessarily because she really felt them.

They stared at each other.

"Okay -" they both said, at exactly the same time. It made them laugh.

Rachel felt her anger breaking apart. She really loved Josh, and a moment like this reminded her of the feeling.

"You first," Josh said.

Rachel felt her nose scrunching up. She hated that it almost seemed out of her control. She didn't want to always use what she knew to be "cute" to get her way, but she also knew that she did, in fact, make use of it. Subconsciously or not, she knew that her nose-wrinkling softened Josh up.

Josh, and a lot of other men.

“Okay,” she exhaled. “I’m sorry, too. I guess I just got offended because...it seemed like you were accusing me of something...”

As she was talking, she felt tears well up in her eyes. Uncontrollably. It was only at that moment that she realized how hypocritical she was being. Something *had*, after all, happened with Xavier. She *had* let him get close to her, let him think that he could get closer...and she liked it.

She looked at Josh and tried to blink away her tears.

“Okay. Okay, look. I have to tell you something. I didn’t...it isn’t like what you’re thinking, nothing has ever been going on between me and Xavier, not before...” her voice ended in a shaky inhale and she found herself unable to keep talking.

Josh was still.

“What happened?” he said. His voice was only a whisper.

Rachel looked at the wall. On it was a painting they had bought at the beach in Mexico on their honeymoon. It was blurry and clear, streaked by her tears. The feeling of their honeymoon, and what they had shared, swelled up inside of her and she realized she couldn’t tell him the whole truth.

Even if there was nothing there.

Her head was spinning. Maybe she should tell him the truth...after all, nothing had *happened*. She hadn’t *kissed* Xavier.

She had just let him stand really, really close to her.

She had just masturbated in the bathroom thinking of him.

But that was all. That was all still technically not over the line, right?

Josh was waiting for her answer, and she knew the longer she waited to answer him, the less like the truth her answer would be, even if she spat out the entire truth. She needed to say something, quick.

Maybe she could tell half of the truth.

She started talking, just to get something out.

“I...look, the conversation came up...because...I don’t know. I spend a lot of time with Xavier. You know. We sit around in the car together and...he was just being sympathetic, I don’t even know how it came up. I felt bad still, I was just saying I felt bad because this stuff on the internet is...you know, it affects his wife. I said something about that...one thing led to another...I don’t know.”

Josh put his hands in his pockets. He looked up at the ceiling and sighed.

She knew Josh was unlikely to have forgotten that she had, only minutes ago, told him she had something to tell him.

So she was confused when, instead of returning to the topic, he tipped his head to level and said: "I'm sorry. I...the whole conversation was out of line."

Rachel stared at him.

She wasn't sure how to react. Her body was still ready for a fight, or at least an argument. Outrage and guilt, in equal parts, were coursing through her. She wasn't ready to just say, "okay," and end the conversation.

She closed her eyes. This happened all the time, didn't it? She had heard on a radio show that women have a lingering physical reaction to fights. They stay physically angry longer, which is why they keep fighting long after the argument is resolved. Bringing up things that happened years ago. Trying to explain to their mind why their body was still mad.

She had found this insightful, but not very practical to know. She couldn't calm herself down so easily.

Still, it would be best if this argument ended.

She had no idea if she was mad at Josh, or herself, or even, in a way, Xavier.

She had no idea what her feelings were.

Thoughts about Xavier intruded at that moment, and the whole scene at the station played out in her mind again, this time ending differently. This time with Xavier's lips pressed against hers. She felt the hardness of his cock against her thigh again.

Suddenly her blood was racing.

She opened her eyes. "Let's just have sex, and forget about it."

Josh's eyes opened in surprise. But when she looked down at his pants, she saw he was more than interested. A vague concern floated through her head: why was he so turned on at this particular moment? But it disappeared just as quickly.

She reached out, and grabbed him by the belt, pulling him to her. She unbuckled him, and pulled down his pants and boxers. She was pleased when he sprang from his pants, hard as a rock, the tip of his cock wet with precum.

Again, her mind chose to consider why this was. It was so unusual for him.

But just as quickly as before, this intrusive thought was pushed out by flashbacks of Xavier.

It was so wrong, she thought, to be thinking this kind of thing while she was with her husband.

She grasped Josh's cock in her hand, squeezing him tightly and pulling on his shaft to milk more precum from his cock. She looked up at him, and saw that he was surprised. His mouth was open, though, with disbelieving arousal.

She slid down to the bathroom floor, and smiled at his disbelief.

She didn't often go down on him. Not anymore, anyway. But now, it seemed kind of fun. She made a wet circle around the ribbed edge of his glans, and delighted in how a shudder rippled through him. She trailed her tongue through the groove in his head, right to the bitter, wet center, where his precum pearled at the tip of her tongue.

She did this again, but this time with her eyes closed.

Guilt poured into her bloodstream when she realized that as she was licking the long, hard length of her husband's cock, she was thinking of someone else. Imagining, in vivid detail, what Xavier's cock would feel like under her tongue. How it would bump in different places, taste like something else, and be heavier and thicker in her hand.

But the guilt did an odd thing as it coursed through her: it only enticed her more. It was so *wrong* to be thinking of another man, but it also wasn't *really* wrong.

She wasn't, after all, really *doing* anything.

She could feel herself getting wet, though, not because she was sucking on cock but because she was imagining sucking a different cock than her husband's. Just like before, when they had come home from dinner at Tyra and Xavier's, she could feel an urgency unlike any she had felt before. She wanted to have her throat filled with cock, feel the cum as it filled the base of his cock, then taste it as he burst inside of her.

And her mind wanted to imagine this was all for someone else.

She lowered her head and placed her lips on his balls. She sucked the loose skin into her mouth, and nibbled very lightly at it. Josh sucked in his breath. She made a circle around the base of his shaft, twisting her neck to do so and then dragging her tongue along the length of it to the tip again. She massaged his cock with her hand.

She opened her mouth and guided Josh's cock to her, to her throat, opening up for him. Josh's surprise was gone, and he was looking down at her as she bobbed her head over his knob. She took him as deeply as she could, enjoying the sensation at the back of her throat. She closed her eyes as his body stiffened, and she could feel his ejaculation winding up like a spring inside of him. He placed his hand on the back of her head, and she felt another surge of guilty pleasure. He never did this, it was more like something she imagined Xavier doing. Taking control of her, pushing her further down his shaft, filling her up.

The pleasure was so dirty, the guilt such a rush, that she was sure she needed no more than to rub her clit quickly a few times to come.

But should she feel guilty? It was only she who knew that she was so turned on because, in some dark corner of her mind, she was letting herself believe that she was practicing.

Practicing for Xavier.

She readied herself for his load, ready to swallow again, for only the second time in their marriage.

But Josh suddenly withdrew from her throat, and lifted her by the hair. He spun her around with uncharacteristic force. It only turned her on more, only let her believe her own fantasies more readily. This is surely how Xavier would fuck.

Josh pushed her against the wall, over the toilet, and shoved her skirt up and over her hips. He jerked on her panties, winding them around his fist. The material cut into her slash, rubbing against her engorged clit. She gasped, as much from discomfort as pleasure, and he pulled on them again. He used her underwear to position her body, lifting her until she was on her tiptoes.

She felt the tip of his shaft against her, slipping around in the folds of her skin. She was drenched. The head of his cock slid from side to side, and then finally found its mark. Josh thrust himself deep into her, and pulled on her underwear to slam her against his pelvis.

Both of them seemed to be overcome by something. Josh hammered himself into her in five hard, almost demonic thrusts. She came somewhere in the middle of this, and her hands slipped from the wall and onto the back of the toilet. The lid ground on the porcelain and her head slapped against the wall as Josh finished himself off, almost violently.

She felt his cum bursting inside of her, and he jerked her body toward him for his final thrusts. Holding her against his body with his hand on her throat.

They were both soaked through their clothing with sweat. They stood, panting. Josh's cock was still inside of her, still hard. The mingled cum was running down her legs. She closed her eyes, indulging for one final moment in her very bad fantasy, which, even though she had come, had not faded from her mind.

Then she looked in the mirror. She saw herself, hair stuck to her face with sweat, clothes in disarray.

The reality was, she was a good wife. She had done all of this with her husband.

The image of the two of them, though, disturbed her. Herself, because she knew what she was thinking.

And Josh, because his eyes were distant.

The two of them were not entirely in the room together.

They disentangled, awkwardly, and Rachel slid her underwear down.

“That was a new...trick,” she said.

Josh looked confused for a second, his mind obviously miles away.

Rachel took off her dress. “I guess I'll take a shower now,” she said.

Josh met her mouth with a deep kiss after she lifted her dress from her body. “That was fun,” he said.

She smiled, and agreed.

But in the shower, with her eyes closed, she could not help thinking: what was it on Josh's mind while they had sex that night?

Was he, like her, thinking of someone else?

And how could she be angry about it, when she had taken his cock into her mouth, thinking about another man?

She turned the water on scalding hot and tried to push the thoughts out of her mind. Did it matter? Everyone was free to *think* whatever they wanted.

It was only a problem if someone acted on it.

Right?

She wondered how in the hell Tyra and Xavier made a thing like this work.

15: THE AUCTION

Josh wiped his eyes with two hands, trying to brush away the grogginess he felt. After a long night of not sleeping, turning dark and beautiful and ugly thoughts over and over in his mind, he had fallen asleep at 5am. Rachel had shaken him awake at seven, asking him if he had forgotten all about the all-day fund-raising event for breast cancer.

“Of course not,” he had answered.

But he had, of course.

Now he was seated on an uncomfortable, convention-type type seat, nearly three hours into the event, with many more, apparently to go. He vaguely remembered being dragged to the same event the year before, and that it was long, alcohol-free, and long.

So far, there seemed to be little reason for Rachel to be here. But Josh was doing his best to prop up his face into a supportive and enthusiastic expression. After all of the weird thoughts that had gone on in his head lately, and all of the weird interactions with his wife, he had decided to be on his best behavior where at all possible.

“Oh god,” Rachel's face fell suddenly. “Oh god. Oh god, I totally forgot about this.”

Josh turned to his wife, whose face was getting paler with each passing second. She turned to him helplessly. “Oh no.” She started shaking her head.

Josh cocked his head. He felt awake for the first time in hours. Something interesting was finally happening. “What's up?”

He felt concerned, but the way Rachel was acting also sent delicious excitement flooding through him. She was uncomfortable. Uncomfortable in that way that she got when she looked at her fanclub sites, or tried to talk about Xavier.

Josh didn't want to be a jerk, but he couldn't help it: he felt a snake of arousal inside of him.

Rachel twisted uncomfortably in her chair and leaned forward. As she did, her blouse hung low and gave Josh a nice view of the crescent of lace against her pale skin. He quickly drew his eyes up to her face. She was looking at the podium, anyway, and not him, so he stole another glance at the swells of her breasts.

“I am going to be auctioned,” she said.

It took a few moments for the words to assemble themselves in Josh's mind.

And then, he felt them boil underneath his skin.

Of course it became evident, very quickly, what it was that Rachel meant by this: the announcer explained it all into the microphone as Josh's mind went in downward-spiraling, dirtier and dirtier circles. KRTV's favorite people had contributed their skills or talents, or sometimes just the chance to meet them, for the auction.

It was all for charity.

It was all very clean fun. Cooking lessons from Eleanor Steele. Dancing with Bernard Michaels.

Josh felt excitement building up in his chest, until the pressure was almost intolerable.

I'm going to be auctioned. He knew his wife meant something quite different than what he couldn't stop himself from thinking about, but it didn't stop his mind from going to filthy places.

And what was his wife auctioning?

He knew what he *wanted* his wife to be auctioning. His mind was well ahead of his conscious thoughts, producing images of Rachel in her black lingerie on the stage, her hands on her hips provocatively, giving the audience a twirl and a wink. How delicious would it be to watch other men bid on his wife's body, hoping to “lick her ice cream” or get her to “pet their snake?”

Imaginary-auction Rachel continued to spin on the stage in his mind, losing scraps of her lingerie until only a thin rope of lace was slung over her hips.

Meanwhile, real Rachel was talking to him.

What was she saying?

He tried to force himself to listen to his actual wife, while in his mind the announcer auctioned his wife: “*I have one hundred for a blowjob from the lovely Rachel Elliot...do I hear two?*”

He snapped back to reality.

“...like a month ago, and this was all before all that stuff on the internet...” Real Rachel was looking around desperately. She was talking to Josh but she was distracted. She didn't care if he was listening, which was

good, because his attention was divided between what she was saying and his terrible fantasies.

She caught someone's eye in the audience, and raised her hand, then scurried over to him without saying anything to Josh.

Josh tried to bring himself back to reality.

But the auction in his mind was getting wilder and wilder: "*I hear one thousand for a piece of Rachel Elliot's ass...*"

He blinked.

What the fuck was wrong with him?

His cock was hard again, and so he would have to stay glued to the table. He knew he should have been listening to Rachel, and offered some support. He looked around the room, trying to find where she had disappeared to.

As he did, he noted that the eyes of many, many men were on her, and was it just him, or did they seem to be undressing her with their filthy looks?

Why did he like this *so much*?

Rachel was leaning over, standing next to a table. She was talking to Arthur. She had apparently realized that her shirt swung open when she leaned over, so she had crossed one arm over her chest as though she were itching her shoulder. No view of her tits, which was disappointing. But everyone could still see the length of her leg where her skirt had crawled up high on her thigh.

Josh felt a rush as he looked around the room, and thought about all the men who were imagining what Rachel's ass looked like without her skirt, as she bent over.

Arthur was shaking his head. He held his hands up, palms upward. There's nothing I can do, his expression said.

Josh was suddenly brought back down to earth as Rachel formed a thin line with her lips and looked up. Josh followed her gaze, and saw that she was looking to Xavier. Xavier shook his head.

Josh watched his wife, looking back and forth from her to Xavier.

There was *definitely* something going on between those two.

He felt another quake of pleasure below the table.

Definitely pleasure.

God, what the hell was wrong with him?

Now that he had some time to think about it, he couldn't help feeling like he had missed an opportunity last night. He wasn't entirely sure how the conversation had gone wrong, or why. He wished he could go back in time and redirect what they had said to each other.

But what would he have said? What did a man say to his wife. Exactly, when he wanted her to have sex with another man?

His head was a mess. He took a sip of water and saw that his hand was shaking.

Rachel turned away from Arthur as he was talking, and her face was red with rage. She trounced back to the table and collapsed in her chair. Her chest rose and fell with her rapid breaths. She had pressed her lips together so tightly they almost seemed to disappear.

Josh reached out for her elbow.

She turned to him. "He won't listen to me," she spat.

Josh knew she meant Arthur.

"I just think it's a little inappropriate," she said, "if your employee is being objectified on blogs, to auction her off, even for charity." She bore into Josh with her eyes. "Don't you?"

He should be glad, shouldn't he, that his wife *didn't* enjoy being the object of every man's sexual objectification? He should be pleased that she didn't have a taste for flirting and inviting other men to fawn all over her.

Right?

He touched her elbow. "I agree with you. But you know what?" he said. "Just have fun with it."

What was he saying?

Rachel was staring at him in disbelief.

He felt like he was on thin ice. He began to walk over it quickly, a little out of control. "If there's nothing else to be done, you know...just own it. If you seem uncomfortable it will only make it worse. What are you...I mean what did you auction, exactly?"

Of course she wasn't going to say, "A night of wild sex," or "A pussy-eating contest," but it didn't stop Josh from secretly hoping she would. His breath was caught in his throat anyway, as if the possibility existed.

"Lunch," Rachel said. Her voice was flat. She was looking at him strangely, almost as if she were trying to dissect him.

Lunch.

Was it relief that was flooding over him? It certainly didn't feel like it. It *should* be. He should have been relieved, but instead he felt as though a door was slowly closing on his fantasy, leaving it in the dark.

"See?" he said. "Not so bad. So just...yeah, own it."

Rachel stared at him. It was much the same way she had looked at him the night before.

"Oh yeah?" she said. He couldn't tell if she was challenging him or implicitly thanking him for the advice. There was a hardness to her voice.

Did she smile?

She turned to the stage, and folded her arms over each other. He could tell by the way her foot was moving that she was thinking. Plotting something. Scheming. But what he didn't know is how she felt about it. Was she angry? Was she humored? It was impossible to tell.

And not knowing was acting on Josh like the high of a drug. He felt his head getting lighter and his southern head getting heavier, as blood rushed away from one and to the other.

Rachel stood up, and went to stand by the stage, a wry little smile on her lips.

She was looking at Josh, and her eyes seemed to have mischief in them.

Or did they?

He felt ill, suddenly. What had he set in motion?

"And now I think I speak for all of us," the announcer, who Josh vaguely remembered from a Christmas party as an anchor of some kind, "when I bring our next bid up to the stage. Rachel Elliot!" There was a ricochet of hoots around the room. "Rachel has kindly donated..." he frowned at the card as Rachel stepped up onto the small stage and walked closer to him. She was looking at Josh as she leaned in close to the mic and tossed her hair.

"Just lunch," she said sweetly, with a shrug. "A nice, long lunch at my favorite restaurant, and I'm paying."

Josh felt himself in a tailspin. There was nothing about *what* she said that was particularly...well, even interesting. It was the *way* she said it. A *nice. Long. Lunch.* Each one of those words slow and deliberate, dripping with a vague innuendo that, Josh could tell by the way the entire room crackled, no one had missed.

Llllooonnnngggg, she had said.

Even Dave, Dave the announcer, was thrown a little off his game. He stared for a moment at Rachel.

For Rachel Elliot was known to be cute. Rachel Elliot was the cute-hot girl of KRTV.

But *this* Rachel sounded...

Sexy. Fucking hot. Dirty-filthy sexy-hot. Like she was going to want a “lllloooooonnnngggg lunch” in every hole of her body.

Dave recovered. “I am...disappointed that I can't bid on this nice, long lunch with Rachel Elliot myself,” he stammered. He was trying to make a joke, but it came out awkward because his voice betrayed him: he really would like to bid on this nice, *long* lunch with Rachel Elliot.

“All right, I'm going to call on my auctioneer, James, to come up here and do this because I can see that this is going to be hot one.”

It was disgraceful. It really was. Rachel smiled for the audience, and gave a little twirl. She was being utterly unlike herself: purposefully flirtatious, purposefully sexy.

The audience loved it. People were shouting at the stage, clapping for her.

Obscene.

Hot as hell.

Josh stared, open-mouthed, unable to do much else, as the bids rose higher and higher and Rachel followed his advice to “have fun with it” in increasingly obscene bouts of giggling and expressions of fake shock, until finally the auction ended at five thousand and one dollars! To the gentleman in the leather jacket.

Josh felt his head move, and his mind slowly return to the room, from the strange heights it had been taken to as his wife pranced on stage and giggled and flirted and was auctioned off like a piece of meat. He looked for The Gentleman With The Leather Jacket.

How much “fun” was Rachel going to have now that the auction was over, after all?

His blood went cold as he saw Rachel bounce down the stage steps, smiling broadly and genuinely for her buyer. She embraced him. They hugged and he picked her up and gave her a little spin.

For a moment he couldn't comprehend the image he was seeing, until it all came into focus:

Xavier.

Xavier had purchased his wife.

And Rachel had forgotten all about the auction itself, and the game she had been playing with it. She was no longer looking at Josh, no longer putting on act. She was really, truly happy to have been purchased by Xavier.

Josh felt a little ill.

But isn't this what you wanted? he asked himself.

It was. It was, in one way, exactly what he wanted. Excitement coursed through him. There was no denying that he liked seeing Rachel spinning in Xavier's arms, and that in some corner of his mind he was imagining Xavier whispering in her ear: "We'll have more than just lunch, baby."

Sure, something was nagging at him, in the back of his mind. He had a vague idea he should be doing something else, something besides sitting there and watching this like a horny idiot. But he just sat there instead, enjoying what he had put into motion.

With no idea whether to be proud of himself or horrified that he was an idiot, he went to the bar as Dave ended the auction.

16: PROPOSAL

“So that was really nice of Xavier to bid on you,” Josh said. Even the words turned him on. Even as PG-rated as the whole event actually was, he was getting a thrill out of his own version of the auction, in his own mind. Replaying Rachel saying “llllooonnnngggg.”

“Wasn't it,” Rachel said dryly.

She was angry.

“You seemed to get into it. You weren't exactly being...shy.”

Rachel shot him an icy look.

“Something wrong?”

She flipped her hair as she turned to him. “No. Nothing,” she said, in that overly casual voice that meant everything was wrong.

Josh looked out the window. “Okay, just tell me.”

She was shaking her head. “I shouldn't have to,” she said.

Josh sighed.

“You should have bid on me,” she said suddenly. But almost as quickly as she said it, her anger disappeared. She held a hand to her mouth. “Oh well, whatever. Forget it, actually. Xavier saved the day.”

The words sliced through his chest.

Of course he should have bid on her. He was taken aback by the fact that the idea had not even occurred to him for a moment. Not until this moment.

It would have been the chivalrous thing to do.

It would have been a way to solve Rachel's problem, of being auctioned when she was so embarrassed about her internet fans, creatively.

He could always claim that the bidding had simply gone too high.

For it had, in the end. Much higher than he felt like going, or they could really afford to go.

But he had never even bid at the beginning.

Why was that?

Because the thrill of watching his wife get auctioned off had overpowered him. He had just sat there, enjoying the spectacle of it and the perverted fantasy in his own mind, because it made him so hot he was

acting like an idiot.

That was why.

“I thought maybe...” his voice trailed off.

Rachel shook her head. She didn't want to hear it.

They drove home in silence, and Josh had the sense that this was another moment of opportunity, and it was slipping through his fingers.

He just had no idea what to say. He couldn't even tell, as he occasionally glanced over at his wife, if Rachel was really mad or not. Her body was folded in indignation, but her eyes were distant, and her lips seemed to be relaxed and almost smiling.

What was she thinking about? Because it did not seem to be making her as angry as she wanted Josh to believe she was.

Rachel hustled to the bedroom as soon as they arrived, and not in a very sexy way. She kicked the door with her foot but it didn't close completely, which usually meant she wanted Josh to feel like she wanted him out of the room, but didn't really.

It *usually* meant that.

Josh followed her into the room.

She whirled around, throwing a shoe on the floor at the same time.

“So?”

Josh was genuinely confused. “So...?”

“So, now that you've had time to think of a good answer, do you want to tell me why you let your wife get auctioned off like that, right after I – she – told you that it was...” she stared up at the ceiling, searching for a word. Josh could tell she had worked herself up in the car.

He sighed and leaned on the doorknob.

He hadn't really thought of anything to say.

And what was she doing, being angry anyway? He knew it had filled her with a rush that Xavier had bought her lunch date.

He could see it on her face.

He might as well be honest.

“Okay. Okay. Look...I have to be...I'm going to just be honest with you, here. Okay? Don't flip out.”

Rachel folded her arms and raised her eyebrows.

It wasn't the greatest circumstances under which to have this conversation, but he realized that fate would eventually run out of opportunities to give to him to squander. “I didn't bid on you...because...”

Rachel was staring at him. He closed his eyes and pinched the bridge of his nose.

“Okay...don't freak -”

“I won't freak out,” Rachel snapped. “Now spit it out!”

Josh opened his eyes. She was very close to being unreasonable.

It was now or never.

“It sort of turned me on. Because it sort of turned me on.” He dropped his hand from his face.

The admission felt good, on the one hand. It relieved him a little to say it aloud. To face up this confrontation, or fear, or whatever it was.

Rachel's face had not changed at all. It was her newscaster mask. She applied it whenever she heard shocking things.

Josh hated this look. She looked, suddenly, like a Stepford wife turned to plastic. It was creepy as hell.

“Don't freak out,” he repeated.

“I'm not,” she said calmly.

A little *too* calmly.

“It turns you on, huh?” she said. Her voice was cloying. She spun and sat down on the bed. “What it is it that turns you on, Josh? Hmm?”

Although her voice was angry, and very definitively not “sexy,” Rachel's thoughts seemed miles away. Her eyes were fixed on something outside of the room, a thing only known to her, inside of her mind.

There was a silence as Josh stood, searching her eyes with his own, scanning her expression. And in the way that most of his insights occurred to him, like a gas leak that caught fire, he knew he had it:

Rachel wasn't angry. She wasn't remotely angry at the suggestion. Rachel, like him, was confused and enticed.

She wanted this as much as he did, which is to say – she wanted it and didn't want it. She desired it and she feared it.

“Admit that you're attracted to Xavier,” he said. The sentence burst from his mouth quite unexpectedly, but he wasn't sorry he had said it. In fact, he felt a surge of pleasure as he seemed to grab the out-of-control situation by the reins.

She turned to him, summoning what Josh could see was the indignant fury she “felt” she should have at such a statement. “What?!” she said. She stood up, and in her action Josh could see that he was right. He was dead-on right.

There was a certain wisdom that had come to him from his work at the CDC, and it was why he was given the assignments he was given: being right was not the endgame. Few people realized this. The CDC was always as right as it was scientifically possible to be, but it didn't matter if they could not convince people to behave the way they wanted them to behave.

He let his flush of self-righteousness die down. He had also had the insight, long ago in his marriage, that being right should not be the endgame.

It was the means to the endgame.

Now was not the time to gloat about being correct, or about having discovered Rachel's secret desire.

Now was the time to coax.

He took a deep breath.

“What if I said that I think you and I share a similar...desire?”

He watched her un-prickle. Ever so slightly. Her head leaned to one side. She was curious now. At least a little bit.

“What?!”

Her tone was sharp still, but it had a filed-down edge to it. She had seen the bait, and now he needed to make her take it.

After all, they did want the same thing, didn't they?

“Okay, not *exactly* the same desire. Mine is different, in a way.”

She was listening. Her shoulders were softening. She was thinking, but now she was thinking about how she could circle in on what she thought Josh was saying. Confess her own desire, without risking that it wasn't what he was talking about.

Someone had to jump.

Josh sighed. “I want to tell you about something I've been keeping a secret because I was worried about how you would react,” he said. He watched as she opened her eyes a little. She was curious, and she was hopeful.

This was the perfect time to add: “I'll share it with you, if you tell me what your secret is.”

He knew that later, when she thought about this conversation, she would get annoyed with herself for falling for Josh's typical tricks. Rachel always fell for this because she was, in her heart, a journalist and therefore a gossip. She had her own secrets, and she liked to share them. And she could not resist the temptation to get someone else's secret out of him.

Still, she wasn't stupid. She would divulge her secret and then realize he had used one of what she called his "dork bureaucratic public-policy diplomat tricks" on her.

He knew she would be mad at herself later. But it was worth it, if he could just get her to say...

"Okay fine. You know what? Fine. I'm attracted to Xavier. I am."

Her voice, far from being tentative, was confident and icy. As if she had wanted to make the admission for a long time.

He felt a rush crawl around inside of him.

"Okay," he breathed, and the excitement strangled his voice to a whisper. He barely dared to say what he realized he had wanted to say all along, ever since he had found out about Tyra and Xavier.

A proposal.

His voice was shaking as he said: "Then that could work out, because my secret is...I like the idea of you sleeping with another man."

Rachel's face went blank.

"I want to watch," he added quickly. "And I...like the idea of it being...Xavier."

He could see that while she may have suspected any number of things to come out of his mouth, this was not one of them.

"*What?*"

Josh paused. Had he gone too far? He couldn't read Rachel's voice. There was shock in her tone, but he had no way of knowing what she was shocked about. The suggestion that she sleep with another man? The fact that he was admitting his own fantasy to her? What about this conversation made her say "*what?*" the way she did?

Rachel folded her arms.

Josh decided to take the bull by the horns.

"Look...why do you say it like that? I'm trying to tell you about something that...you said you're attracted to him. You said they're swingers. I'm telling you...I have a thing. I'm just telling you because...I don't know. It could all maybe work out so everyone could get what they want. Or at least be okay with it."

Rachel was frozen. Her lips were pressed together.

"Why does that upset you?" Josh inquired.

She spun and sat on the bed.

Suddenly she shook her head. "I don't...I don't know. It just seems...not right."

Josh sat down next to her. She bristled slightly.

"I mean, what kind of man wants his wife to...you know?"

She seemed sad now.

Josh put his arms around her. "Look, Rachel, no, it isn't like that. I don't want to make you sad. Really. I don't even know where it comes from. I've had these thoughts for a while. I even...I even researched them. And now that there is this...obvious attraction...between you and Xavier, it seemed like a good time-

She wriggled out of his arms, sitting bolt upright. "What do you mean, 'this obvious attraction?'"

Josh cocked his head. "Come on, Rachel."

She stood up.

He reminded her. "You just admitted to it."

She shook her head.

"Why are you getting so upset, Rachel?"

She looked up at the ceiling. She was shaking her hands. "Aggh!" she yelled suddenly. "I don't know!"

Josh wasn't sure what was coming over his wife. She began to undress suddenly, and she threw her clothes in the corner. "I have to go take a shower!" she shouted at him, and she went out of the bedroom and down the hallway to the guest bathroom.

17: A LONG LUNCH

The week had gone by as though the auction day had never happened. At least between her and Josh, and her and Xavier.

Josh didn't mention the auction, or their conversation about her sleeping with another man, again. And neither did she, even though she wanted to.

She had stayed up that night, feigning a need to work. It surprised her that Josh didn't come to her to talk about what had just happened.

Xavier didn't say anything about the auction at all. Not on Monday, when they interviewed residents about snakes coming into their flooded basements by the river. Not on Wednesday, when they were sent to talk to people opposing a new park design in their neighborhood because it looked like a swastika on the blueprints (it didn't).

Everything was so normal it finally drove her crazy, and she asked Xavier to lunch on Saturday.

No, that wasn't quite accurate.

Josh had maybe forgotten all about it, or decided to ignore it.

Xavier had perhaps thought it wasn't going to happen.

But Rachel was unable to get it out of her mind all week.

It was hard to know how to bring it up with Josh. Over breakfast?

"Honey, about that swinging thing..."

She also managed to push that evening out of her own mind. She wasn't sure what to make of it. Josh's admission was not the one she had expected, and she didn't know how she felt about it. It was almost as if he were giving her permission to do what she wanted with Xavier. But something about it set her so ill-at-ease that she couldn't quite even summon it to her conscious thoughts. When it surfaced in her mind, she pushed it away for another day or time.

Why, after all, would he want to see her with another man? What did that mean about their marriage, about his feelings about her?

Rachel also didn't want to admit it, even to herself, but she was looking forward to walking the line between inappropriate and appropriate.

To being so close to something forbidden. Maybe that's why she didn't tell Josh about lunch right away.

She thought about what she would wear. She bought a new dress.

She didn't tell Josh about it.

She bought new underwear.

She had bought them at the same time as the dress. That was how she justified it to herself. She wasn't buying them for Xavier, or because she imagined Xavier seeing her in them.

It was all just a fantasy.

She had the feeling that she wading out into water. That maybe she had taken one tiny step too far. But she could still feel the ground underneath her. She hadn't really *done* anything.

Buying underwear, new underwear, was not the same as sleeping with someone.

Thinking about someone was not the same as fucking someone.

Making a reservation at a restaurant in a hotel was not quite over the line. It was a good restaurant, after all. People ate there all the time, even if they didn't stay at the hotel. Good restaurants were hard to come by in this hog-town.

She had dropped the date on Josh casually, at the last minute. She had chosen Sunday, to make it seem less auspicious. More friendly. Less “sexual” than a Saturday. “Oh yeah, I have that..lunch 'thing' with Xavier today.”

And Josh had responded casually. “Oh. Okay. I'll go to the gym or something.”

And then she had told Xavier to meet her there.

It might have been true that she spent a lot of time in the lobby bathroom, perfecting her makeup. That her stomach was twisting like she was going on a first date. That her mind had to be constantly reeled back from the thoughts of Xavier's body, what it must look like, what it would feel like if she pressed her palms against his solid chest.

But it was all still fantasy.

It might have been true that she arrived early and waited for him breathlessly.

“Nice place,” Xavier said, sitting down.

“It's the least I could do,” Rachel said nervously. Her voice felt as though something had grabbed it and squeezed it. The whole, elaborate tableau seemed ridiculous to her suddenly: her underwear, her dress, the hotel. She was playing with fire. She even looked a little desperate.

What was she doing?

“You're payin' though, right?” Xavier chuckled. “You know, you could have just as easily taken me to McDonald's, and I'd've been cool with that.” He shook out his white napkin and set it onto his lap.

Rachel felt the same release of tension that she so often felt with Xavier. He set her at ease so...effortlessly.

Then, he set his elbows on the table and pushed his right hand into his left. His eyes burned over his knuckles and Rachel had to look away.

“Funny thing, though,” Xavier said.

“What's that?” Rachel asked nervously, shaking her own napkin open and placing it on her lap. She kept her eyes on the window as though something outside fascinated her.

“Oh, just the auction.”

Rachel dared to look back at him, and immediately wished she hadn't. His eyes were right where she had left them, hovering over his closed fists and burning into her own. She felt something cool in her stomach and her breath was uneven.

“What about it?” she said, trying to sound casual. She almost knew what he would answer, and she didn't want to hear him say it, but she also did.

“Oh, it's just unusual that a man would let his wife get auctioned off like that. After she said she was uncomfortable with it. Almost like...” Xavier pressed his thumbnail to his lower lip, and gave a dramatic pause. Then he pointed his thumb toward her. “Like he wanted to auction you off, or something.”

Rachel felt her whole body fill with a sensation she had never felt before and had no idea how to name.

Arousal? It had the feel of it. Her ears were filled with a tinny ring, and she was sure she could feel the artery in her neck. She felt a stain of pink creeping up the side of her face.

She knew, of course, that Xavier was right.

What she didn't know is whether or not it bothered her that he knew. Did it bother her that he saw what her husband wanted, and that the two of

them were enjoying implicitly passing her between them, as a piece of meat to be used?

It should bother her. She wanted it to bother her.

But the feeling between her legs was not of being bothered.

She tucked a strand of hair behind her ear.

She had no idea what to say.

"I told you maybe you should just talk to the man. See what he says. Seems to me he may have a different reaction than you would expect."

Rachel looked down at her plate. Her voice was small when she said, "I already did. Well, kind of. I..."

Xavier leaned back in his chair and waited for her.

She turned back to him. "Um...so what, you think he...?"

Xavier smiled at her. "I think he gets off on the idea of you having an affair," he said plainly. "And I think *I* get off on the idea. And I think..." he leaned forward. "you do, too." He placed a hand on her chin. She was powerless to move.

"Am I right about that?" he said.

It was all true. He was right about all of it.

So what was the problem, then?

If everyone was okay with it, then what was stopping her?

"You're probably thinking, 'why would my husband want to see me with another man?'" Xavier dropped his hand. "You want me to tell you?"

Rachel had no idea what she wanted him to do. She had no idea what *she* wanted to do. Half of her wanted to run away.

"I'll tell you from my experience," Xavier said. His voice was smooth and almost soothing. "I like to see Tyra with other men. I like to watch."

Rachel scrunched up her nose. This was too much.

"You can't be serious."

Xavier tiskied, and held up a finger to wag. "Now, just hear me out."

Rachel pressed her lips together, but she was feeling altogether too weird about what he was saying to believe she would "hear him out" for real. This was too much. Too...unorthodoxed. Having an affair was one thing, but this was...too weird.

"I love Tyra. She's the only woman for me. But we've decided there's no denying that sexual attraction gets...well, a little dull after so many years. And that people start thinking about other partner – now, see, Rachel, you're

rolling your eyes, but you can't pretend like you're not attracted to me, can you?"

She rolled her eyes more. "I don't see what this has to do with -"

Xavier held up his finger. "It has to do with Josh like this: I like seeing Tyra with other men because she does it for me. She does it all with my permission. It's like...I don't know how to explain it, an extension of our marriage, not something *outside* of it."

Rachel's mouth was hanging open, and she couldn't will it close. Her cheeks burned. Her stomach twisted.

"Yeah, but that...that doesn't actually work," she finally said meekly.

Xavier unclasped his hands, shrugged, and then punched them back together again. "No? So if I say it works just fine, you aren't going to believe it?"

Rachel shook her head. "No, I just..." she looked back at Xavier. "You might say anything," she said, trying to lighten the mood, "because you're just trying to get in my pants."

Xavier paused, and rather than lightening the mood, his stare turned the air between them to crackling electricity.

"I am doing that," he admitted.

The sensation of seasick, heated lust was so strong in Rachel's chest that she couldn't take her next breath. What would it be like to give in, and just let a man like Xavier, who said things like this, have his way with her? He must be as direct, as dominating, as delicious *in* bed as his words were out of bed.

Josh had already admitted that he wanted this.

She wanted it.

Xavier wanted it.

Tyra didn't care.

Everyone was okay with this.

She felt like her thoughts had to make their way through mud.

She just didn't quite believe Josh was into this. How could he be?

Her heart was racing.

Surely there would be a price to pay for this.

"There's always a...price to pay," she said. Her voice was almost strangled.

"Maybe." Xavier was cool, collected. His confidence was permeating her exterior, convincing her to be confident that it would all work out.

He was seducing her.

“No, *always!*” she wanted to scream. There was always a price to pay, and she didn't want to be some dumb woman who let a man talk her into what she knew to be true.

But did she believe that?

Xavier pressed his lips together. Rachel watched the white stain of pressure dissipate into his dark coloring.

“Ball's in your court, Rachel Elliot.”

The waiter, who had only taken their drink order, returned to the table. He flinched as he perceived the quiet stare-down taking place between them. Evidently he had mistaken their silence for a good time to take their order, and now regretted it. He cleared his throat. “Can I...get you started with an appetizer?”

Xavier un-wove his fingers from each other and then wove them back together again, without breaking eye contact with Rachel. He raised his eyebrows.

Everybody wants this, Rachel thought.

“I think,” she said, and her voice seemed smaller than it had ever been. “We'll just have the drinks, after all.”

There. That was neutral.

She still had options.

She *could* leave the restaurant, walk into the adjacent hotel, get a room, and finally engage in her fantasy.

Or, she could still get out of here. Tell Xavier this was all a bad idea.

She felt hot on her neck, but didn't dare to move her hand and do anything about it.

The waiter came with the check and she set her credit card down robotically.

Xavier pressed his pointer fingers together and pointed them at her.

“*You,*” he said, his fingers wagging, “still owe me lunch.”

Rachel felt desire slither through her. It took control of her. She could feel it squeezing around her, taking over her body, pushing her mind away from her actions and her reservations. She loved the way Xavier moved his hands. She wanted to feel them on her own body.

“You did win an auction.”

“I did.”

He was smiling now. Ordinarily, she might have thought this was smug. Instead, it only burrowed further inside of her, making the skin on her cheeks and the back of her neck turn scarlet with excitement. “Well, we better make sure you get what you paid for,” she said. She felt unsteady, almost like she was drunk.

Xavier tapped on the bill, twice, and stood up. “Get that. I’ll go get the room.”

18: I DID IT

Josh busied himself for the first part of the day by tidying the house. There was almost no tidying to be done, because the two of them were rarely at home, and they had no kids or pets, and they did have a cleaning lady. He cleaned out the fridge, focusing on the potential pathogens in the rotting take-out containers and calculating the risk of consuming them.

This kept his mind occupied for about fifteen minutes.

After that, he sat on the couch and sank into a fathomless paranoia.

The conversation with Rachel after the auction had not gone as he had wanted it to.

Of course, he knew that his desire to have Rachel turn to him sweetly and say, "Anything for you, darling, I would love to suck Xavier's cock right in front of you if that's what you want," was...well, unrealistic.

Still, he had hoped for something different.

Then, she had announced that today was her lunch date with Xavier. She had locked herself in the master bedroom, and she exited an hour later, smelling faintly of a perfume she rarely wore. Josh had watched her from the dining room table, where he was pretending to be nonchalantly working. She was barely covered in a red dress. The fabric was expensive, and the deep hue, slightly brown, set off the dark chocolate of her eyes. The dress was conservative in shape, with no plunging neckline or backless drop-off, but it was short and tight-fitting. It was just a hair away from not being professional.

Josh looked at her legs as though seeing them for the first time. They were lean and muscled: she went to the gym every day, and he had failed to take note of how good she looked. Her feet were tucked into a pair of very sexy shoes, identical in color to the dress. The higher-than-usual heels made her calves taut and colt-like.

The dress seemed new. He couldn't recall having ever seen it before.

"New dress, huh?" he said, and his voice sounded accusatory, even though he didn't mean for it to.

Rachel had tossed her hair, and affixed an earring to her ear.

Then she had smiled.

"Maybe," she had said.

She had then retreated to the bedroom, and come back with her purse, claiming to be late. She had kissed him briefly, and scurried out the door.

It was this “maybe” that Josh found himself considering as he sat on the couch.

What had she meant by her tone?

Had he somehow pushed his wife over the edge? And if he had, had he meant to do that?

And why did she have a new dress, the very next day, if she hadn't been planning to wear it all along to her lunch with Xavier?

Perhaps she had not been as shocked when they talked about Xavier and Tyra, and Josh's desires, as she had pretended to be.

Maybe she had somehow planned for this all along.

And then, after stewing in his paranoid thoughts for a good half hour, he got up and went to his laptop.

He went to the fanclub website, where he read and re-read the comments and the posts, looked at the pictures and the video clips of his wife. He tortured himself with the website for a good while, and then he was back to thinking about Rachel right then. Rachel at lunch. Rachel at lunch with the man he wanted her to fuck.

He couldn't tell what was gripping him: jealousy or lust? Desire or anger? His torso felt like a cauldron of emotions, all of them biting viciously at each other.

His cock was hard, his stomach was cold with fear. He was sweating. He was compulsively looking at a fanpage for his wife, made by idiot adolescents, and getting off on their idiot adolescent, lewd comments.

He slammed the laptop shut again, and went to take a shower.

After he jerked off, thinking the entire time about Rachel sucking on Xavier's thumb while her body rocked beneath the thrusting mass of his body, he stood under the stream of water and closed his eyes.

He was ridiculous.

But it was nearly five pm before Rachel returned.

He heard the click of the downstairs door. Her footsteps up the stairwell. He stood up, in an effort to look like he had been doing what he had been doing – namely nothing – all afternoon. He turned on the TV, and started to walk toward the kitchen, hoping she would see him headed there

when she reached the top of the stairs. As though he were just getting a beer. Relaxing. Enjoying his afternoon.

She stopped at the top of the stairs. Josh kept walking, turning to look at her as if he had just noticed her, as if he hadn't spent the whole afternoon like a wild animal, with his ears attuned to every little noise in the building, hoping it was her.

Her voice was small but clear, like a fine crystal glass:

"I did it."

Josh stopped cold in his tracks.

The feeling that spread through him seemed to seep out of his limbs and into his core. It was a sensation he had never felt before. It was of some temperature that was either so hot it seemed cold, or the other way around. He felt weak and he felt strong.

He felt, maybe, turned inside-out.

His heart seemed to stop. It seemed to, but couldn't *actually* stop, could it?

I did it, Rachel's voice skittered around in his head, like a ghost, whispering and whispering.

He turned to face her. "Did what, Rachel?"

She set her coat down.

Was she shaking?

She peeled her purse from her shoulder. Tapped the chair-back with her fingers.

"It."

There wasn't any need for explanation, and they both knew it. They had been dancing around "it" when they talked about "it" all this time, but now the time for pretense was over. "It" was fucking Xavier. "It" was what Josh wanted, and what he knew his wife craved.

"It," though, was suddenly too large for the room.

"It" might be the beginning of the end of his marriage, he realized.

He started to feel the heat of anger rise up inside his chest.

He had wanted more control over it than this. She hadn't even seemed particularly convinced that this is what Josh wanted. How could she think the conversation they had was sufficient? Didn't they need to sign a paper, or do something to make it more official?

But right behind the wave of anger came the arousal. The arousal told Josh the truth about himself. He could deny it to himself all he wanted, for

whatever reason, but his cock – which was twitching to life – would not lie.

“Today? At lunch?”

His voice cracked. It was dry.

Rachel held her hands up and let them fall.

And as she did, Josh realized another very dark, very perverted pleasure he wanted:

He was getting off on Rachel feeling guilty.

“It just got...away from me.” Her face turned downward. “But...I thought it's what you wanted.”

Josh took a step forward.

It was tempting, wasn't it? To let her feel bad?

Josh pushed the idea out of his mind.

Actually, the idea left his mind as it got crowded out by all of his other thoughts.

He put his hand on her cheek.

After all, he had told her to do this.

After all, he had wanted her to do it.

There was an even scarier truth, he realized, as he touched her face and smelled the scent of a high-end hotel soap on her skin:

He was disappointed that she had showered.

He had wanted to smell another man on her skin. He had wanted to see her with him. He wasn't angry at her for what she did, he was disappointed that he hadn't seen it live.

“Tell me what you did, Rachel,” he heard himself say.

His own voice sounded strange to him. He wasn't admonishing her. He was hungry. He wanted her to submit to his desire now, maybe as a kind of penance, and give him every last detail of her experience with Xavier.

So he added, as he moved his hand to the back of her neck: “I want details.”

Her mouth fell open.

“I was supposed to watch you, Rachel. And you went ahead, which I can forgive you for.” He was listening to himself but he couldn't quite believe his own voice and his words. It was what he wanted, and what he wanted his wife to do, and it was making his cock hard as steel to say these things to her, but he just *didn't* talk to his wife like this.

He moved his mouth close to her ear, and he felt what was similar to a flinch travel through her. There was fear in Rachel's body now, and he

wasn't sure why, but it turned him on. "Tell me everything," he whispered.

"I...I...don't know what to..."

He pushed her onto the couch, and she looked surprised for a moment. But when he knelt on the floor next to her her expression changed to one of arousal. Still mingled with confusion, but arousal nonetheless.

He slid his hands underneath her skirt, one on each side of her leg. "Did Xavier slide his hands here?"

Rachel shook her head. "Not like that," she whispered.

He curled his fingers underneath her underwear. Now that he was close to her hemline and the sweet spot between her legs, he could smell her excitement. Beneath it was a musky layer, foreign to her. Even if she had tried to cover it up, Xavier was still inside of her.

He shuddered.

Her panties were wet. He could tell by the weight of them as he slid them from her legs. They were a deep, new crimson pair, and they looked expensive. As he slid them down her skin, the thought occurred to him that she seemed to have chosen them deliberately, before she left. As though she had known that Xavier would see them.

She had put them on in the morning, thinking ahead to what she would do. Had it turned her on? Had she searched through the drawer, looking for the pair that would look best on her?

Instead of the thought depressing him, it excited him.

He left the underwear around her ankles, admiring the sight of them twisted around her skin and her shoes. He pushed her legs apart, so she opened like a butterfly, her knees the outermost tips of the wings. "How did he touch you then?" Josh asked her. He pushed her skirt up, and she wiggled to help him move it out of his way.

Now she was exposed to him, and he looked at her perfect cunt. The downy landing strip of blonde hair could not hide that her pussy had already been attended to today: she was glistening with her own excitement, but the flesh of her cunt was distended. It bulged from between her lips.

Another man, Josh thought, had been in his wife's pussy.

But now he could smell only her, and beneath that scent the notes of soap. A shower; and attempt to cover up her sin. Had she used a condom, or let him fill her up with his seed?

He would hear it from her soon enough. The thought turned over and over inside of him, making him seasick.

He pulled the lips of her pussy open, and paused to look at the shape of her. He could almost see it as though it were there in front of him: Xavier's cock filling her, stretching out the very lips he was looking at, until they were strained to near-tearing.

He moved closer to her. "Tell me about his cock," he said.

"Josh..."

He was surprised at himself when he pinched the inside of her thigh, near her watering cunt, rather forcefully. "You said you would tell me everything," he growled. "And you've been a little naughty, Rachel."

He was almost nervous as the words left his mouth. He liked this game, to be sure, but how far would he take his trash-talking to her? How much would she put up with? They were far, far outside their boundaries now. He never spoke this way to her.

She gasped, and then she squirmed so that her pussy came closer to him. The evidence that his words and her own naughtiness turned her on was impossible to hide: her pussy welled up in the center of her hole with a sticky, fat drop of her juices.

"Okay," she said. Her voice was hoarse. "Okay. His cock was...big. Very big."

"Bigger than mine?"

She demurred, and he pinched her again.

"Yes."

"Longer?"

She nodded, and the image of Xavier's long cock took shape in Josh's mind. He would love to have seen it, of course, but something about the imagining was equally exciting to him.

"Now tell me what he did to you first," he said.

Josh moved in and licked her clit. It was already saturated with smear of her sweet juices. He wanted to dive into her, but he resisted. He would reward her for being good, for telling him the filthy details of her good-bad behavior. But not until then.

He slid a hand beneath her right buttock, to let her know he would lift her to his mouth if she told him more.

"Hmm? What did he do?" He breathed next to her wet cunt but did not touch his lips to her.

She shuddered and twisted in his hands. He let his eyes drop to watch her ankles shifting in the loose bondage of her red panties.

“Uh...he...we kissed, I think, and then he turned me around...and unzipped my dress. He pushed me against the wall.”

Josh gave her a lick, over the hardened center of her clit, as a reward for filling his head with the image of Xavier turning his wife abruptly to the wall and unzipping her dress. He imagined the flex of Xavier's cock as Josh's wife's skin tumbled from her dress, the red tearing open to reveal creamy ivory.

He waited for Rachel to keep talking before continuing the swirls of his tongue over the hard center of her pussy. He allowed himself to wonder if she tasted different while he waited.

“He slid the dress from my shoulders,” she panted, in an effort to restart his tongue. Josh hummed against her sensitive flower, and she moaned. He imagined Xavier's big hands, elegant and practiced, as they unwrapped the red shoulders of her dress and pushed her hands to her sides to slide the material from her, baring her skin.

“Where were you?”

“In a...in the hotel.”

He pressed his lips around the slender teardrop of her clit, and rubbed the taut center between them. Rachel's body convulsed, and then went limp as he released her. Her nectar was smeared on his lips, making them slick as he spoke. “And then?”

He breathed on her clit, promising her more, and she clutched at the couch, digging with her nails at the leather, to no avail.

“He slid his hand between my legs,” she panted.

“While you were facing away from him?”

“I...yes.”

He swept his tongue along the slick, wet interior of her outer labia. “And then?”

“He pushed me onto the bed, Josh, please...” she grasped his head and tried to pull him toward her, but he grasped her wrist and pulled her arm away. “No. Tell me what I want to know,” he said. He flicked his tongue at her clit. “I'll tell you what,” he said, thinking better of his idea suddenly.

Having a marvelous idea in fact.

“You keep talking, and give me all the details, and I'll keep going as long as you do. But if you stop,” he breathed against her wet skin, and drew his head to her inner thighs. “Then so will I.”

Then he pressed his mouth to her cunt, so that her clit was sucked into his mouth in a perfect fit, and he could stroke her hot, hardened center with his tongue. She rippled with the movement of his tongue, and he felt her abdomen tighten in pleasure.

He stopped moving his tongue, and she gasped, desperate for more.

“He pushed me onto the bed,” she said.

Josh licked her again, but with less energy. “That very boring,” he said.

She moaned, and tossed her head back. “He had his fingers inside of me,”

Josh gave her a little more pressure – but just a little. It was still too boring.

She whimpered, and tried to push herself into his mouth, but he resisted, and pressed her backward into the couch.

She looked down at him. His eyes could meet hers over her crumpled dress and the feathery hair of her mound.

“I...he had his fingers up against my...clit, from the inside.”

Josh rewarded her with a strong massage from his tongue. He felt the pleasure that it gave her, but he slowed as she lost herself in what he was doing. *Keep talking*, he willed her silently.

“Then he stroked me with one finger on the inside, and one on the outside.” Josh could hear her gathering momentum in her voice, in the same way her need was winding up inside her body. He vowed to only reward her for the dirtiest details. He slowed his tongue, and savored the taste of her.

“Oh don't...” she moaned. Then she began to talk quickly, bringing Josh up to a rhythmic, steady speed:

“He made me come, and I came so hard I didn't notice he had started to put more fingers inside of me, and stretch me open, and...and...Josh, don't stop, oh, god, I can't tell you the next part...okay, okay, then he pulled me by the hair and I turned around, and he pushed me down on my knees, and that's when I saw his cock for the first time. Then I...please don't stop...”

Josh stopped what he was doing. “Tell me about his cock.”

“Oh god. I already...okay, okay, his cock was big, I could barely get my hand around it.”

Josh pressed his tongue hard into her clit. His own cock was pulsing now with a depraved ache, thinking of her hand around his girth the way she had been around his own just nights before. He almost lost himself in

his own devouring of her pussy, but when he realized she wasn't talking he slowed to a stop.

“And then,” she picked up, telling her story as almost a form of proxy masturbation, which only intensified the thrill for him, “then I sucked his cock.”

Josh slowed again, to let her know this was not enough. Tell him more.

“I...did, I did what I did the other night, to you. But his cock was bigger, and it was harder to...harder to fit, I couldn't get the whole thing in at first-”

Josh pulled away. “Tell me how it felt. Did you like it? Tell me how you felt.”

Rachel shook her head, and so Josh smiled, and shrugged, and sat back on his heels.

“Okay,” she said. “I...I liked the feel of him in my mouth.”

She blushed.

Josh leaned in toward her, and began to give her butterfly kisses across her clit again.

“I almost choked. But I liked it. I wanted to know what it would feel like inside of me. I liked that he was enjoying himself. Then I...I did that for a while, and he pushed me all the way to the base of his cock, and held me there, and I couldn't breathe. And then he let me go, and then he...oh god...oh don't stop...he turned me around again and he pulled me apart and then he...then he put his cock inside of me...”

Josh slowed, letting her know he wanted more detail. He could also feel that she was very close coming.

“Oh god, Josh...” she whispered.

He remained where he was, still, waiting for the details he craved. In his mind, his wife was on her hands and knees, with Xavier's dark body behind her, his cock in his hand, ready to split her open and pound her full of his cum.

He could imagine it, but he wanted her to say it. He wanted her to tell the story. He wanted the details.

She relented. “He slid inside of me and...at first it...hurt. It was so big. I thought he might tear me, but I was so...wet, and so he just filled me up and...Josh don't stop, please.”

He could feel that her body was rigid, close to the peak that would send her spiraling into her climax. But he stopped, because she stopped talking. He imagined his wife's pussy, the one he now peppered with the lightest of touches from his tongue, wrapped around another man's cock.

“Keep talking,” he murmured into her folds. He slid a hand beneath her other buttock, though, and knew as he did that he would not stop until she screamed and twisted in his hands. There was no room for teasing now: he made deliberate, rhythmic slides from the top of her slippery knob to the bottom. The quiver of her fattened clit told him he had the precise place. Her legs began to shake.

“He pounded me until I came...oh god...and then he...didn't stop, he just kept going, and I...I...”

Her last words were an exhale, and she lifted her head and looked down at him. He met her eyes as she convulsed with her orgasm. He felt her body shudder, from her trapped feet to her head. Her juices gushed from inside of her and smeared across his entire face.

He began to rub his face against her, and she screeched wildly and twisted in his hands. It was too much for her, but he wanted to keep going, as Xavier had, until she...she...what?

As she began to almost sob, and dig her nails into his head through his hair, he felt his own painful erection again. It had been there along of course, but now it seemed like an anesthetic had worn off suddenly. He lifted his head and Rachel seemed relieved for the brief mercy. Her body was shaking.

He jerked her panties away from her feet, taking one shoe with them and tossing them aside. Then he lifted her legs and pushed them against the couch on either side of her head as he rose up and slid his own cock into her drenched pussy.

Could she even feel him inside of her, after all that? She gasped, and her legs bounced wildly in his hands as he pounded himself into her soggy hole. He wanted to hear her finish her sentence, and tell him what Xavier had done after she came, but he imagined it was something like this: fucking her with his huge cock until her pussy began to squeeze him.

Rachel did, in fact, build up to another orgasm. He could feel her clenching his cock, and he held out as long as could for her. He hoped, as he yelled and ground his pelvis against her spread and contorted legs, that she

came as well. He dumped his seed inside of her, looking down at his cock buried in her flesh.

But he imagined a different sight as he did: that of Xavier's cock, veined and dark, cum squirting from the sides of the tight seal of his wife's pussy.

They collapsed on the couch, and Josh pulled Rachel to him. It was evident that neither one of them knew what to say.

Rachel entwined her fingers with his. He knew he should say something to her, but he wasn't sure what.

"That was hot," he said, nothing else having occurred to him and the silence becoming too much to bear.

Rachel looked up at him. Her head was on his shoulder. Then she looked down at their hands.

"I feel sort of weird about it," she said softly.

He kissed her on the forehead. "Don't feel weird," he assured her. "It was...I wanted you to do it. Didn't you want to do it?"

She shrugged, but not as though she didn't have the answer to the question. She closed her fingers into a fist, taking his fingers with her. He squeezed her hand. "I mean...I feel funny saying this. I *did* want to do it..."

Her voice trailed off.

Josh kissed her again. "And didn't you enjoy it?"

She nodded.

"And wasn't this hot?"

She nodded again.

"So what's the problem?"

Rachel shrugged again. There was a long pause. "I don't know...I guess...it just seems like it's too good to be true, like, you can't do this kind of thing and not have any consequences. It seems...sort of fucked-up. And..."

He waited for her to finish her sentence, because he really had no idea what she was going to say.

The pause was long, pregnant, torturous.

While the clock ticked in the background, Josh felt his elation tick away with every second. It was an unexpected feeling. Here he was, getting what he wanted – exactly what he wanted. It was hot. He could feel his cock getting hard again. Part of him loved it, wanted more of it, was waiting

on pins and needles for Rachel to give in to his desires again. Part of him was plotting already, thinking of how he could get her to do it where he could see and smell her with Xavier.

But with every tick of the clock, it felt like chisel was plunging into his happiness, chipping it away.

What was it?

“...I don't want to mess up anything between us,” Rachel finally said.

Josh turned her face toward him. This was it. Surely this was the thing that worried him. He looked deep into her eyes. “That's my priority,” he said. “Always. Okay? I don't want anything to happen here that would make things bad between us. This is just about...experimenting. Okay? If you want to stop, you just tell me. If we feel like it's getting out of control, we just stop. Okay?”

He was surprised that, as he said these words, Rachel's expression changed to a more placid one. She seemed to be comforted by the words.

On the other hand, though he himself had said this with so much conviction in his voice, he didn't believe his own words very much. He realized this as he forced himself to smile and look reassuring to Rachel.

A pain – a deep, profound, pleasurable and horrible pain – twisted in his gut.

What was he doing?

Rachel looked at their hands. “It was pretty hot, wasn't it?”

Josh kissed her ear through her hair. “It was.”

That was true. It was.

“So you...I don't know...you'd be up for me doing it again?”

He felt as if a bottom dropped out of his body and his soul. Like he was falling. He wondered what was wrong with him, so suddenly, after he had dreamed so intensely of getting this very thing.

“Of course I wouldn't. Just...you have to tell me what happens.”

Rachel smiled.

Josh felt as if he were split into two people as he turned toward his wife. There was Josh The Animal, whose cock was getting hard. Josh The Animal, who was kissing his wife passionately on her mouth, speaking to her in low tones. This Josh moved his hands over her body, unzipped her wrinkled dress, slid it up and over her arms. Josh The Animal was hungry for more of his wife; this Josh was talking dirty to her, telling her what he wanted her to do the next time she “saw” Xavier, intimately. This Josh was

picturing her mouth on Xavier's cock, her every hole penetrated by Xavier's gigantic cock. This Josh was whispering to her, as he walked her back to the bedroom, that he wanted to see her with Xavier with his own two eyes some day. How hot would that be? So hot.

The other Josh, Rational Josh, had departed his body. Rational Josh screamed at him to stop with his mangled mouth, but there was no stopping Josh The Animal. The man he used to be could only whisper to him how this was all a very, very bad idea.

Josh The Animal, though, was already poised over the lithe body of his beautiful wife, his cock just inches from her abused and sloshing cunt.

There was no talking to or reasoning with that Josh.

19: AFTERMATH

He spent the entire morning in a daze. After making love tenderly, they had fallen asleep early in the evening. They had sweat against each other, writhing and passionate, until they could take no more. They woke up at three am, desperately hungry. They made sandwiches, and laughed at themselves.

If someone had asked Josh how he felt that morning, he would have said fine. Everything was fine.

When they woke up in the morning, they kissed, and he had felt as everything were coming together, lining up perfectly like the pieces of a puzzle. Sex with Rachel was incredible; she seemed content; he didn't feel jealousy or rage, but rather a sense of sharing.

He told himself all the way to the train that he was a lucky man, a man who was about to embark on new adventures with his wife.

Who knew where this could go?

If the two of them were making it work – Tyra and Xavier – then Josh and Rachel could do it as well.

But as the train swung along on the tracks and away from the city, his thoughts began to cloud over.

The more he imagined Rachel moaning and panting with Xavier's prick impaling her, the darker his thoughts became. Mistrust began to breed in his mind like a culture of bacteria on agar: spreading, growing, multiplying into something ugly and repulsive.

Rachel had such good rapport with Xavier. What if she started to trust him more than Josh? After all, Xavier had been the chivalrous one who pursued her, who saved her from the internet dragons and then provided “comfort” to her. Xavier had chosen her, and hunted her...whereas Josh had *shared* her. He had given her up to another man.

He felt the spasm of his own needs inside of him again.

He had shared his wife.

He had *shared* his wife. He had deliberately created a situation in which he had basically pushed his wife into the arms of another man. And he both loved and reviled thinking about it. He loved imagining this man degrading her and pummeling her. He loved imagining her screaming in

pleasure and writhing in exquisite agony beneath his body, too full of his cock to do anything but pant and tremble in pleasure.

But a new feeling had come with his pleasure: he also hated the thought of Rachel enjoying herself *too much*. It was something he hadn't given thought to when this was all just a fantasy. He didn't want her seeking comfort and intimacy with Xavier.

And yet isn't that precisely where this would go, if continued?

Josh wasn't entirely comfortable with himself, he realized. He wasn't entirely comfortable with how much he enjoyed, sexually, bestially, what his wife had done. It paired wrongly, like the wrong wine for a meal, with his love for his wife.

Didn't it?

There was the matter of what to do now. It was tearing him in two directions.

Did he really want to go down this path? Give permission to his wife to sleep with Xavier yet again? Were they going to become swingers, real swingers, and start exploring people outside of their own relationship?

Part of the idea enticed him.

Part of it made him a little ill.

His psyche began to split into two again. He felt the division in his body, almost as if it were real.

He tried to focus on work when he arrived. He was behind his deadlines.

All day long, no matter what he tried, his thoughts inevitably turned to his wife, to Xavier, to the torturous day he had spent waiting for her to come back from lunch. A certain kind of aroused jealousy had burned through him all day long, even before he knew that she would sleep with Xavier that very same day.

Rachel called in the afternoon to say she would be late getting home. Her voice was tender and she told him she loved him in her message. This was something she rarely said, and she claimed to say it only when she really meant it. She didn't want it to become a form of stale closure that meant nothing at all.

Josh's heart soared to new heights.

Then it plummeted to a new low.

After all, maybe she had lied.

He had no idea how a couple like Tyra and Xavier managed these feelings. He wasn't sure he was cut out for this.

Why was Rachel going to be late?

It wasn't long before he began to imagine scenarios. Began to imagine Rachel calling and leaving a message, while Xavier listened. Imagine her winking at Xavier while she said "I love you."

His cock ached, and his heart felt like swollen lead.

Did he love this or hate it?

20: THE VIDEO

He found a link to the video on Rachel's filthiest fanclub website.

The room was dark and the first part of the video was mostly sound. The camera had been placed near a bed, looking out at an angle over the expanse of white sheets on the bed. A patch of white-curtained window glowed too brightly in the center of the screen, so at first the two people who entered the room could only be heard. Their bodies were silhouettes, distortions of shadows, nothing more.

They didn't say much. It seemed to happen exactly as Rachel said. The red of her dress gave a vague outline of her body against the wall, Xavier's black skin against her.

They moaned. His arms moved and his hands were undoubtedly delving into the very private parts of his wife's body. But it couldn't be seen well, only hinted at.

Suddenly the two figures careened toward the bed. When the window was blocked by their bodies, the camera adjusted for indoor light, and they came into focus. White and black. Rachel's strapless red bra, clinging to her breasts for only a moment before Xavier's large hand grasped the material and tore it away.

Josh watched as his wife opened her mouth and gasped. He watched as Xavier held his own thick meat in his hand and guided it to her opening. Just as she had said. He watched the large, purple-brown slab, bumpy with veins, bow slightly as he pressed into her cunt. She was too tight, Josh realized with his own cum boiling at the base of his cock with the thought. Her pussy had been so tight against the huge cock of Xavier that at first he had been unable to get in.

And then a gasp. Rachel tossed her head backward and closed her eyes tightly as the enormous member slid inside of her, filling her up.

Josh watched as Xavier's body fell toward his wife. Closer, closer, until he was deep inside of her, all of his many inches buried inside her body. Rachel's face was at first twisted in pain, and then she squealed as he slowly drew back and then pushed forward.

He fucked her slowly at first. This was a detail Rachel had never gotten to: Josh and Rachel had come far too early for it to be revealed.

Slowly, slowly, Xavier moved his cock in and out of her pussy. Her squeals deepened to moans of pleasure. Xavier's cock was turning shiny and creamy with her gushing pussy juices.

And, Josh realized suddenly, it was right here for the whole internet to see.

But he couldn't tear his eyes from the scene. He couldn't break with the vision of Xavier's cock burying itself over and over again in his wife.

Xavier got her ready, slowly working to her a gushing mess, and then he began to fuck her.

Josh's eyes widened as he watched Rachel come after the first ten or so hard thrusts inside of her. She tossed her head back again and screamed. Blood rushed to her face and she bucked like a wild horse.

But Xavier did not stop there. He continued to pound into her. Maybe he even slammed harder into her. Now that she had come, the sound of her sloshing pussy could be heard over their voices. She was as soaked and sticky as she had ever been. She groaned and her head fell forward. Josh could see that she was balling the sheets up in her hands. She pushed back against him, stretching her arms straight – but more than anything it seemed to be in order to brace herself for the incredible pounding she was getting.

Xavier was slamming so hard into her that his balls were swinging around like great black lead balls, slapping against her cunt and her thighs. His thighs slapped against her ass, and her pussy squelched and slurped as he fucked her, manhandled her, tore her apart with his cock.

Rachel, apparently unable to take any more, fell to her chest. A moan came from her chest, and her head turned back and forth on the sheets. The moan continued, on and on – it could have been pain or pleasure. It sounded animal, submissive, resigned. She could do nothing else but lie there and be fucked now. Her skin was glistening with sweat, and so was Xavier's.

Still, over the moan, came the slap, slap, slap of his thighs against her ass. She had her butt turned up toward him, her arms pressed against the sheets on either side of her head. She was in a posture of ultimate submission, and she was sobbing incomprehensibly now.

“That's it,” Josh heard Xavier breathe, and since Josh had forgotten where he was, he did not jump at the sound from his speakers. “Come again for me.”

And his wife, Josh's wife, did just as he asked. Her moaning turned to wailing, and then to breathless screams. Josh could see the pleasure roll

over Xavier's body as her pussy tightened and she screamed into the sheets with her climax.

Then she collapsed again.

Xavier was still not done with her. He grasped her ass with his big hands, and as though she a mere doll, he jerked her toward him as he thrust and thrust deep into her.

Josh watched in horror as he finally leaned back and up, his eyes at the ceiling, and yelled.

He withdrew his cock before he came. He knelt over Rachel and his enormous member spurted rope after rope of cum onto her back. The spurts were full and long: cum fell in Rachel's hair, across her back, onto her turned face.

This might have been all there was to see, but it was not. The horror continued as Xavier, still spurting cum, moved up along the bed, pulling Rachel's body toward him at the same time that he climbed, moving her as though she weighed nothing. His hands went to her head, and he pulled her gently by her hair. Rachel's face lifted up, and her mouth was open. Xavier held his cock in his hand and the two moved closer together: Rachel's mouth, and Xavier's cock, still overflowing with little spurts of cum...

Then the screen went blank.

Josh stared for a moment. He felt severed from his body and the things that were happening to it: his hard cock, his tingling legs, his pounding heart.

His mind floated somewhere else. Some other strange realm.

He grasped the mouse and wriggled it, scrolling down, clicking maniacally.

Where was the rest of it? Surely there was more.

The screen suddenly transformed, subtly at first and then with such violence that Josh, the ever-lucid dreamer, became aware that he was in a nightmare of sorts. The screen began to display large, blinking fonts, all of them screaming that he could make this all go away if only he paid some outrageous sum of money. Then the request turned into a request for a pound of flesh, and then the squiggling words, which by now were swirling and yawning and yelling at him with creepy voices, were demanding that he cut off his cock if he wanted his marriage back.

Josh sat up straight in bed, covered in sweat. He looked down at his cock: evidently the final moments of his nightmare, as disturbing as they had been, had done little to convince his erection to go down. He was turned on, but his heart was racing, pumping gallons of adrenaline into his body. He looked at Rachel. She stirred and waved a hand in his direction. "You okay?" she murmured.

He patted her absentmindedly and threw the covers off. He walked to the guest bathroom, with its tiny, clawed bathtub and the shower curtain that stuck to him if he moved wrong. He took a cold shower and tried to think.

The first part of his dream had been so realistic that it stuck to him like a residue. It wouldn't leave his mind. He panted in the shower, but the adrenaline would not let him rest.

He got out, dried off, and went to the living room to check the internet. So realistic was the dream that he had to see with his own two eyes that her fanclub page had no link to anything like a video.

There were more comments, each lewder than the last, but the only new post was one he had already seen: a picture of Rachel and Xavier in the hotel lobby. Speculation. But no real video.

He wiped his face.

His breathing calmed.

He leaned back in his chair and folded his arms behind his head.

He had a feeling, a feeling he knew well, and that was that he had made a terrible mistake. There was no undoing it, no going back in time.

But he could not see going forward with things any further than they already had. As much as he wanted to see Rachel with Xavier, as much as his subconscious demanded it, he knew that it would be a mistake to keep going forward. It would only end badly.

But how to put the breaks on what he had set in motion? How could he get his wife to stop seeing Xavier, when he himself had pushed her into it?

He rubbed his eyes and fought with the reptilian force inside of him, the one he tried to submerge, but the one that was simultaneously thinking:

Or, how could he get everything he wanted?

How could he feed Animal Josh, and end the relationship?

It was an impossible matrix. He should put it out of his mind.

What was the best-case scenario? That's what he needed. It wouldn't be perfect, it wouldn't be everything he wanted, but that's how real-world problems were analyzed.

Think, Josh.

The idea came to him, the way ideas often did: suddenly, filling his mind, like the water of a tsunami. The water was not there, and then suddenly it was: the idea was not there, and then suddenly it was. All of it.

A way to get everything he wanted.

It was a terrible idea.

It was risky and irresponsible, audacious and crazy.

He shook his head and slammed the laptop down.

He was having crazy thoughts in the middle of the night.

He would never do such a thing.

He returned to his bed and lay face-up, looking at the ceiling, doing his best to count sheep.

His mind, though, had gone to other places. To Planning Stage.

He closed his eyes. This was all just fantasy. Fantasy in the middle of the night.

He would never actually *do* it.

21: RECKLESS

“*This*,” Xavier said, wiping his forehead with the back of his hand, “is a doozy.”

It was almost 100 degrees outside, in early May and the late evening, which was unusual. Rachel watched the sweat drip down Xavier's dark skin, rolling down his solid neck and beneath his shirt, to the hard muscles of his chest.

Which she had seen.

Which she had touched.

And which she really wouldn't mind touching again. She could feel the hot fingers of desire squeezing her between her legs and in her abdomen.

She knew she was outright staring at him, and she also knew he was aware of her stares. He grinned and offered her some of the ice-cold water he had in a Dixie cup. She took it, and took a sip.

“You're doin' it all wrong,” he said. He poured himself another cup and poured it down the back of his neck. Rachel watched with fascination, imagining the water and its path down his delicious body.

She shook her head. “I'm *not* doing that,” she said.

But even as she said it, it gave her pause. After all, she could use this cliched gesture as a segue for seducing Xavier. She could start now, and try to have things flow naturally to a hot sex scene in the office.

She felt herself shake from the inside out. He had really gotten under her skin. She felt herself craving him.

Worse yet, she found herself being more reckless than she had ever been in her life. When thoughts about whether this was really good for her marriage, whether Josh really meant what he said, or whether Tyra and Xavier's swinging relationship could really work surfaced in her mind, she swept them away like flies. Her mind went back, as though pulled by a magnet, to the feeling of Xavier's cock in her body.

Reckless.

Xavier shrugged. “We already got your bit,” he said, referring to her story tags and sound bites. Now they were waiting, out on the hot pavement, for some b-roll footage of the Cinco de Mayo “cruisers” who

were gathering steam. Xavier was waiting for good scene. He was certainly right: she *could* let him pour a cupful of the ice-cold water down her shirt. She could feel it snaking down her spine, between her buttocks, into her panties...

She shook her head again.

God, what was wrong with her?

Since they had slept together at the hotel, Xavier had not acted in any particular way toward her. He still flirted with her, he still made suggestions, but she was grateful that their professional relationship had not gotten weird. He still seemed like his old self.

More than a week had gone by, and Rachel was beginning to wonder if the whole thing was just intended to be a one-off. If Xavier and Tyra did this sort of thing, but then out of respect for their marriage, they didn't do it again.

And she wasn't sure if that was a bad thing. Maybe it was just best to let things end this way: indulge in one night of fantasy and then never revisit it again.

Xavier stood up and tossed his cup into the van. "Here we go," he said.

Several cars, overflowing with dark-haired, hollering teenagers and Mexican flags, were headed down the boulevard, honking and shouting. Xavier filmed them for several minutes, while Rachel tried not to look at the outline of his body: the river of cold water that had trickled down his back and dampened his shirt; the shape of his shoulder blades beneath it; the shape of his firm buttocks in his jeans.

Her heart was beating faster. She could feel it, and she tried to stomp down on it. Memories of his hot skin against her back haunted her. The feel of his thick cock inside of her, filling her completely, surfaced in her mind and made her quiver wetly between her legs.

She sighed and pushed her hair from her face.

She unbuttoned her blouse.

Her heart was beating faster.

Xavier clicked off the camera.

Rachel fanned herself, knowing full-well she was being a little clichéd. She knew her skin was sweaty; she knew Xavier would notice her extra unbuttoning. The odd thing was, she didn't care. She didn't want him to miss her signals.

Was it what she had agreed to with Josh? Not exactly. But she knew she could twist it so that it was. It was just a stepping-stone toward what he wanted: to watch her with Xavier.

If something were to happen tonight, late at night, say in the office, who was she to stop it? Wouldn't it add more realism to things when Rachel finally did find a way for Josh to be in the room, watching?

Anyway, she thought, tracing a finger shamelessly down her chest, she would tell Josh all about it.

That was the deal, right?

She smiled at Xavier. He smiled back. He moved his head in something like a nod.

The sexual tension between them was back, and Rachel loved the feel of it in the air.

"We better get back," Xavier said.

"We'll probably be the only ones there," Rachel murmured.

She tried to be sexy, but the hilarity of what she had just said, and the way she had said it, as if she were starring in some B-grade porno, made her erupt in laughter. She doubled over and shook her head.

"I'm sorry," she said. "I...I'm sorry, I couldn't help it."

But when she looked back up at Xavier, even though he was smiling in appreciation of her joke, the look in his eyes was still hungry. They *would* be the only ones on the eighth floor, at least. There were a lot of rooms that no one went to, a lot of places to hide.

This what she was thinking about as they packed up the van and returned to the station.

22: POORLY PLANNED

Josh could hardly believe himself. He could actually barely believe himself, and the plan he had set into motion, and the fact that he was actually out here, in his car, in the heat, executing his insane plan.

It wasn't even a particularly good plan. He hadn't done what he would normally do, and played through all of its possible outcomes, weighing each of them carefully and statistically against each other.

That, after all, was his job.

When he tried to see his way through the maze of potential recommendations to himself, however, as a way of containing his own infection, he got lost. His mind sunk into a fog of images and paranoid thoughts, and he ended up jerking off in the shower as opposed to finding a plausible, carefully thought-out way out of the situation he had created for himself.

So now, here he was, in the most preposterous of situations, baking – actually baking, if you asked him – in a car. Next to him was an expensive video camera, and in the pocket of his camera bag was Rachel's ID and fob for the station.

He was thirsty as hell. There was a Starbuck's about a block away, but he wasn't sure if he dared to go and get a water, which he wanted desperately, and lose sight of the parking lot where the KRTV vans went in and out.

They would be back soon. He thought. He hoped.

He...didn't know.

The whole plan was crap, he realized. Not just the dark, twisted part that would come after what he was doing right now. But this, what he was doing right now, was a terrible plan.

Still.

He swallowed. His throat was dry. His eyes were tired, because he had been staring at the parking lot for over an hour. Why, why hadn't he thought to bring water? It had to be a hundred degrees out here.

He looked at his hands. He was gripping the steering wheel so fiercely his knuckles were white.

Maybe they had gone somewhere else. Maybe they had just fucked in the van. Maybe that's what they did, all the time. Or maybe they had some

secret hotel, where they went after assignments, and they were there now, twisting and writhing in the sheets, sweating and panting like animals. Xavier's black skin was pressed against his wife, right now, while he waited by the station like a madman in the heat.

He released the steering wheel.

He felt dizzy.

He was dehydrated.

He was going to pass out.

He must have looked like a crazy man, and he knew it: covered in sweat, his shirt soaked through, his camera bag slung over his shoulder, walking backwards toward the Starbucks. Looking over his shoulder constantly, his hair plastered to his face, his features screwed up in paranoia and madness, as he bought a water.

He tried to calm himself as he walked back to the car.

And then there it was:

The van. Unmistakably painted with their logo, unmistakably a news van. And surely it was them.

He looked at the car. It was unlocked.

The gate was opening.

This was his chance.

This was stupid.

He was a crazy man.

But he was walking faster.

He was half-running, his eyes on the big gate as it started to close.

Was this really him? Hands straight at his sides, crouched slightly, running toward a closing gate, technically trespassing?

He looked back, briefly, at his own car.

Leaving his Volvo, with the windows down, on a night like Cinco de Mayo, on the corner of Bradley and 5th? Doors unlocked?

He darted into the parking lot with only two feet of the gap remaining, and he ducked behind a van to calm himself, in the odd event that KRTV employed an actual watchman.

This was insane. What if they did? What if the cops were coming for him *right now*?

But apparently, apparently, he was just this kind of man. He heard the van he had followed. He straightened up, put on the baseball cap that

seemed to be the uniform of choice for cameramen, and walked calmly through the parking lot, trying to “blend in.”

Not that he knew what that was. He supposed it simply meant to look confident.

His stomach twisted, but outwardly he was calm. He was impressed with his own calm, his own single-mindedness.

Especially given what a stupid, stupid idea this was.

It would never come together.

It would never work.

He looked at his reflection in the glass door as he swiped Rachel's keycard, which he had stolen this morning from her purse. His own face looked back at him, almost unrecognizable.

You're such an ass, he wanted to tell himself.

You're breaking into a building.

But Animal Josh was unfazed by all of this. Animal Josh swiped the keycard, Animal Josh walked calmly up the stairwells to level 8. Animal Josh sat down in the stairwell and waited patiently.

Nothing had really happened yet. There was that. His whole plan had yet to be set in motion. It might not even happen at all.

He looked at his watch. He would wait ten minutes.

Even if he got what he was after *right now*, he reasoned with himself, there was nothing to say he *had* to do the other thing.

This was a first phase.

He concentrated on that.

After this, he could always end his plan. Unlike the other chain of events he had set off, between Rachel and Xavier, he had control over the reactions in this one.

He looked at his watch, and waited.

23: OUT OF CONTROL

They didn't say much to each other in the van. Xavier, though, did not reach for the elevator button to his own floor, and that was when Rachel knew what was going to happen. She knew that he would follow her to the eighth floor, that they would look for an unoccupied room, that they would dangerously fuck somewhere.

Her breath was caught in her throat. She could feel herself getting wet. The ache of extreme arousal unfurled low in her belly, reaching its tendrils down to her pussy and making it throb.

She knew this was reckless, but she didn't care. She wanted to feel him inside of her again, stretching her open in every cliched, stereotyped-pornographic way he could think of. She wanted the meat of his huge cock pressing against her clit from the inside, making her orgasm seize her in a choke-hold, like it had their first night, like she had never felt before.

This is so wrong, her conscience tried to tell her.

But was it?

It was true, everyone knew, and everyone claimed to be okay with it.

But she herself felt like she was holding onto something slippery. She was not in control.

Worse yet, she liked it.

They exited the elevator, and she walked toward her office. Xavier was behind her. At first he was at a platonic distance. Then closer. Then his hands were on her hips, and she felt her skin prickle with goosebumps all the way from the dip between her buttocks to the nape of her neck. He was steering her now.

She placed her hands on his, inviting him. He pressed his body up against her back, and she could feel the shape of his muscles, the hardness of his body, and the bulge of his enormous cock. She melted backward, against him, and let him control her.

They walked a little further, but Xavier grabbed her suddenly and spun her around, pushing her against the wall. The cheap dividing wall shuddered and threatened to give, but he continued to press her against it. He didn't care. This passionate abandon was what she craved: a need to fuck, even if the wall was going to get knocked over.

He kissed her forcefully, pushing her hands up and over her head. With a subtle control, he pushed her slowly downward with his mouth, and she slid down the wall. She realized where he wanted her to go, and it was fine with her: she wanted him inside her mouth as much as he did.

He moved back a little and let her fall to her knees, but he kept her hands pressed to the wall. He switched his grip to hold her two wrists in one large hand, and he did it so easily that it sent a shudder through her.

She watched, because she knew he wanted her to watch, as he unthreaded his belt and unbuttoned his pants, and pulled down on the zipper of his pants. The bulge of his cock was visible through the black of his boxers, and Rachel felt the urge to reach into the fabric and take his cock out, feel it in her hand, enjoy the weight of it before she had the taste of it inside her. But Xavier, as though he could read her thoughts, pressed her hands more firmly against the wall and gripped them tightly.

He took his cock out himself, using his free hand to slide his pants over his round, tight ass, taking the boxers with him. As the silken material slid away from his cock, it sprang forward, pulsing and growing with each throb of excitement. She could smell the clean but distinctively musky scent of him, and it uncoiled another wave of excitement inside of her. Her pussy throbbed, and she could feel her panties soaking through, her wetness staining the sides of her thighs.

She tilted her head to look up at him, and when she met his steely gaze she almost turned to molten lava. He had his cock in his hand now, and he was stroking it languidly, his hips back just a little so that she could not have him, not just yet.

Gone were all of her thoughts about her husband, about whether this was wrong or right. Her head was filled with a single desire to *submit* to what he wanted. A craving for it. She was afraid of the size of his gigantic cock, but she wanted to feel it in her mouth, feel it pry her throat open, see if she could take the whole thing. There was very little limit, in fact, to what she wanted him to do to her, what she would let him do to her.

And she wasn't going to ponder why that was right now. She stashed it away for later thought, but let the feeling wash over her. She opened her mouth to invite him. She kept her eyes on his, something she had always found too submissive to tolerate before, with other lovers, even with Josh. She could do it for a moment but she had to look away.

With Xavier, however, she wanted to hold his gaze. She wanted him to bore into her with his eyes, and watch her submission as he stuffed her mouth full of his cock. She wanted him to use her as a plaything.

He moved his cock to her lips, and rubbed the wet tip of his glans on her lower lip. A streak of precum, hot and slimy, wet her mouth, and she slid her tongue along the line of it to taste it. It was bitter, but she found herself wanting more of it. Wanting to be subjected to its bitter taste.

She flicked her tongue out to get another droplet of his precum, but Xavier took control of her by slapping his cock against her tongue, flattening it against her lip. He squeezed her hands and she understood his command without a need for words: she opened her mouth wider and let him slap his heavy cock against her tongue for a few moments.

It was a form of humiliation, looking at him, meeting his eyes as he slapped her mouth with his big cock, but she could feel her pussy welling over with more sloppy, sticky juice than she had ever felt inside of her, before actually coming, in her life.

“Open,” he said, his voice changed to the cold and mechanical voice he had used in the hotel to command her and take control of her. Perhaps as her cameraman, they had a rapport between them, but it was gone when they had sex.

When they had sex, he was in control.

She opened her mouth, stretching it as wide as she could. Even though she strained her jaw to get it wide, she knew from the feel of his girth inside of her a week before, and from sizing up what was in front of her now, that his cock would have to push her open even further. Her jaw was going to ache as he stretched her open. Would he try to go all the way down? Her eyes watered at thought of it, and her pussy squelched out another wave of her own juices.

The tip of him fit neatly into her mouth, and she sucked in a gulp of air, preparing for the worst. Her eyes were still on his. His face now had a different expression: one of domination, total and absolute. There was no going back. She was helpless, against the wall, her hands suspended above her head, his cock in her mouth. She would simply have to take what he gave her.

And she loved it.

He pushed himself forward, slowly, giving her a chance to get used to the filling of her mouth. Her jaw began to open with the force of his meat –

was he really this big? The tip of his cock passed from the roof of her mouth to her soft palate, and she felt herself gag involuntarily. Her throat spasmed and her eyes watered, but the feeling passed and he proceeded.

He pushed on her hands, making her slide down the wall, and he used his other hand at the same time to tilt her forehead up. He angled her throat so that he could keep pushing himself inside of her, all the way in, all the way to her throat. She could scarcely believe it as his cock filled her up and cut off her breath. She could actually feel the hardness of his shaft pushing out, against her neck.

Slowly, slowly, he pushed in, but he was still far from going all the way.

He withdrew slowly, and she was beginning to feel the pain of lack of air by the time he pulled his cock from inside of her mouth. Viscous, heavy saliva dribbled down her chin, and she gasped for breath.

He went in again, this time not as slowly. The lubrication of her spit made it easier, and she felt his cock make her throat twist in a gag and then pass further, further, even deeper into her neck. He moved his hips a little, rubbing himself back and forth inside of her, and then slowly, torturously, withdrew. Again, she gasped, and again he went back inside of her. Even deeper.

It took several more turns before he at last crushed his pelvis against her face. She felt the soft sacs of his balls against her chin. He pressed himself against the wall, and she closed her eyes because she could no longer see him anyway. She was completely stuffed, almost all the way to her chest. Her lungs began to scream. Her jaw ached, and she twisted her hands in his palm.

Still, there was something about it that she loved. She felt herself go limp with resignation.

When she did, he pulled out of her mouth and let her breathe.

So that was it: she had to give in completely.

When he plunged into her throat again, she let him do it, and he began to thrust against her in short pumps, his cock still deeply embedded in her throat the entire time. She felt his free hand on her throat, feeling his own cock through her neck.

Then he pulled out, and let her catch her breath. He did not release her hands, and she sat there, kneeling and trapped, panting, spit running down her face. The thought that she was in the hallway of her work

occurred to her suddenly, and it lit a fire of fear and excitement inside of her. For some reason it intensified the excitement of it all.

She looked up at him, and he moved his cock over her lips with tenderness. Then she felt him lifting her by the arms. She rose, and let him press her against the wall, her hands still above her head. They ached now from their constant suspension; she could feel her fingers going numb.

Xavier stepped out of his pants, leaving them on the floor without a care. He dropped her arms, and pushed her backward down the hallway to her own office.

When they entered the room, he pushed papers from a small table and spun her around in one fluid motion. He bent her over the table, and pushed her skirt roughly up and over her waist. Then, thinking better of it, he unzipped it and jerked it down, letting it fall around her ankles. He pushed her blouse up, so that it went over her head and became tangled in her arms and hair, where he left it as a sort of half-bondage. He was pressed against her as he did this, and she could feel his cock between her legs, hard and heavy. Fat. God, she wanted him to fuck her hard with it.

He slid his hands under her bra as he moved back down her body, kneading her breasts and pinching her nipples until she let out a small gasp. His hands were hot and smooth, and they moved over her body until they reached her panties.

He worked his fingers under the material, and slid them over her ass, leaving them at the fold of her lower buttocks. He plunged a finger into her cunt, and made a pleased grunt when he found how wet she was. "You liked that, little girl?" he said.

But she knew he didn't want an answer: her overflowing pussy was answer enough.

She was aching to be filled up by him now, with an intensity she had never felt before.

He stroked her clit with his thumb. He pushed hard on it, and an electric jolt of pleasure went through her. But it was not the teasing, anticipating kind. Not like with Josh. No, this was animal. He was going to squeeze her clit from the inside and the outside, until she was shaking like she was being electrocuted. Like he had before.

She felt his finger move along the inside of her outer labia, and then draw some of her moisture up, up to her...

Was he really going to do that?

She tried to look over her shoulders, and her body stiffened in alarm. He pressed on the small of her back with one hand, and swirled her juices over her asshole with the other. “No, no, we won't do that just yet, calm down.”

She tried, tried to let her body release the way it had when he had gagged her on his cock, but she couldn't give in completely to the feeling of his finger teasing her ass. His cock was too big. Far too big to take in the ass, which she rarely did anyway...

But she had thought about it. She had masturbated thinking about it. She felt a quiver of excitement. Inside of her, a small part of her almost wanted to feel the blunt end of his cock pressed up against her asshole now. Almost wanted to feel the excruciating pain as he entered her for the first time, and then the filling, filling of her most intimate hole. The utter submission, until he exploded and she felt the hot wet cum inside of her.

She realized she was moaning, enjoying his fingers making circles around her ass. She lifted herself up to him, wanting more, and he complied. He dipped a finger into her cunt, and then drew it up to her ass. She winced as he pushed it inside of her, slowly, slowly until her ass opened up, and he could plunge inside of her.

He finger-fucked her for a moment, and she squealed and writhed on the table. The pain faded and all that was left was the aching fullness. He curled his finger downward, and she felt the pressure inside her cunt.

He placed his hands on either side of her buttocks, and slowly, painfully, pulled his finger from inside of her. The lubrication was gone for the final inch of him, and she screeched into her closed lips. He pulled her ass apart, displaying her to him. She felt her thighs straining against her underwear, her feet against the fabric of her dress. Everything was going to be stretched out, ruined by the time he was done with her.

She tried to kick a leg out of her dress, but he stopped her by pressing his cock against her pussy. He rubbed it up and down the length of her slit. His head was so large that it seemed to cover the whole thing. She remembered this feeling from their first time, in the hotel. Like there was no way she could fit him inside of her. He would push her clit inward, turn her inside out.

But she let herself relax against the table, because she knew now that it wasn't true.

He pulled on her buttocks until the flesh of her ass pulled her lips apart with it. He spread her open, and pressed his fat cock against her.

Then he was inside of her. "Ooooooh," she moaned, almost sobbing. Even as wet as she was, and as much as she wanted him, he was big and her body flailed in resistance to the intrusion. He pushed deeper, deeper, slowly filling her. Her insides twisted to accommodate him.

And then he began to fuck her.

He began slowly, and she felt her orgasm building already. His cock pressed hard against her clit from the inside, and she felt her orgasm building from deep inside of her, as she had the first time he fucked her. It was like nothing she had ever experienced before.

Her body now felt like it was outside of her own control. She could only feel his cock, deep inside of her, stretching open, rubbing her clit and sending her toward a breath-stealing, numbing, blinding orgasm.

She felt his hands on her ass, gripping it more fiercely, kneading her flesh as he pounded himself into her. She felt the wetness of her pussy overflowing, slick on her thighs. She felt his thumbs, first one, and then the other, as they curled inward and pressed against her puckered anus, then pushed into it. A sharp pain as a second finger clawed inside of her and he began to spread her open.

But she barely felt these things; it was all far above the pleasure that was crashing into her, radiating from her very center-most core.

She screamed as she came, but she could barely hear her own voice. Her ears were ringing. She felt his hand as he pulled one thumb from inside her ass and placed his palm over her mouth, lifting her up and trying to quiet her as he slammed even deeper inside of her.

She was already over the edge, and he kept going, rutting away deep inside of her harder and harder until at last he stiffened and plunged so deep she felt it against the wall of her cervix, and then she felt herself being filled with his hot liquid. He released her mouth, and she let herself fall to the desk. Her skin was sweaty, her hair stuck to her face. He thrust a few more times inside of her, groaning as he did.

As with the first time with Xavier, she found herself in awe of the extremity of the sex. Or maybe not so much that, but how much she liked it. Her pussy, she knew, would ache all the way home, for half a day. Maybe more. Her ass was throbbing. Her throat was raw.

She could not believe that she had given in to this kind of raw, animal lust.

Or that she liked it.

Reckless.

Xavier slowly withdrew from her. She felt cum gush from inside of her, down her thighs. She even liked *this* sensation.

She knew she should be feeling something else as she lowered herself to the floor and gathered her sopping panties and wrinkled skirt. A *pop!* Came from the hallway, and it should have made her jump: they were, after all, *in flagrante*. But she felt calm as she shimmied her skirt up and zipped it.

She pulled her hair back with a twist-tie she had spotted on the table in the last moments of her orgasm, and looked at Xavier. He was shaking his head. “You are one *piñata* full of surprises, Rachel Elliot.”

He leaned against the glass partition to look out into the hallway, and then pushed his lean body back in to inform her that no one was there.

“So,” she said. “See you...Monday, I guess?”

Xavier winked at her, and spun out of the room, wearing nothing but his shirt.

That was all there was to it, right? Rachel thought. Was she saying that to herself because it's what she wanted to believe, or because it was true?

It *felt* true.

She rearranged the papers on her desk.

Then she looked out at the blinking lights, the final traces of dusk bleeding into the sky.

This was irresponsible. She was being reckless with herself, reckless with Josh, reckless with Xavier. She knew that *had* to be true.

Now if only she could make herself *feel* it.

24: WAY OUT

Something he hadn't considered, Josh realized, was his way out.

It was both a small-scale and large-scale problem: he hadn't really figured out how to get out of the building. On a large-scale, he was starting to realize he had no exit plan for whatever it was he had started in his marriage.

He moved calmly, even though he was stunned. He touched the camera frequently, as he placed one foot in front of the other, descending the stairs to the ground level.

He almost didn't see the real world as he pushed through the stairwell door. His mind was too filled with, and simultaneously emptied by, what he had just seen.

His erection was so intense he could barely walk. He was replaying the visuals of Xavier's cock in his wife's throat, the great bulge of it visible in her neck. The sight of his thumbs pulled her apart by the asshole while he rammed his cock deep inside of her.

His ears were filled with the sound of her moans and screams, of pleasure and pain.

It was just all so...much more extreme than he had imagined.

He vaguely registered that the door began to buzz as he went through it in his trance. Maybe he had set some kind of alarm going. No one came running toward him as he crossed the empty lobby and pushed open the main doors, though.

The air had cooled. Only a faint, inky blue remained smeared across the Western sky. He touched his camera again.

The front of the building was still open. He walked into the street, without looking in either direction, and was grateful he wasn't plowed by a car.

Like a robot, he walked to his car and opened the unlocked door. He sat in the driver's seat staring at the windshield. Who knows how long?

He drove to The Flats, a deserted hazardous waste dump that had been turned into a park no one wanted to use. It was windswept and desertified. His was the only car there.

He turned on the camera and replayed his video. He let the pain of it, the entire thing, and the hard, exquisite eroticism of it, fill his cock and his

head. All over again, from start to finish, before he freed himself from his pants and jerked out a painful orgasm from his aching body.

What had he started?

He closed the camera.

What the fuck was he doing?

What was he going to do?

Before he had actually seen Rachel with Xavier, he had gone back and forth like a pendulum. Hating this, loving this, planning to stop it, planning to add more fuel to the fire. Before he saw them together, this had all been an abstraction. Something he thought he wanted because he could imagine it.

There had been no way, in his view, to put the brakes on it anyway. Rachel would feel too bad, after he pressured her into doing it.

Right? Isn't that what had happened?

But now, he couldn't imagine what the woman he had just seen would do.

He couldn't say what it was that was eating him. He was in a similar catch-22 he had been before he brought up the idea to her. Only now, he felt he couldn't talk to Rachel because...he feared she might not listen to him. She seemed like a different person than the woman he knew.

And is that what he really wanted? Obviously, he thought, looking at the napkin of his cum in the passenger seat, he was turned on by it still.

He just hadn't expected Rachel to be so...reckless.

The woman in the video was not his wife.

He felt a ripple of pleasure creep along his spine.

God, what was wrong with him?

He exhaled.

He turned on the car, suddenly aware of how ridiculous and creepy he must have seemed out here alone. A middle-aged man with porn on a recorder, jerking off in his car.

"Fuck," he breathed.

Then he looked at the camera. He twisted his wedding band.

He still had options, he reminded himself.

He still had a plan.

Now the only question, he thought, putting the car in reverse, was whether or not he was reckless enough to use it. When he had crouched in the stairwell with the door propped open and turned on the camera, it had

almost made him laugh out loud. His plan, based on a dream, was preposterous.

But now, seeing Rachel so transformed, so unlike herself, his plan seemed realistic after all.

If not realistic, at least no more crazy than all of this had turned out to be.

Find out what Josh has planned, and whether or not he goes through with it, in the sequel to Human Interest. I'll have it out soon! Meanwhile, find [more books from Arnica Butler](#) by following [this link](#) or turning the page.

Thank you for reading. I hope you enjoyed my story as much as I enjoyed writing it.

Please don't forget to leave a review...it's the best compliment I can receive, and it helps boost sales and get my stories out to the readers who want them, so I can keep writing more long works like these for you to enjoy!

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END

MORE FROM ARNICA BUTLER

*If you enjoyed **Human Interest**,
give my other novels a try!*

Ela's Performance

Peter's sweet-faced and fiery wife is headed back to school for a degree in violin performance. Unexpectedly, Peter finds himself becoming very paranoid about who Ela is spending so much time with, and what she is doing at school so very late. It isn't as if he doesn't have his reasons for suspicion. There's the way his own relationship with Ela started, and their own past experiment with an open relationship before they were married. A few other strange things to fuel his jealous fantasies...

And when he discovers someone from Ela's past has resurfaced, he'll take a chance and confront his own desires and obsessions...but will he get what he really wants?

A Well-Laid Trap (2-Part Series)

It all begins when Patrick is convinced he saw his wife with another man at a downtown bar.

He begins to investigate. But the more Patrick uncovers about Jordan's activities, the less he understands.

The biggest problem is, Patrick can't decide how he really feels. On the one hand, his wife seems to be betraying him, and on the other, his sex life has reached a scorching pinnacle he never thought possible.

But he had better hold on to his hat, because when he finds out the truth, things will get much, much hotter than he might have ever imagined...

The Hobby Job

Former career professional Laura is going crazy living her stay-at-home-mom life in a small country town. Her husband Conrad has the perfect solution: get a “hobby job.” Laura gets turned on to the idea, and to Conrad's surprise, chooses to wait tables at a run-down restaurant down the street. But she gets a lot more than a hobby job when she meets Nate, a young, hot waiter who has his eyes on her from the start.

Conrad and Laura start on separate journeys, exploring new possibilities in their marriage, and opening up to their hidden desires, fantasies, and needs. Will their journeys merge, or will Laura's “hobby job” make a hobby of their marriage?

The Hotwife Tattoo

When Greg's brother marries his wild, tattooed, ex-girlfriend Renee, he knows things will be a little complicated. But when Renee befriends his wife Sara, she starts to change in almost unbelievable ways. Greg sees that there is something more to Renee's plans than just friendly sister-in-law bonding. Is Renee's influence all bad, or can Greg get something he has always wanted and never admitted to is wife – maybe even himself?

The Tenant: A Very Naughty Hotwife Novel

Once upon a time, his exotic and incredibly sexy wife Anna loved to indulge Brian's fantasies...to a point. She teased strangers, and took them to cruel, tantalizing places. But she never went all the way. The game ended when Brian and Anna got married, and that was that.

Or was it?

When the gorgeous, charming, and very black John moves into their basement rental, Brian finds that his sleeping desires have been building up all these years. He doesn't just want Anna to tease. He isn't just toying with the idea. He is obsessed with driving his wife to do things with another man. Lewd things. Obscene things.

When he confesses his desires, is Anna just a little bit too willing to make things just like old times? Is she too easy to push over each new line? Brian can't help but wonder if his own obsessions have gone too far...or if Anna's have.

A Gamble: The Making of A Hotwife

Ryan is just an average guy, coaxing his sweet, beautiful wife Victoria into playing into his hotwife fantasy – even if they're just pretending. But a trip to Vegas with his co-worker Brad and his sexy wife Irena turns Ryan's life upside-down. To help Ryan, Brad makes a proposal that could change everything...but it all centers on Victoria's innocence. How far will Victoria go to save what she holds most dear, now that her virtues, her love for Ryan, their marriage, Ryan's desires, and even their finances all hang in the balance? This is a 52,000-word novel about risk and romance, filled to the brim with the hard, steamy scenes you love. Please enjoy!

The Hotwife Summer

When Ben and Summer have the chance to spend the summer in Italy, their stale marriage starts to heat up in ways Ben could only have dreamed about. Summer is ready to take his hotwife fantasy all the way, and her choice is a sexy, Italian, Michelin star-studded chef. It's too late to put the brakes on what he's set in motion when Ben discovers the humiliating truth about Summer's choice of man. Summer has a taste for being naughty, and a filthy little plan of her own. Will it be everything he could wish for, or will Ben's cuckold fantasy turn into a nightmare he can't escape?

A Dark Place: Cuckolded In Lagos

Three people are carving out their fortunes in Africa's largest city, but each of them holds a deeper, darker desire. What is the secret desire of the angelic Charlotte, who finds all men's eyes on her after dark in Lagos? What about Andrew, who keeps a secret hunger so buried perhaps he doesn't admit it even to himself? And what could be darker than Clement

Ambode's already shadowy “*reliability*” as an all-purpose contractor in the underbelly of Lagos?

Charlotte, Andrew, and Clement will find themselves in a very dark place when their worlds collide in this ultra-sexy, novella-length cuckold story.

Not Black And White

When a photographer turns Rick on to the idea of watching his wife with another man, Rick feels an obsessive desire inside of himself catch fire. He can't help arrange for his shy, girl-next-door wife Danielle and the rugged, black photographer to cross paths. He knows that Drake Reyes' erotic photographs are not as abstract as they appear, and that Reyes sleeps with his married models. He knows his wife is not immune to Reyes' charms – no one is. He just can't help but imagine what it would be like to stand in his gallery, looking at Reyes' lurid photos, knowing his own wife is the model, knowing how the photos were taken.

But was it really his idea, or have Drake and Danielle been as manipulative as he has?

Please note, this is the novelized version of the short story Black and White, with significant changes to all scenes depicted in the short story, as well as the point of view. There is, however, some repetition: scenarios which occurred in the short occur in the novel. There are plenty of fresh new adult scenes, however. Please enjoy.

NOVELLAS BY ARNICA

Try To Have Some Fun

Poor Keith. He's been condemned to a campy cruise with his family and friends. Worse yet, he suspects something is going on between his wife and bad-boy Hank, the husband of a family friend his wife has invited along. Keith's in for a very big surprise – and much more naughty, adult fun than he expected on this cruise – when he finds out what's really going on.

Claire's Cowboy

When he gives his wife Claire the gift of a vacation of her choice, Chris is perplexed when she wants to go on a horseback-riding adventure in Montana. Nothing about that kind of trip has ever appealed to Claire. Next, she mentions a mysterious ex-lover, and she turns out to be nearly a professional at riding horses. Chris can't help but wonder if her choice of vacation, and the rugged man who will lead the tour, are just an uncanny coincidence...or if there is something more to Claire's cowboy?

[Nothing Better To Do](#)

Rob is finding out from the locals in his wife's small mountain hometown that his soccer-mom wife Kirsten may have been quite a different person once upon a time. He'll find out the truth first-hand when a late summer blizzard traps everyone at a party, and his wife comes up with some very indecent ideas for passing the time.

After all, there's nothing better to do...

If you're a new fan of Arnica Butler, why don't you try [Wives Gone Wild](#)?

I've put together ten of my short stories about wives on vacation, who get taken every way you can think of while their husbands watch. **Ten stories for \$4.99!** For fans of my longer hotwife novels, these stories may not be for you (but then again...they might). These are quick or medium-length, dirty stories about men taking willing wives right out from under their husbands' noses. Most include very graphic scenes of humiliation, menage, cleanup and...well, that's all I can write about here!

Stories included in this bundle are: *Double-Cucked; Cuckolded in Texas by The Oil Tycoon; Watching My Wife Get Trucked; St. Paddy's Day Cucktale; A Long Hard Winter; Watching My Wife Get Lumberjacked; My Wife Goes Back To Black; Cuckolded On A Plane!; Cuckolded In Vegas!; and Cuckolded on My Dominican Vacation.*

All stories are available for purchase individually for \$2.99 and some are in Kindle Unlimited for free, with the exception of Cuckolded In Texas, which is only available here. I want to give readers a chance to read some of my earlier works and quickies at a discounted price.

Because sometimes, you just want to get down and dirty, right?
Enjoy!